HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University

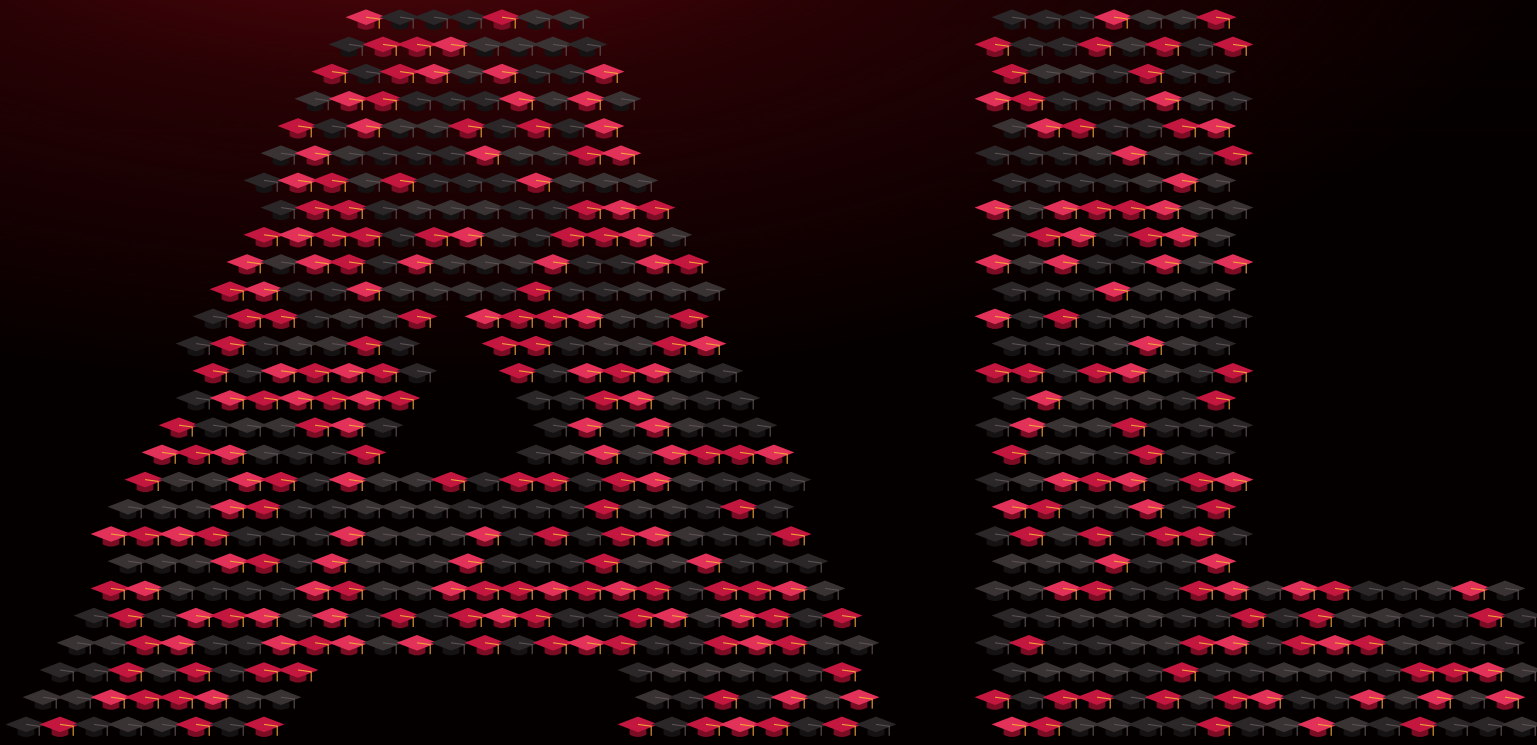
HAI Stanford University Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence

NOVEMBER 2026

The 2026 Alabama Talent Profile

Emerson Johnston
Amy Zegart

The bright caps, **43 in every 100**, mark the international share of Alabama's STEM master's degrees.



This page intentionally left blank.

HOOVER INSTITUTION | Stanford University

Stanford University
Human-Centered
Artificial Intelligence

The 2026 Alabama Talent Profile

By Emerson Johnston and Amy Zegart

NOVEMBER 2026

A publication jointly produced by the Hoover Institution and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence at Stanford University.

Table of Contents

OVERVIEW

At a Glance 6

SECTIONS

Section 1 International Dependence 8
Section 2 STEM Degrees 20
Section 3 Where Students Come From 26
Section 4 K-12 Preparation 34
Section 5 Graduate Research 36
Section 6 Do Graduates Stay? 38
Section 7 Research Funding 40
Section 8 H-1B Jobs and Green Cards 42
Section 9 STEM Workforce 46
Section 10 Patents 48
Section 11 Competitors 50
Section 12 Fields of Study 52
Section 13 Students and Money 62
Section 14 Student Outcomes 70
Section 15 Faculty 74
Section 16 Institutions 78

BACK MATTER

About these Data 82
By the Numbers 84
Sources 93

Authors

Emerson Victoria Johnston is a research assistant with the Hoover Institution's Technology Policy Accelerator. A Knight-Hennessy Scholar, she holds a master's in international policy from Stanford University, and is on leave from its master's program in the history of science, technology, environment, and medicine.

Dr. Amy Zegart is the Morris Arnold and Nona Jean Cox Senior Fellow at the Hoover Institution, director of Hoover's Technology Policy Accelerator, and a senior fellow and associate director at Stanford University's Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence.

Data come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), the Department of Homeland Security's SEVIS by the Numbers, the National Assessment of Educational Progress, NSF's Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates and Survey of Earned Doctorates, the Department of Labor's Office of Foreign Labor Certification, the USCIS H-1B Employer Data Hub, the Census Bureau's American Community Survey and USPTO patent data via PatentsView, processed in Python; every figure and table is generated from those sources, and each one names its source.

About This Profile

This profile is a companion to *The 2026 US Talent Report: Benchmarking America's STEM Pipeline Amid the Great Talent Competition*. It applies the report's measures to Alabama: the students the state develops at home, those it draws from abroad, and how both compare with the nation and with the states closest to it in size.

Degrees, enrollment, prices, outcomes and faculty come from IPEDS, the federal census of U.S. colleges and universities, harmonized across 1980–2025. Countries of citizenship come from SEVIS by the Numbers, the Department of Homeland Security's monthly count of active F-1 and M-1 students. Each figure names its source. Peer states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

How to Cite this Profile

Emerson V. Johnston and Amy Zegart, “The 2026 Alabama Talent Profile,” Technology Policy Accelerator, Hoover Institution, and the Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence, Stanford University, Stanford, CA, November 2026.

Public Data and Tools

The data behind every chart come from the Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS), published by the National Center for Education Statistics, and from SEVIS by the Numbers, published by the Department of Homeland Security's Student and Exchange Visitor Program. An interactive version of this profile accompanies the report.

To share any charts and figures, proper attribution is required. This profile is licensed under Attribution-NoDerivatives 4.0 International (CC BY-ND 4.0). Please cite as: The 2026 Alabama Talent Profile.

AT A GLANCE

What Alabama's numbers say

1. **International students earn 43% of Alabama's STEM master's degrees,** 9.6 points below the U.S. (52%) in 2025, ranking 26th of 51 on dependence. The share is 49% for STEM research doctorates (U.S. 43%) and 2.7% for STEM bachelor's (U.S. 6.6%).
2. **Alabama awarded 1.47K STEM master's degrees to international students in 2025,** 1.3% of the U.S. total and 20th of 51 among states. Since 2015 the count changed 3.5×, against 2.2× nationally.
3. **The heaviest dependence is in computer & info sciences,** where international students earned 82% of master's degrees (1.27K degrees; U.S. 65%). One STEM field with at least 50 master's graduates is majority-international.
4. **Among states of similar size,** Alabama ranks 4th of 5 on the international share of STEM master's: Alabama 43%, Tennessee 50%, Wisconsin 55%, Washington 39%, Kentucky 75%.
5. **68% of Alabama's first-time students in fall 2024 were state residents** and 1.2% came from abroad. More students arrived from other states (14.8K) than residents left (5.56K), a net gain of 9.19K; the top destination for those leaving was Mississippi.

43%

of the STEM master's degrees Alabama awards go to international students (U.S. 52%).

SCORECARD

Nine numbers against the nation

311K #24
Students enrolled, 2024
U.S. **19.7M** · +2.7% since 2015

1.47K #20
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · 3.50× since 2015

43% #26
International share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · +16.5 pp since 2015

10% #33
International share of grad students, 2024
U.S. **17%** · +3.3 pp since 2015

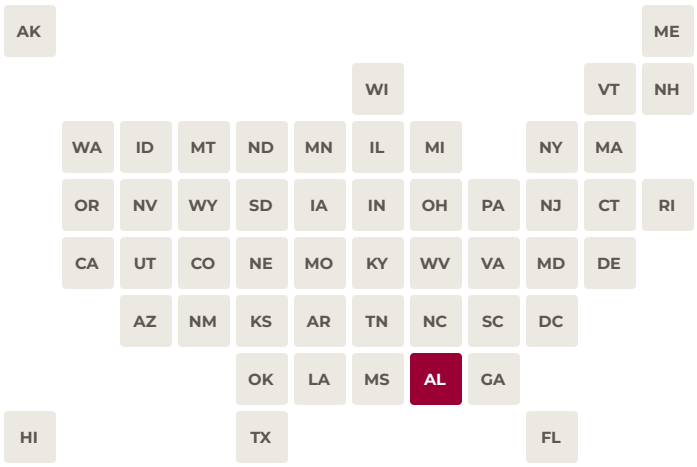
24% #23
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · +3.8 pp since 2015

60% #30
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · +11.4 pp since 2015

$11.4K #20
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · +25% since 2015

68% #32
First-time students from in state, 2024
U.S. **–** · −3.0 pp since 2016

$86.4K #37
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · −6.7% since 2016



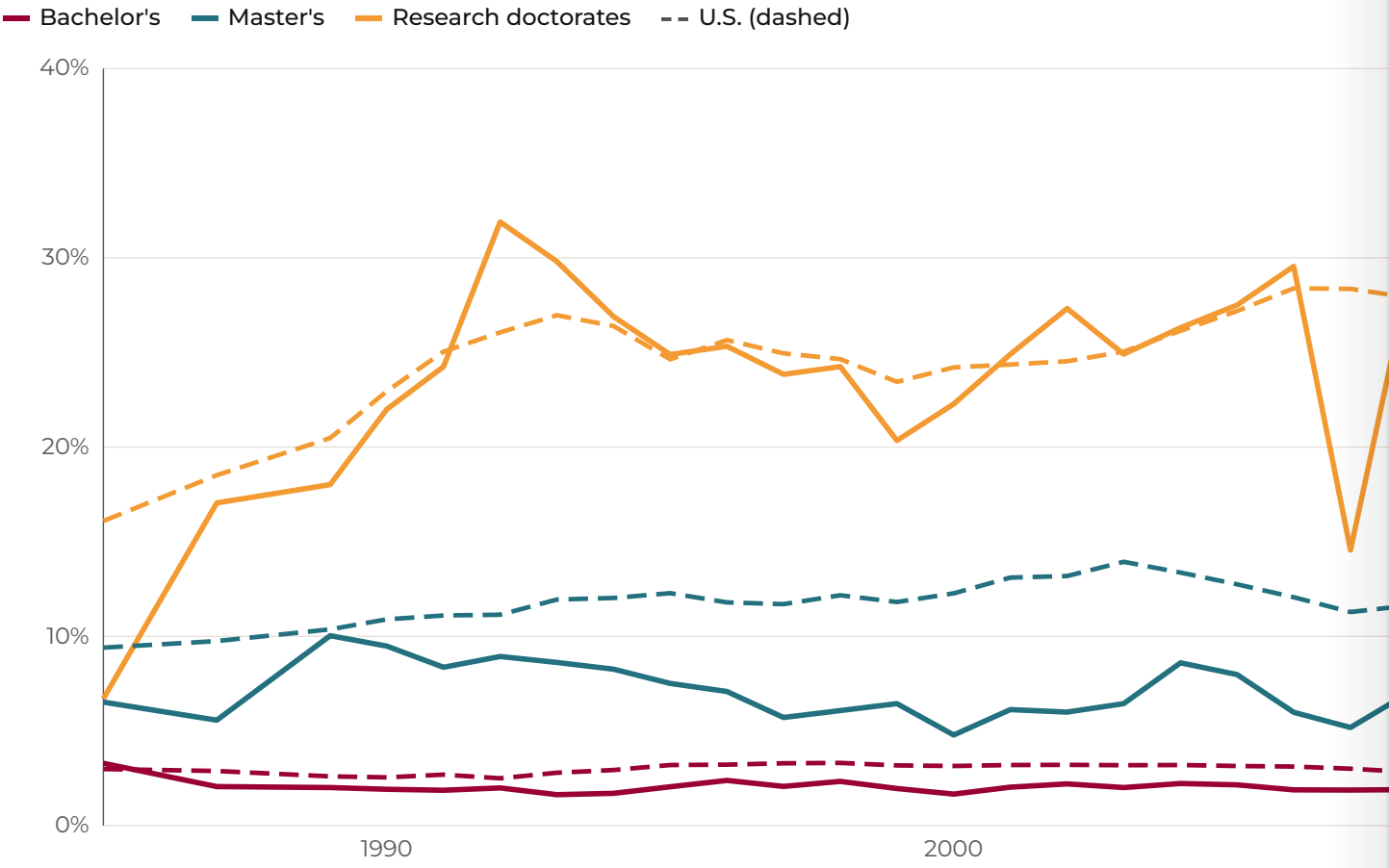
Badges give Alabama's rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Changes are since 2015.

SECTION 1

International Dependence

Alabama ranks 36th of 51 states on the international share of all master's, at 11% in 2025 against 22% for the U.S.

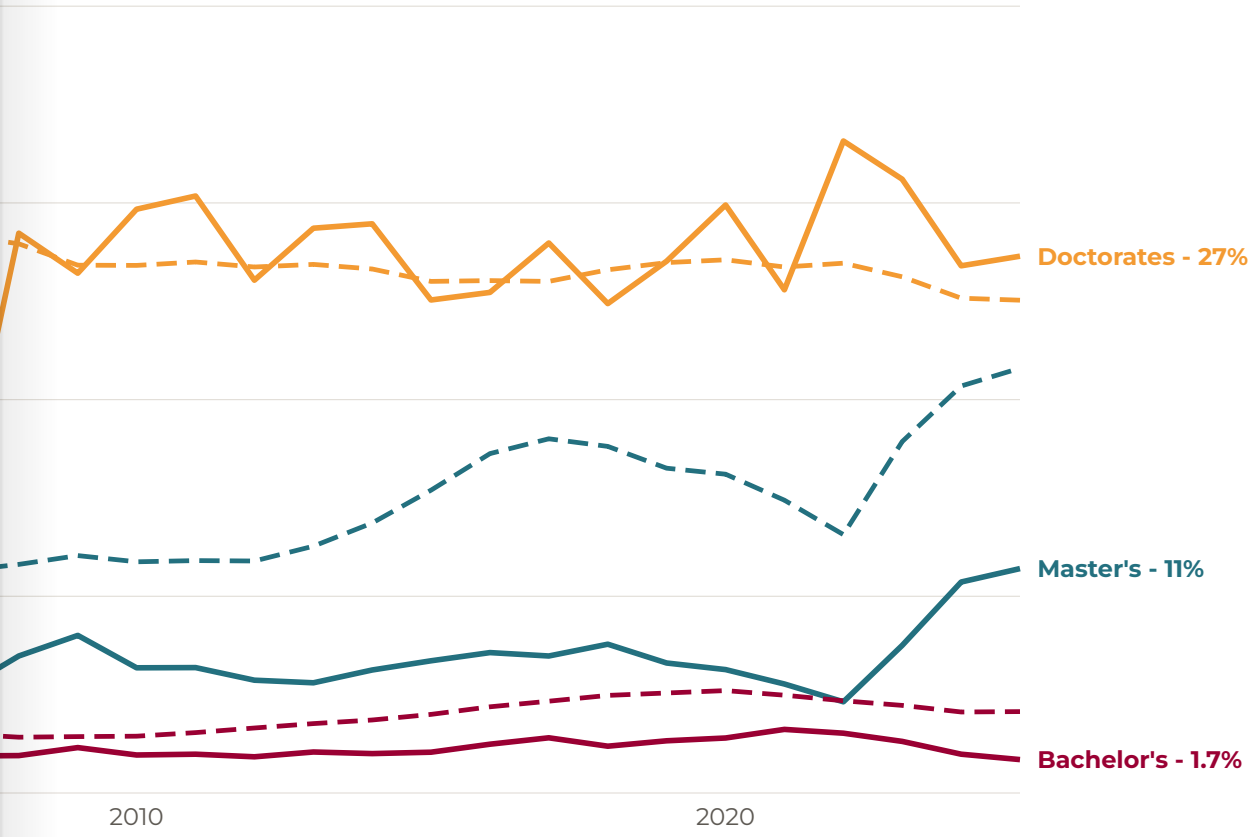
Figure 1 What Share of Alabama's Degrees Go to International Students?



International share of degrees awarded, all fields; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions, 1985–2025

International students make up 10% of Alabama's graduate enrollment and 1.5% of its undergraduates. Dependence climbs with each degree: 1.7% of bachelor's, 11% of master's and 27% of research doctorates go to international students.

In STEM the shares are higher still: 2.7% of STEM bachelor's, 43% of STEM master's and 49% of STEM doctorates. The state awards 1.3% of all U.S. international STEM master's, 20th of 51.



5.

10%

Int. share of grad students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **33rd** of 51 · +3.3 pp since 2015

11%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

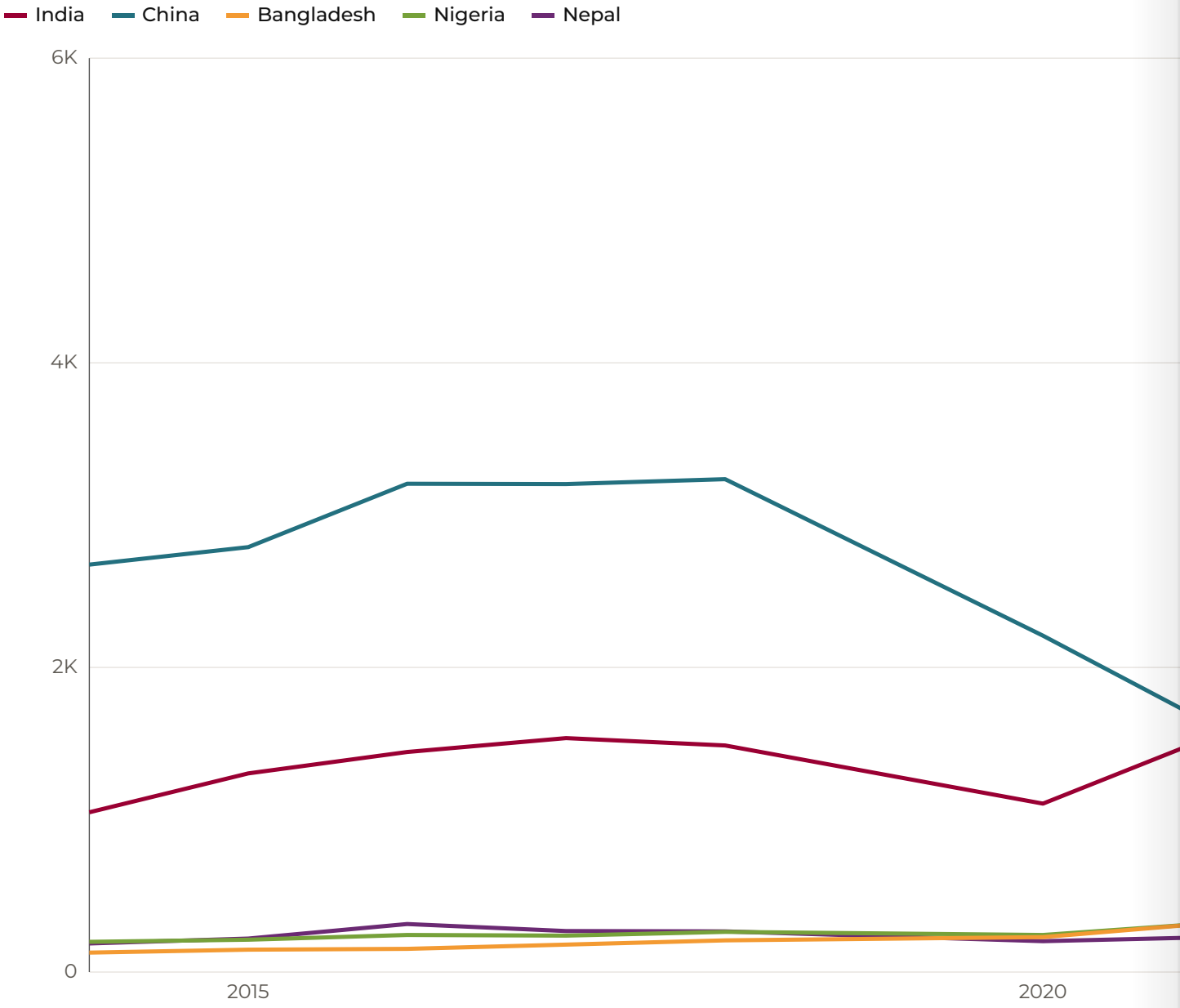
U.S. **22%** · **36th** of 51 · +4.7 pp since 2015

43%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **26th** of 51 · +16.5 pp since 2015

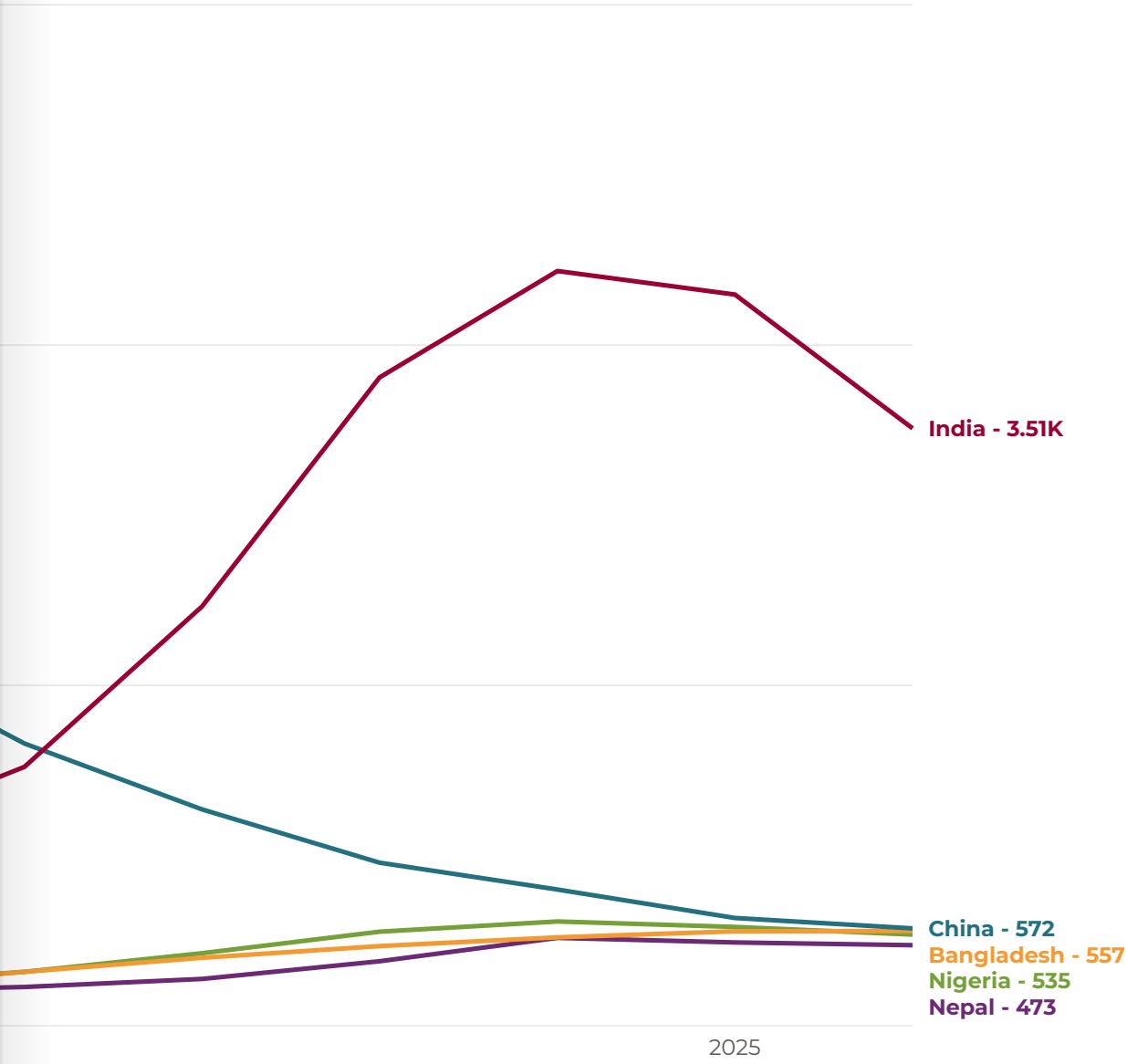
Figure 2 Where Do Alabama's International Students Come From?



Active F-1 and M-1 students by country of citizenship, the five largest in October 2026; one fall snapshot per year (the mor

In October 2026, Alabama had 10.2K active international students in SEVIS, 26th of 51. India accounted for 34% of them and China for 5.6%, against 27% and 18% nationally.

Students came from 158 countries, but the two largest supplied 40%. The state's total is up 30% since 2014.



nth closest to November), October 2014–October 2026. All education levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

10.2K

Active international students, October 2026

26th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

34%

From India

U.S. **27%**

62%

In STEM fields

U.S. **63%**

SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

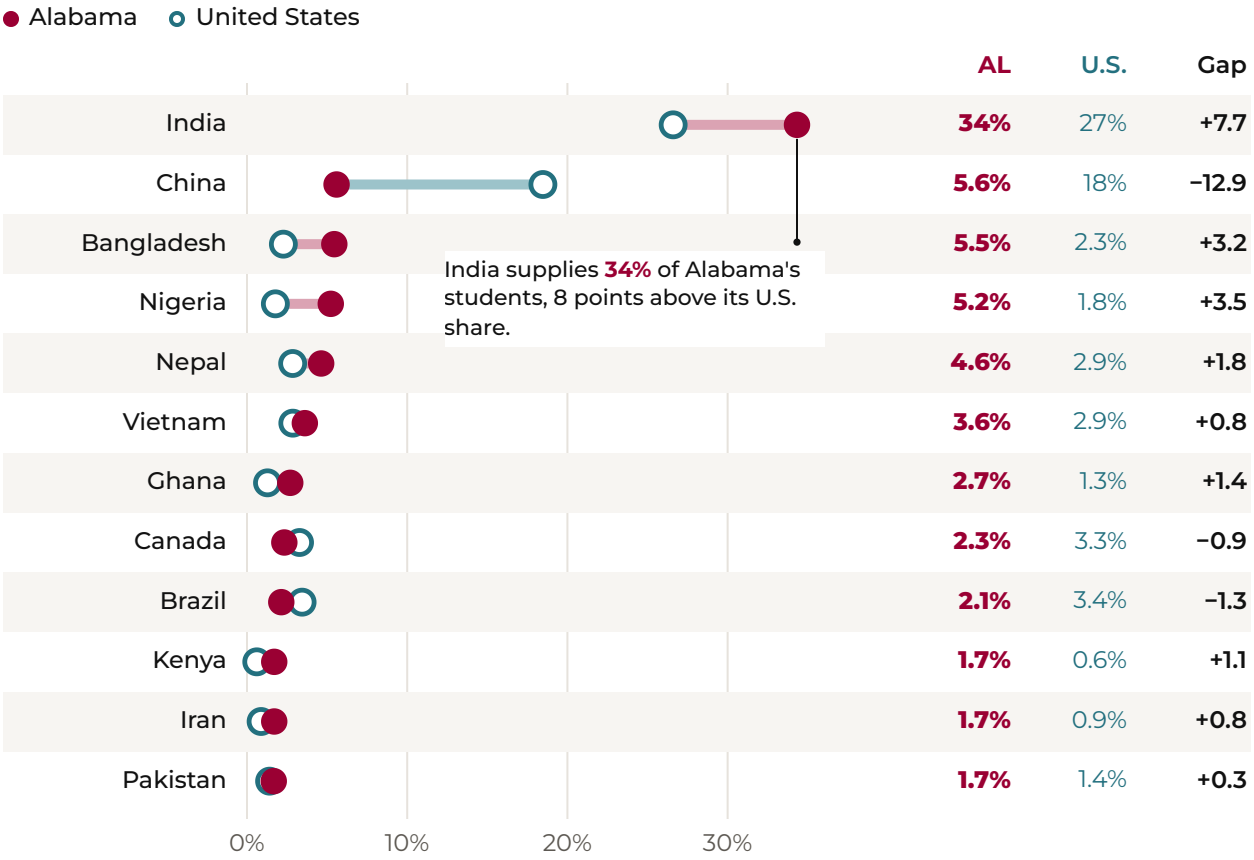
How Does Alabama's Mix of Countries Compare With the Nation's?

In October 2026, Alabama had **10.2K** active F-1 and M-1 students, 26th of 51 states and **0.9%** of the U.S. total. They came from 158 countries.

India supplied **34%** of them, against 27% nationally, and China **5.6%**, against 18%. Bangladesh (5.5%), Nigeria (5.2%), and Nepal (4.6%) followed.

Together the two largest countries supplied **40%** of the state's international students (U.S. 45%), 24th among the states, against 47% in 2015.

Figure 3 Is Alabama's Mix of Countries Like the Nation's?



	AL	U.S.	Gap
India	34%	27%	+7.7
China	5.6%	18%	−12.9
Bangladesh	5.5%	2.3%	+3.2
Nigeria	5.2%	1.8%	+3.5
Nepal	4.6%	2.9%	+1.8
Vietnam	3.6%	2.9%	+0.8
Ghana	2.7%	1.3%	+1.4
Canada	2.3%	3.3%	−0.9
Brazil	2.1%	3.4%	−1.3
Kenya	1.7%	0.6%	+1.1
Iran	1.7%	0.9%	+0.8
Pakistan	1.7%	1.4%	+0.3

Share of active F-1 and M-1 students, all levels. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October 2026.

10.2K
Active international students, October 2026
26th of 51 · U.S. **1.19M**

34%
From India
U.S. **27%**

5.6%
From China
U.S. **18%**

158
Countries represented
U.S. **219**

The state's count is down 8.0% from 2025 and up 19% since 2015, when it stood at 8.63K. Its share of all U.S. international students is up 0.1 points since 2015, to **0.9%**.

Since 2015, the number of students from India went from 1.3K to 3.51K, China's from 2.79K to 572, and Bangladesh's from 147 to 557.

Over the same years, the number from Nigeria went from 212 to 535 and Nepal's from 220 to 473. The table gives each country's count for the first, previous and latest years.

Table 1 International Students in Alabama, 2015–2026

	2015	2025	2026	Change since 2015	U.S. 2026	Rank
ALL INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS						
Active F-1 and M-1 students	8.63K	11.1K	**10.2K**	+19%	1.19M	26th
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.7%	0.9%	**0.9%**	+0.1 pp	–	26th
Countries of citizenship represented	163	161	**158**	−3.1%	219	33rd
Share from the two largest countries of origin	47%	44%	**40%**	−7.5 pp	45%	24th
LARGEST COUNTRIES OF CITIZENSHIP (STUDENTS)					**U.S. SHARE**	**STATE SHARE**
India	1.3K	4.3K	**3.51K**	+169%	27%	34%
China	2.79K	633	**572**	−79%	18%	5.6%
Bangladesh	147	555	**557**	+279%	2.3%	5.5%
Nigeria	212	580	**535**	+152%	1.8%	5.2%
Nepal	220	489	**473**	+115%	2.9%	4.6%

Active F-1 and M-1 students, one fall snapshot per year (the month closest to November; 2019 has none; the latest year is October 2026). Rank among the 50 states and DC. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers.

Figure 4

Which Countries Supply Alabama's International STEM Students?

6.3K of Alabama's international students were in STEM fields in October 2026, **62%** of the total against 63% nationally, up 61% since 2015.

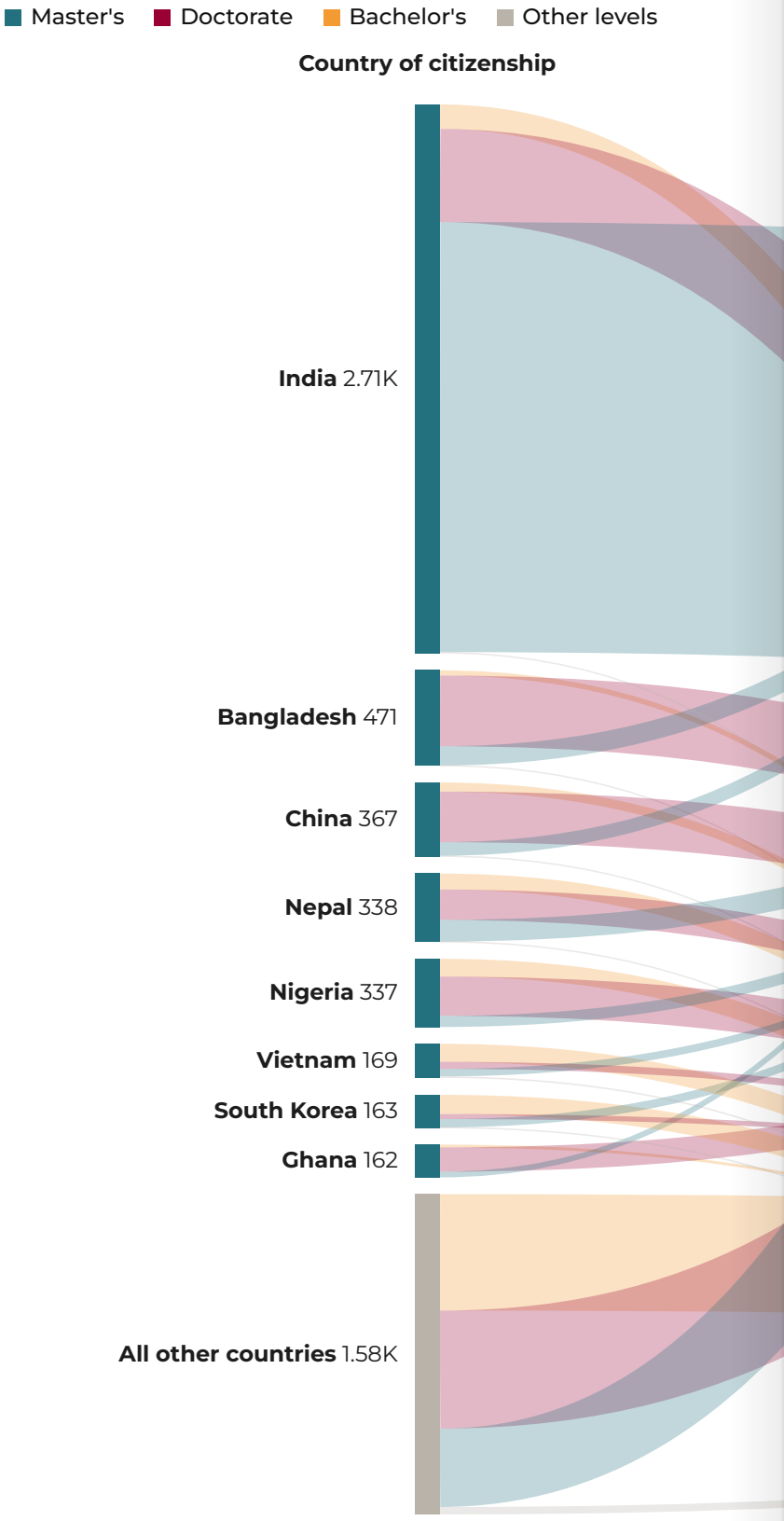
Master's students were the largest group, **2.94K**. India supplied 72% of them and Nepal 3.6%.

STEM doctoral students went from 1.15K in 2015 to **2.17K**, and STEM master's students from 1.42K to 2.94K.

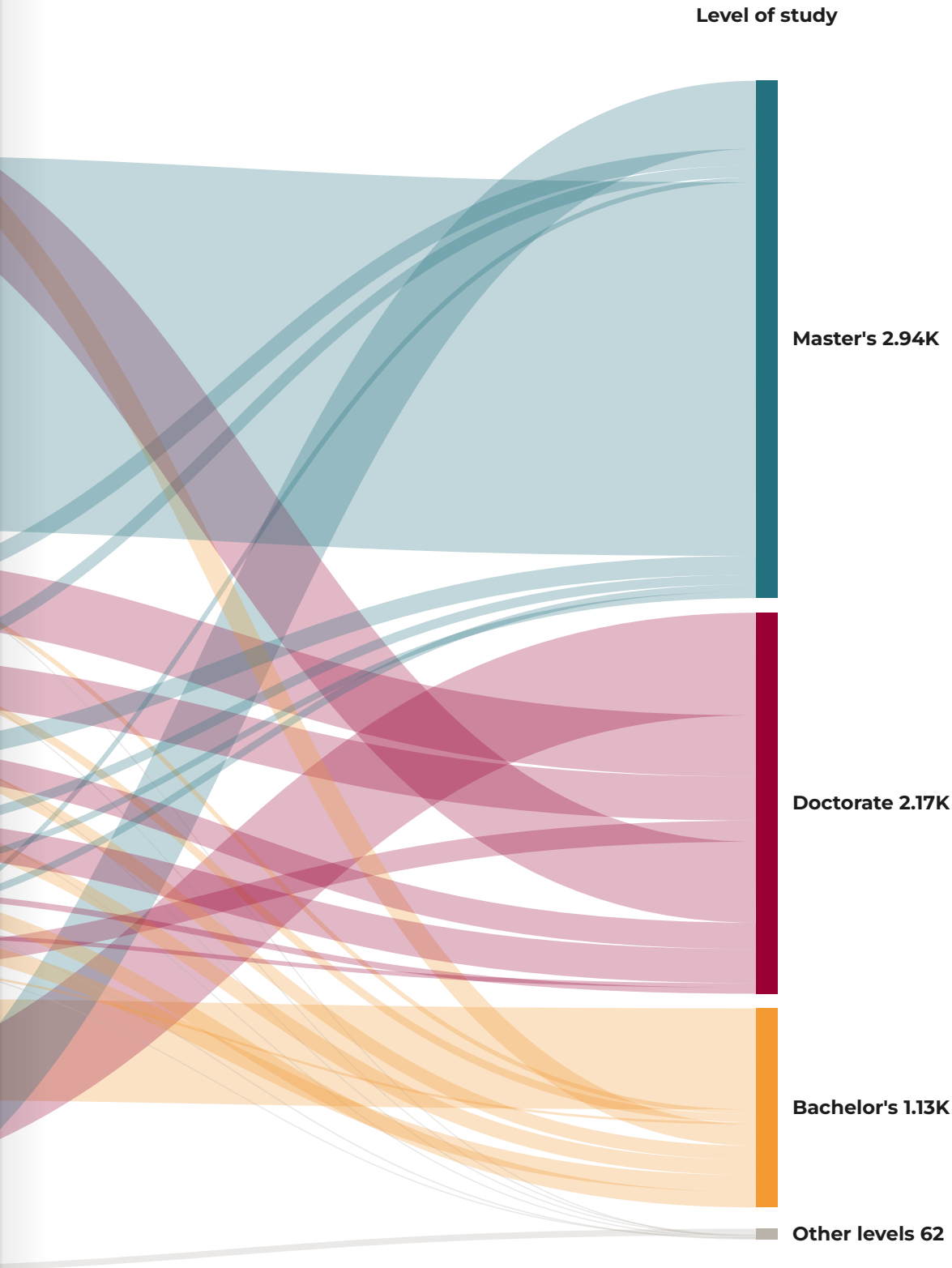
6.3K
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students, 2026
U.S. **749K** · **25th** of 51 · +61% since 2015

62%
Share in STEM fields
U.S. **63%**

2.94K
Active STEM master's students, 2026
U.S. **393K** · **25th** of 51 · 2.07× since 2015



Active F-1 and M-1 students in STEM fields by country of citizenship an
2026.



d level of study, October 2026; the eight largest countries are shown. Data from DHS, SEVIS by the Numbers, October

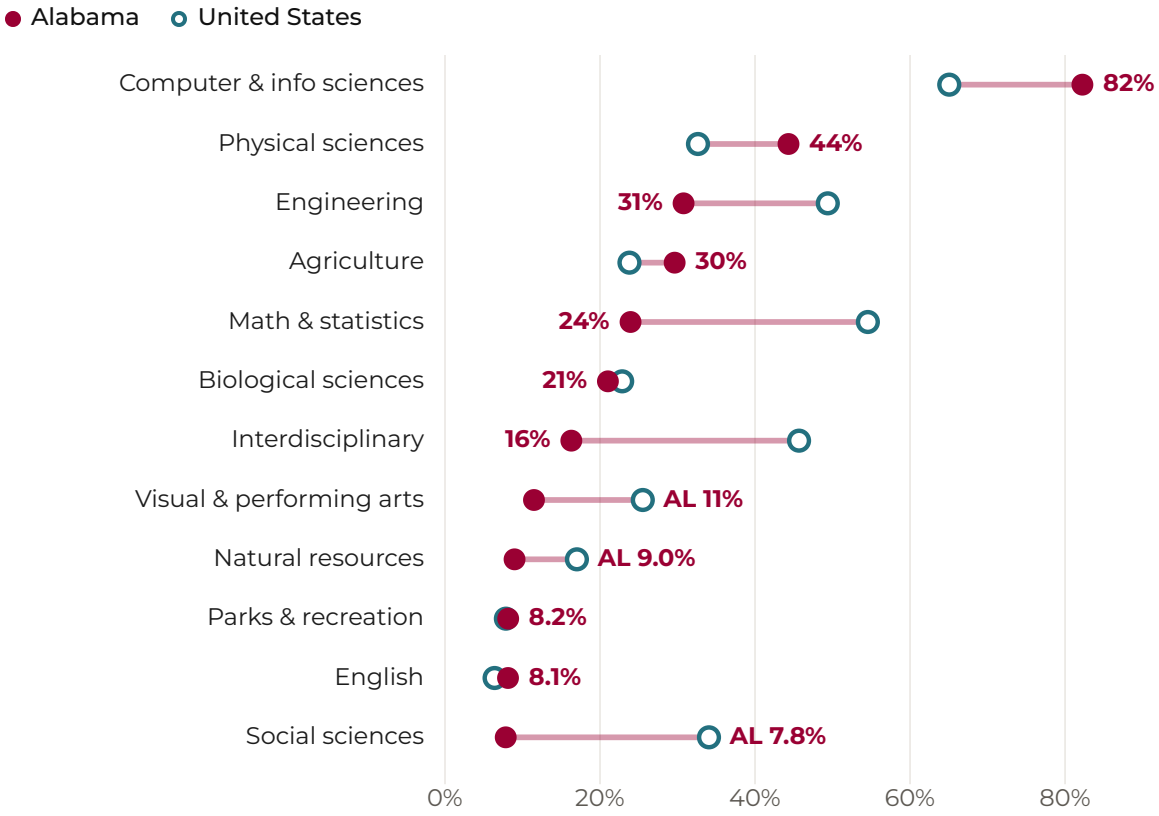
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How International Are Alabama's Master's Fields?

Each row is a master's field with at least 30 graduates in Alabama in 2025, ranked by the share of degrees earned by international students (U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas). The filled dot is the state's share; the open dot is the national share for the same field.

Highest international shares. International students earned the largest shares of master's degrees in computer & info sciences (82%, against 65% for the U.S.), physical sciences (44%, against 33% for the U.S.), and engineering (31%, against 49% for the U.S.).

Figure 5 Which Master's Fields Depend Most on International Students?



International share of master's degrees by field, 2025; fields with 30+ graduates. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

11%
Int. share of all master's, 2025
U.S. **22%** · **36th** of 51

43%
Int. share of STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **52%** · **26th** of 51

82%
Int. share of CS master's, 2025
U.S. **65%** · **9th** of 47

The table gives the international share of degrees in each STEM field at three levels: Alabama first, the United States after the slash. The master's column is highlighted. A dash means the state awarded no degrees in the field at that level.

Highest international share among STEM master's fields. International students earned 82% of the master's degrees in computer & info sciences, against 65% for the U.S.

Fields with an international majority. International students earned more than half of the master's degrees in one STEM field.

Table 2 How International Is Each STEM Field?

Field	Bachelor's	Master's	Doctorates
Computer & info sciences	6.4% / 8.6%	**82% / 65%**	– / 56%
Engineering	2.5% / 7.2%	**31% / 49%**	64% / 55%
Engineering technology	0.3% / 4.5%	**0.2% / 54%**	– / 42%
Math & statistics	3.7% / 17%	**24% / 55%**	50% / 53%
Physical sciences	2.1% / 6.0%	**44% / 33%**	40% / 38%
Biological sciences	1.6% / 3.4%	**21% / 23%**	35% / 23%
Natural resources	1.0% / 2.0%	**9.0% / 17%**	– / 27%
Architecture	7.8% / 7.3%	**12% / 29%**	– / 55%

International share in Alabama / U.S., 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

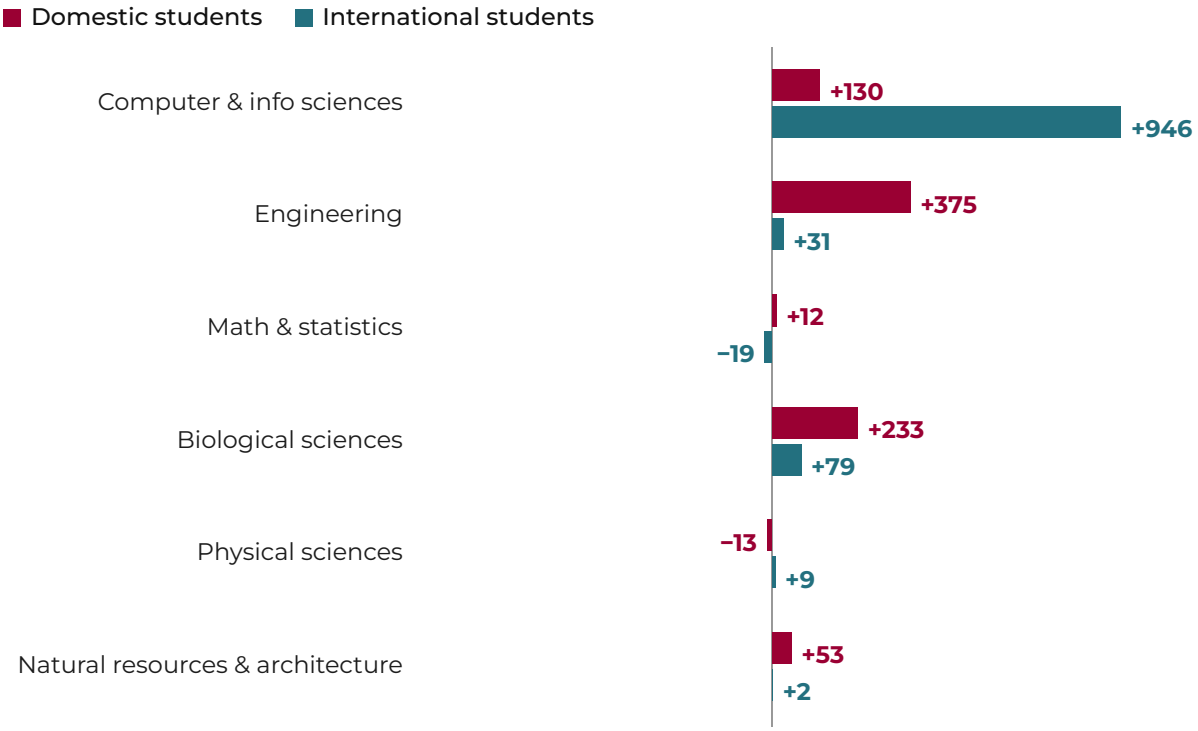
SECTION 1 · INTERNATIONAL DEPENDENCE

How Has Alabama's STEM Master's Output Grown?

Each pair of bars is the change in the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Alabama between 2015 and 2025 in one field: to domestic students (U.S. citizens and permanent residents) and to international students. Bars to the left of the axis are declines.

STEM master's degrees. The state awarded 3.45K in 2025 and 1.61K in 2015, a change of +1.05K for international students and +790 for domestic students.

Figure 6 Where Did the STEM Master's Growth Come From?



Change in STEM master's degrees by field, 2015–2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

1.47K
International STEM master's, 2025
U.S. **117K** · **20th** of 51

21%
STEM share of master's, 2025
U.S. **23%** · **26th** of 51

1.3%
Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025
20th of 51

8.2
STEM master's per doctorate, 2025
U.S. **6.4** · **10th** of 51

The table gives the number of STEM master's degrees awarded in Alabama in each field in 2015 and 2025, the change between the two years, the number awarded to international students in 2025, and international students' share of the field's degrees in each year.

STEM share of master's degrees. The share was 21% in 2025, against 23% for the U.S., 26th among the states, up 2.0 points from 19% in 2024 and up 7.0 points since 2015, when it was 14%.

Table 3 How Many STEM Master's Degrees Does Each Field Award?

Field	2015	2025	Change	International 2025	Int. share 2015	Int. share 2025
Computer & info sciences	191	**1.27K**	+563%	1.04K	50%	82%
Engineering	1.07K	**1.47K**	+38%	266	22%	18%
Math & statistics	78	**71**	−9.0%	17	46%	24%
Biological sciences	121	**433**	+258%	91	9.9%	21%
Physical sciences	92	**88**	−4.3%	39	33%	44%
Natural resources & architecture	65	**120**	+85%	12	15%	10%

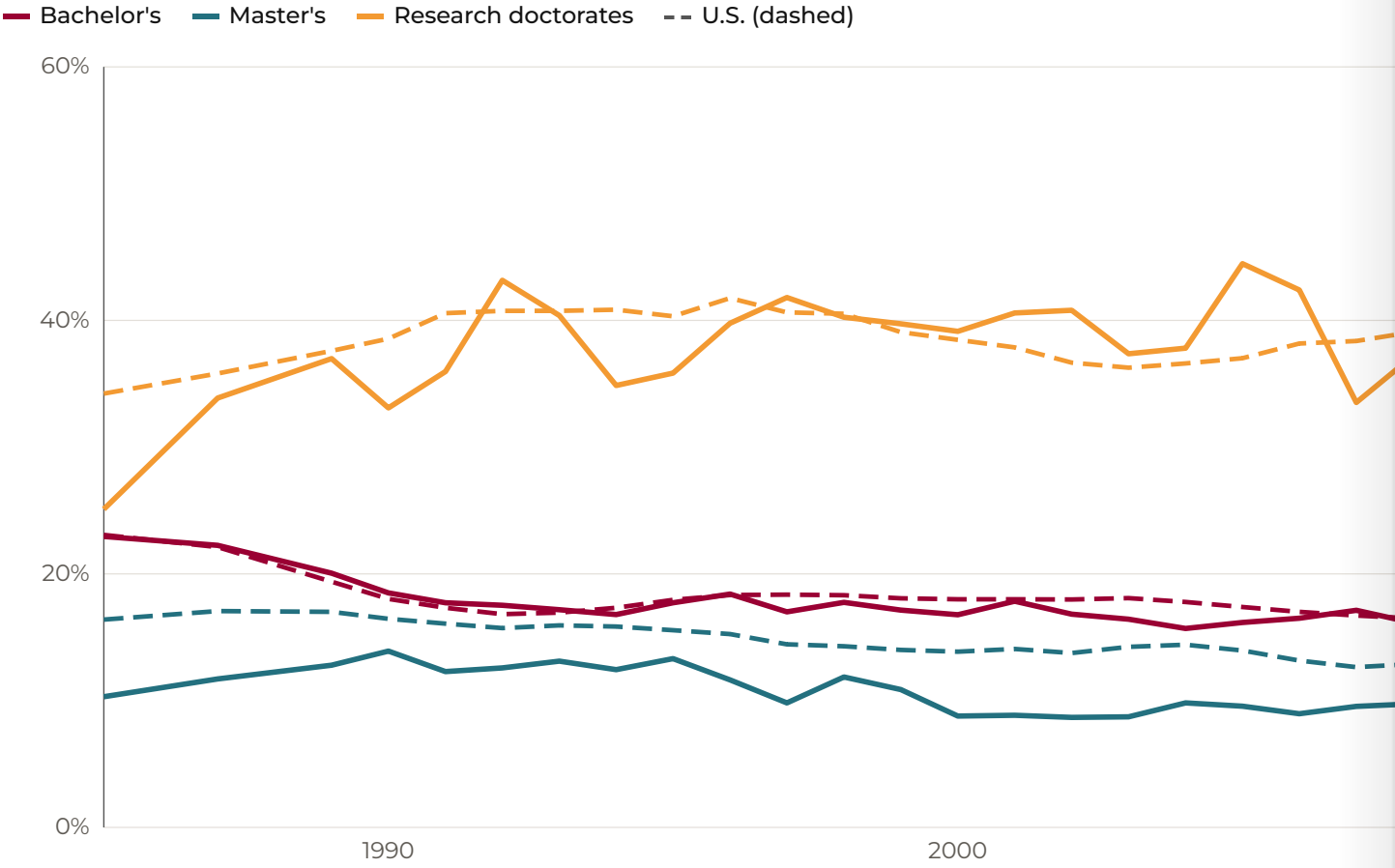
STEM master's degrees awarded in Alabama, all students and international students, 2015 and 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

SECTION 2

STEM Degrees

Alabama ranks 23rd of 51 states on the STEM share of bachelor's, at 24% in 2025 against 24% for the U.S.

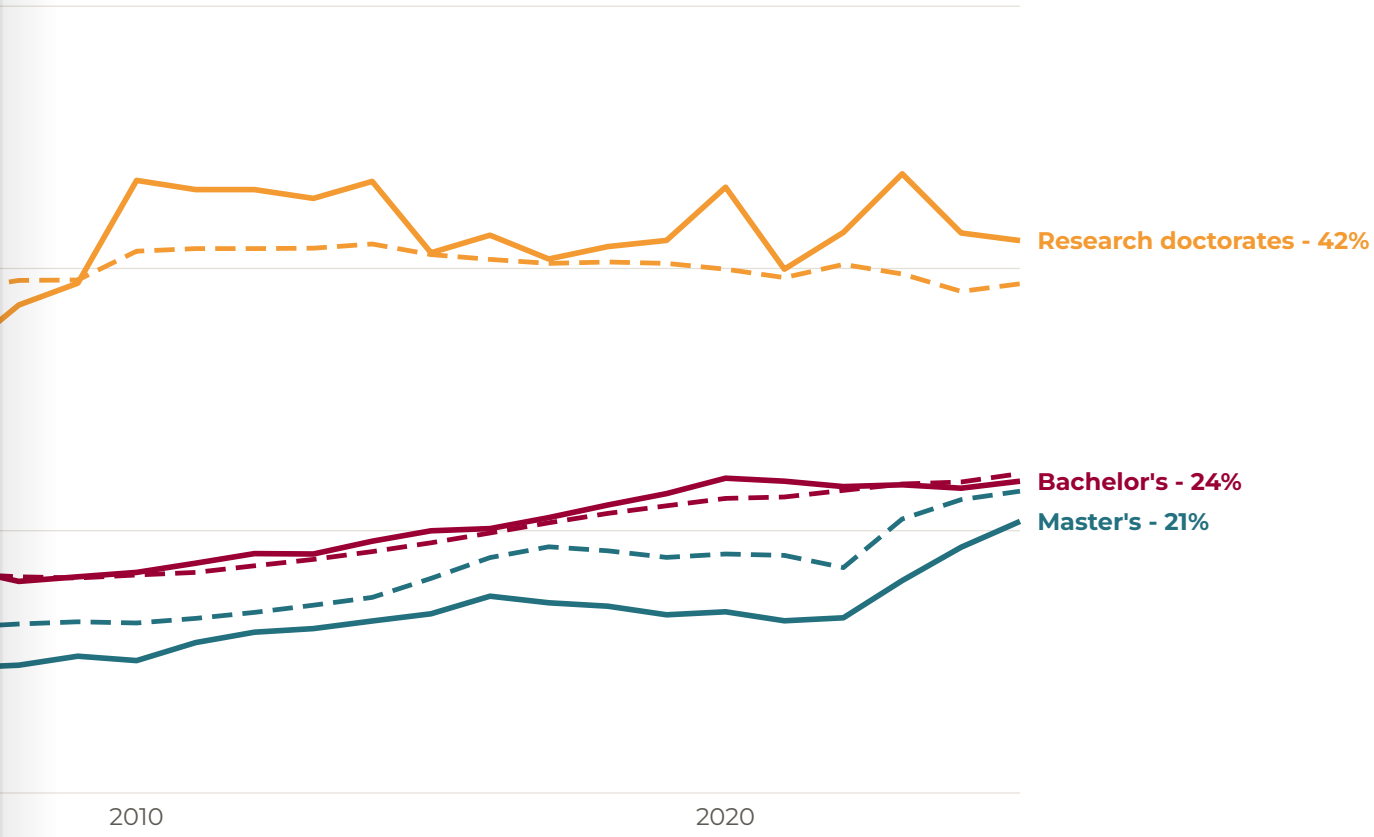
Figure 7 How Much of Alabama's Degree Output Is STEM?



STEM share of degrees by level; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

STEM fields account for 24% of Alabama's bachelor's degrees, 21% of its master's and 42% of its research doctorates (U.S. 24%, 23% and 39%).

The STEM share of master's degrees is up 7.0 points since 2015, and the state ranks 26th of 51 on it. On the STEM share of bachelor's degrees it ranks 23rd of 51.



24%

STEM share of bachelor's, 2025

U.S. **24%** · **23rd** of 51 · +3.8 pp since 2015

21%

STEM share of master's, 2025

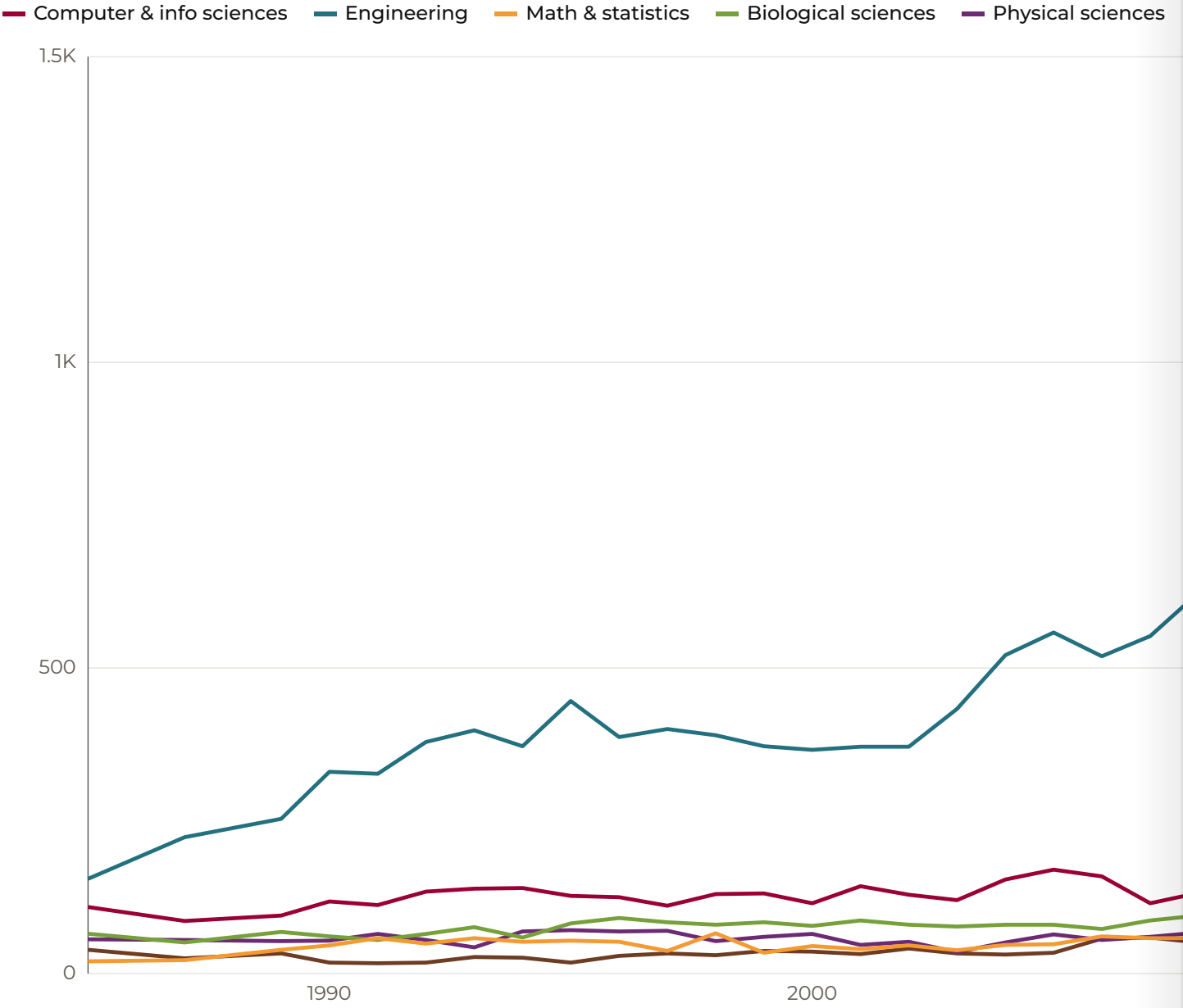
U.S. **23%** · **26th** of 51 · +7.0 pp since 2015

42%

STEM share of research doctorates, 2025

U.S. **39%** · **28th** of 51 · +0.9 pp since 2015

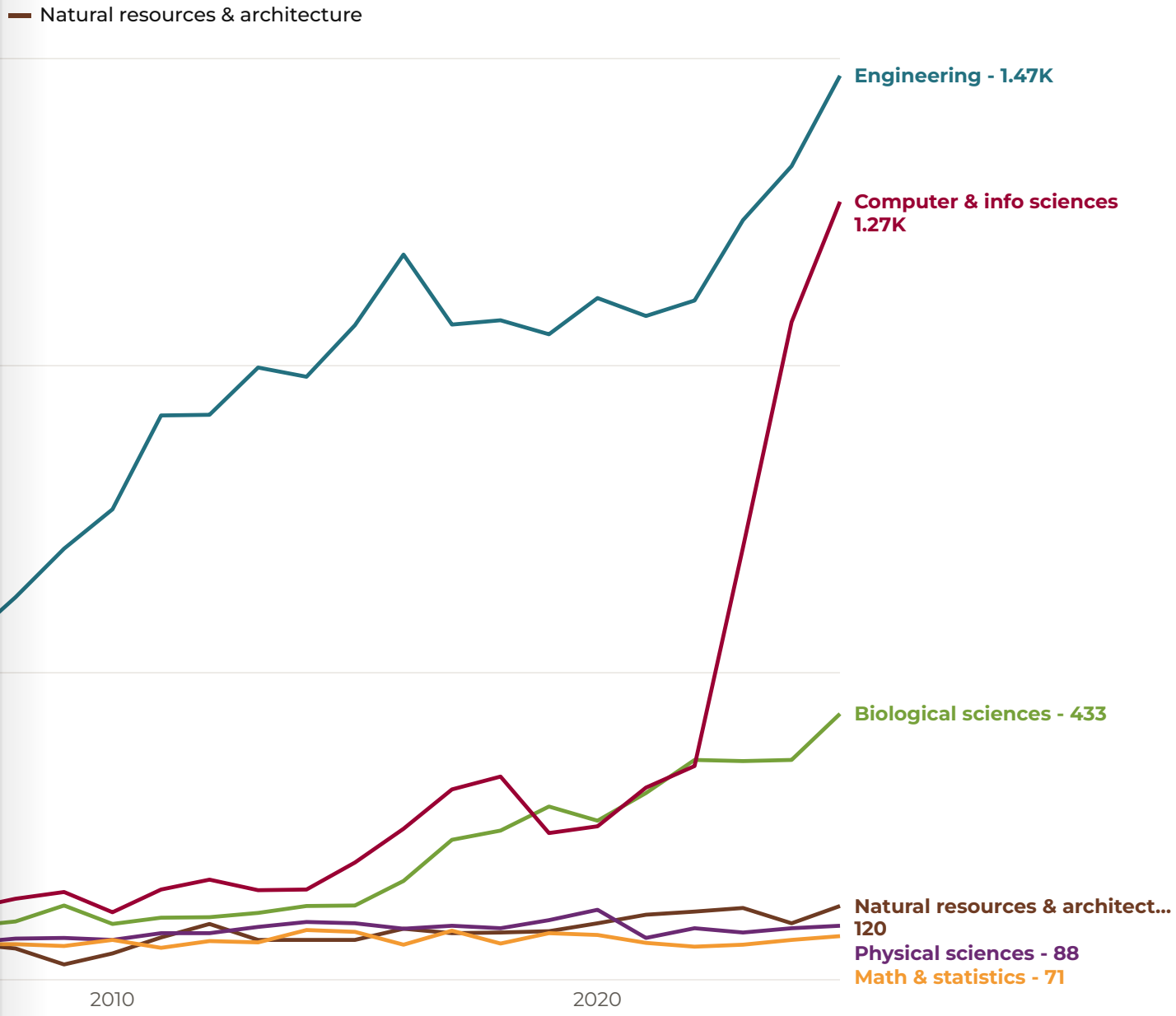
Figure 8 Which STEM Fields Produce Alabama's Master's Degrees?



STEM master's degrees by field, all students. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Engineering produced the most STEM master's degrees in 2025, 1.47K, followed by computer & info sciences (1.27K) and biological sciences (433). Master's degrees in engineering are up 38% since 2015.

International students earned 1.47K of the state's STEM master's degrees in 2025, 1.3% of the national total (20th of 51).



1.47K

International STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **117K** · **20th** of 51 · 3.50× since 2015

1.3%

Share of U.S. international STEM master's, 2025

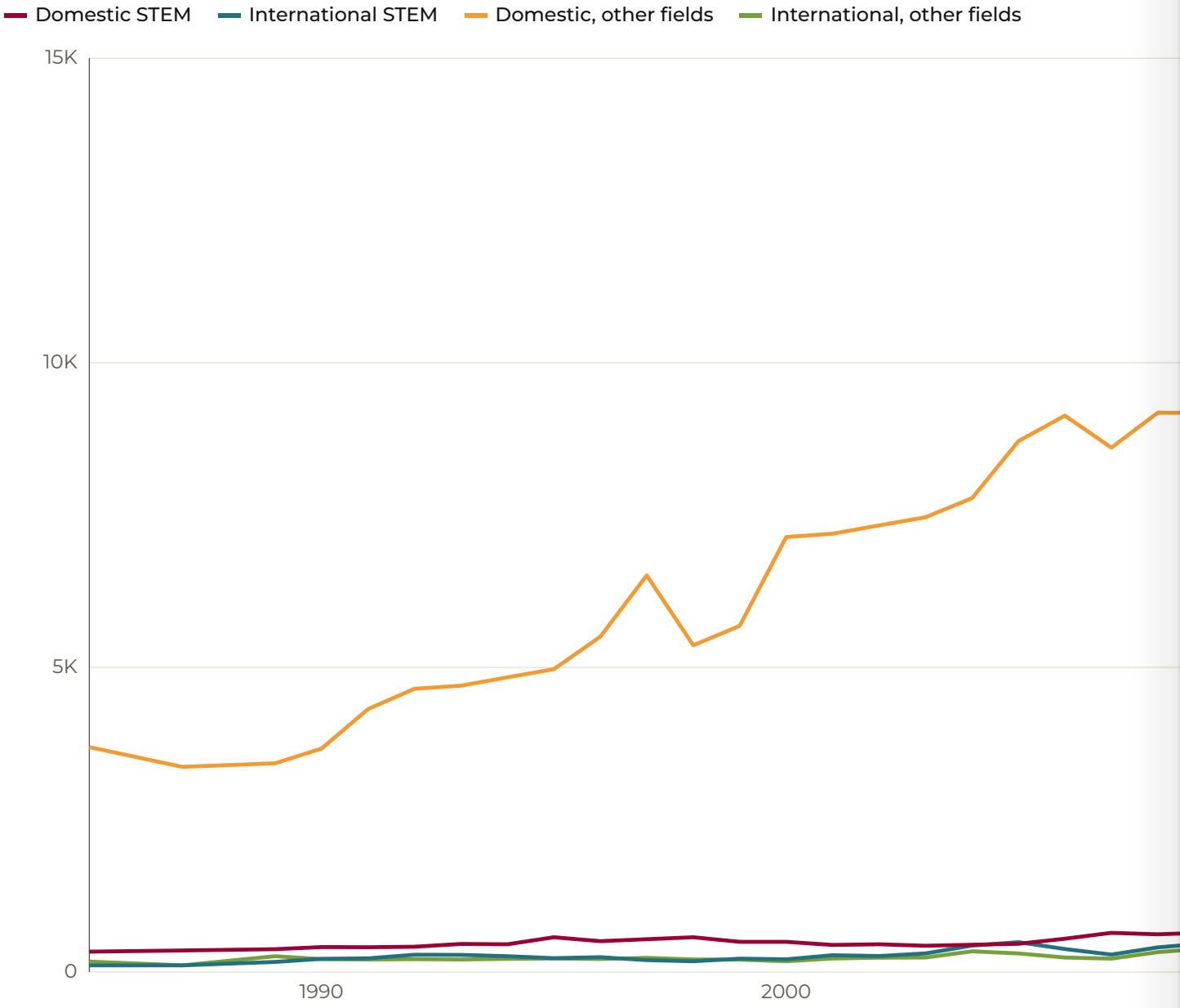
· **20th** of 51 · +0.5 pp since 2015

82%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

U.S. **65%** · **9th** of 47 · +32.0 pp since 2015

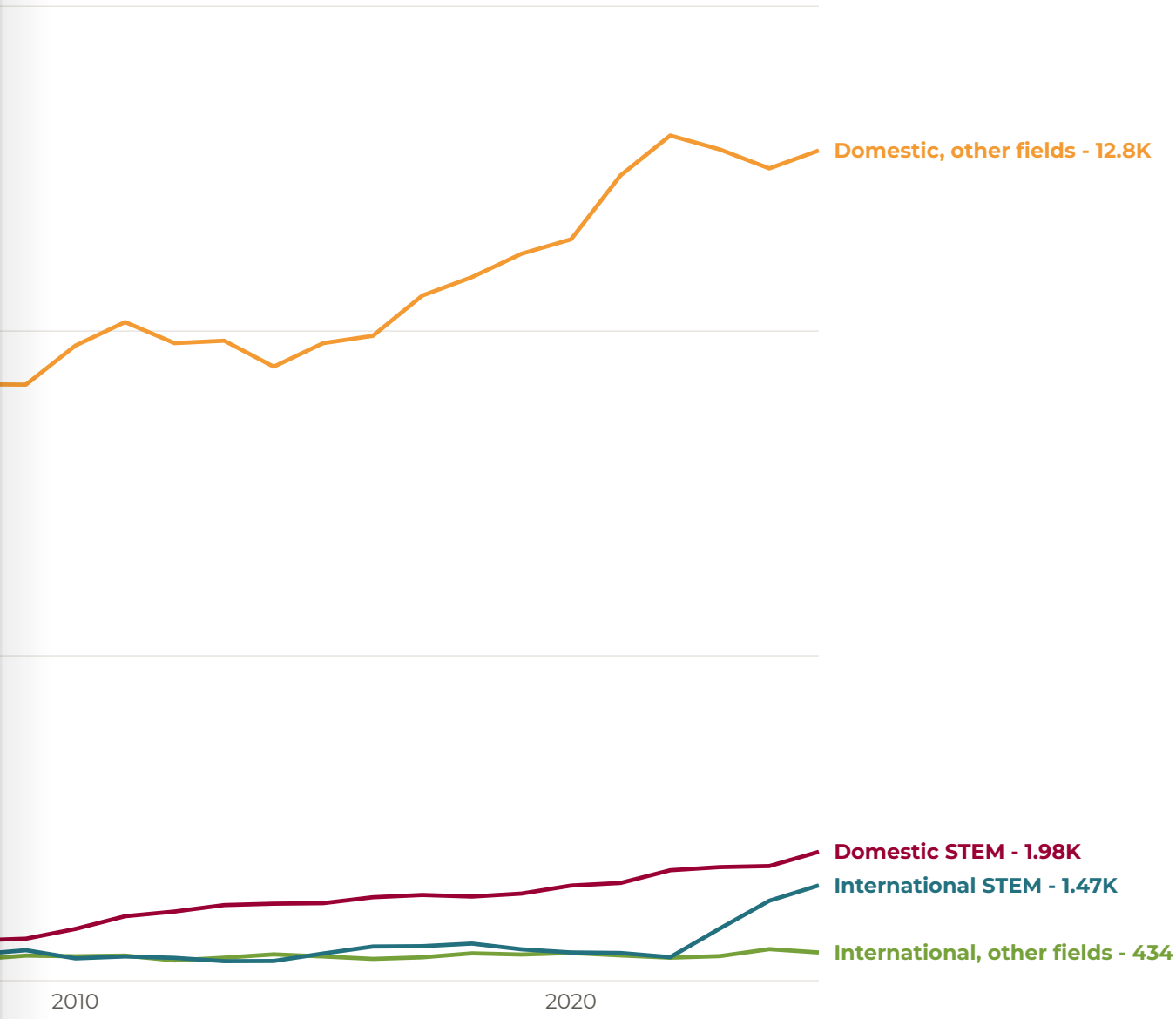
Figure 9 Who Earns Alabama's Master's Degrees?



Master's degrees by student residency and field group. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Between 2015 and 2025, 1.05K more STEM master's degrees went to international students and 790 more to domestic students.

International students earn 43% of Alabama's STEM master's but 3.3% of master's in other fields (U.S. 52% and 12%).



11%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

U.S. **22%** · **36th** of 51 · +4.7 pp since 2015

43%

Int. share of STEM master's, 2025

U.S. **52%** · **26th** of 51 · +16.5 pp since 2015

8.2

STEM master's per doctorate, 2025

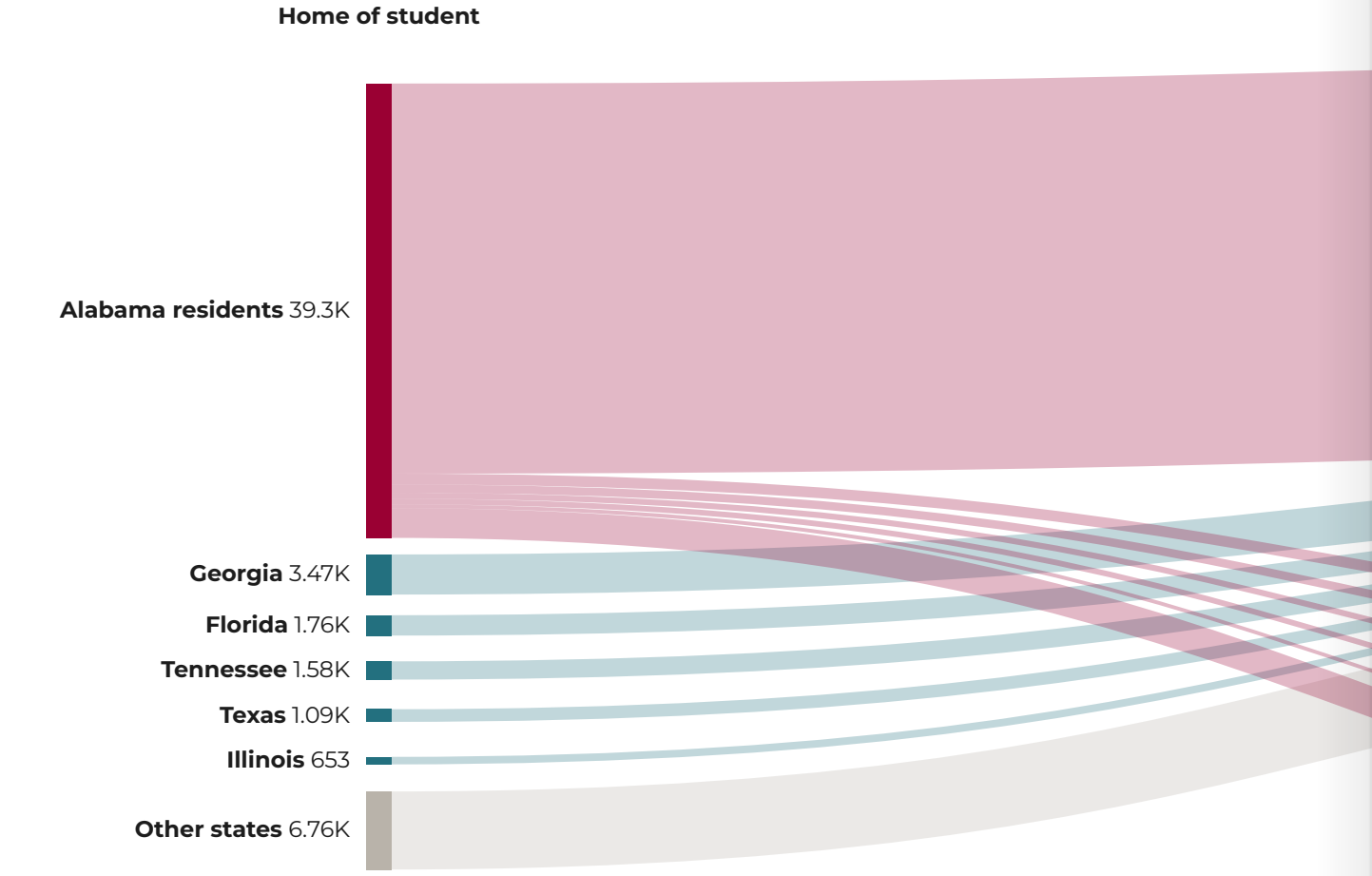
U.S. **6.4** · **10th** of 51 · +3.4 since 2015

SECTION 3

Where Students Come From

Alabama ranks 45th of 51 states on the share of first-time students whose home is outside the US, at 1.2% in 2024 against 3.1% for the U.S.

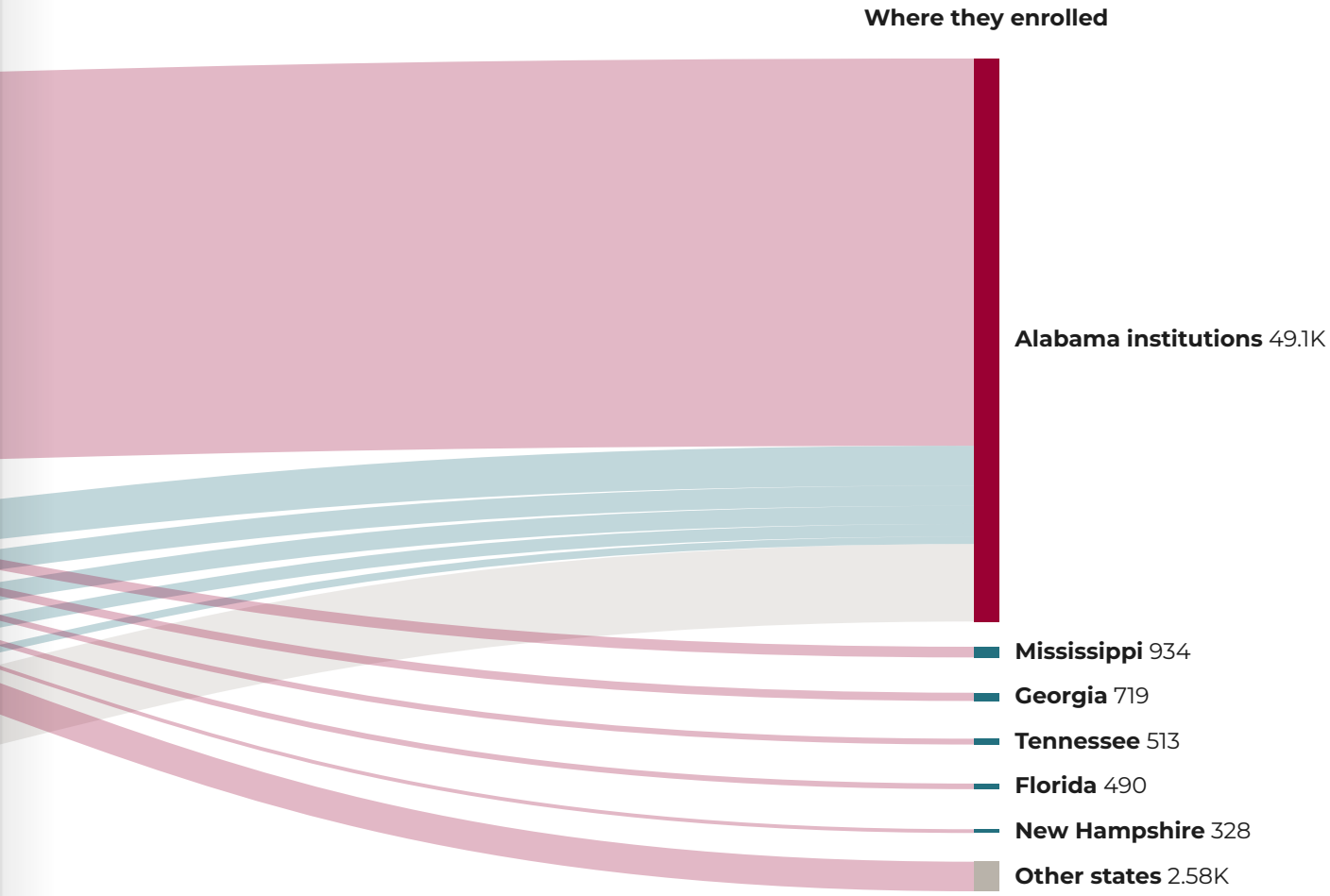
Figure 10 First-Time Students by Home and Destination, Fall 2024



Home of first-time degree-seeking undergraduates (left) and the state of the institution entered (right); the five largest s

33.8K residents stayed in Alabama for college in fall 2024; 14.8K students arrived from other states and 574 from abroad, while 5.56K residents left.

Each band runs from a student's home on the left to the state where they enrolled on the right. 68% of the state's first-time students are residents (U.S. –).



ources and destinations, the rest grouped. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

68%

First-time students from in state, 2024

· **32nd** of 51 · −3.0 pp since 2016

1.2%

First-time students from abroad, 2024

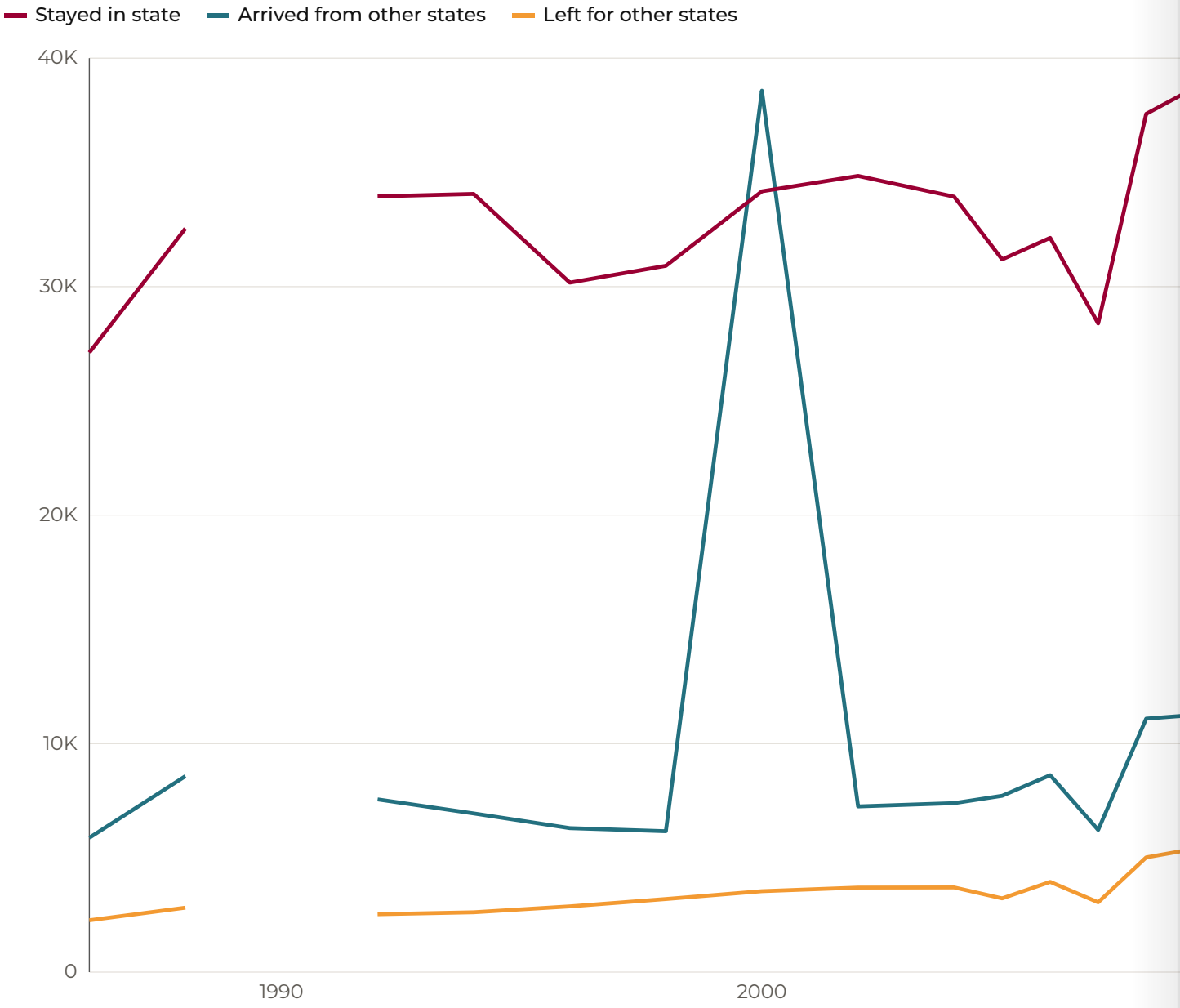
U.S. **3.1%** · **45th** of 51 · −0.2 pp since 2016

+23

Net migration per 100 residents, 2024

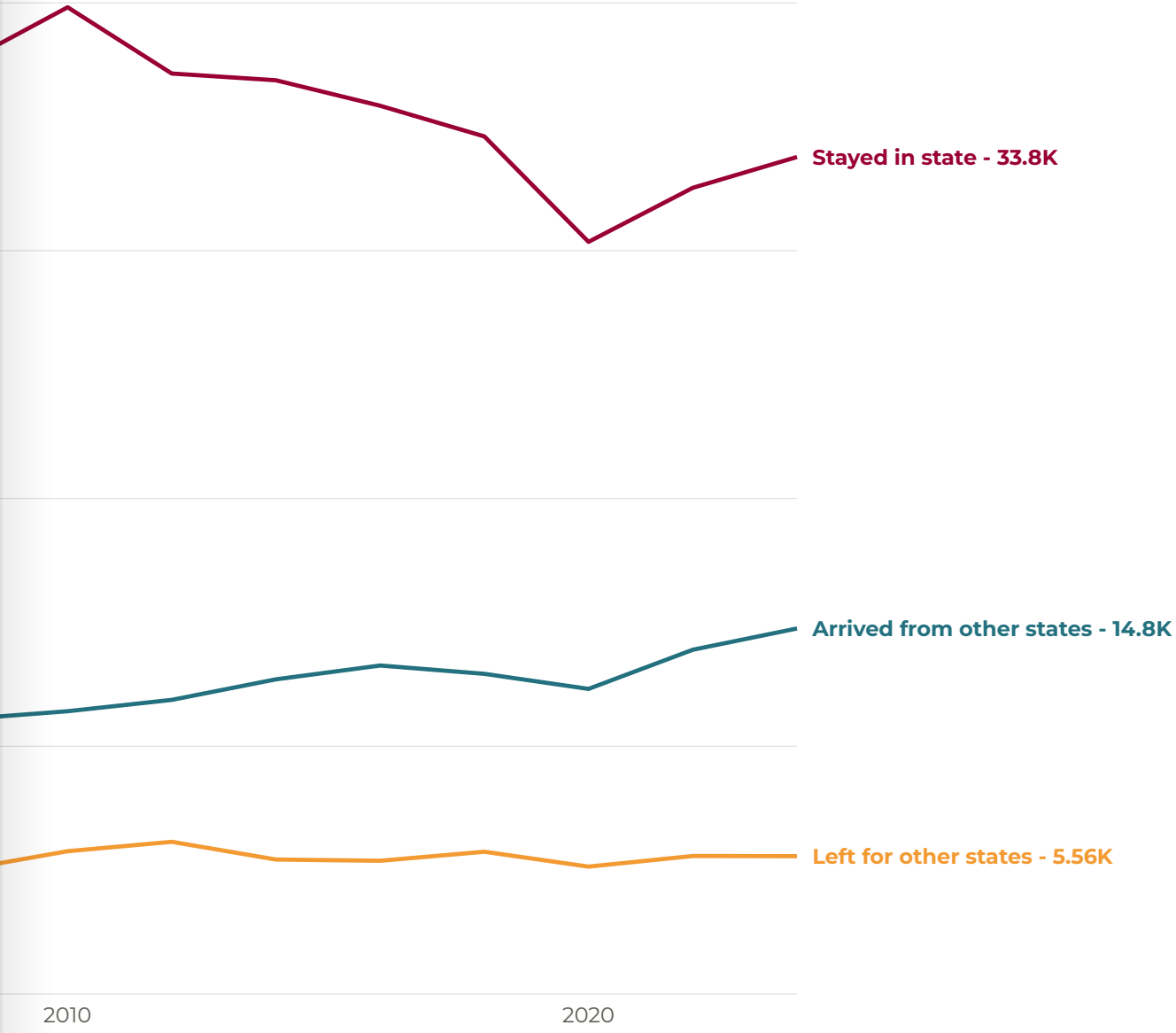
· **9th** of 51 · +4.2 since 2016

Figure 11 How Have the Flows Changed?



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by flow; even years before 2001. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Since 2015, the number of residents staying in state for college is down 6%, arrivals from other states are up 11%, and residents leaving are up 3%.



Net migration was +23 per 100 resident first-time students (9th of 51). The top destination for residents who left was Mississippi (934).

Figure 12

Where Do Alabama's Newcomers Come From?

The bands show where first-time degree-seeking undergraduates who enrolled at Alabama's institutions in fall 2024 but did not live in the state came from: the 12 largest home states and students from abroad, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Home is the state where the student lived when admitted.

15.3K

First-time students from other states and abroad, fall 2024

Abroad **574**

1.2%

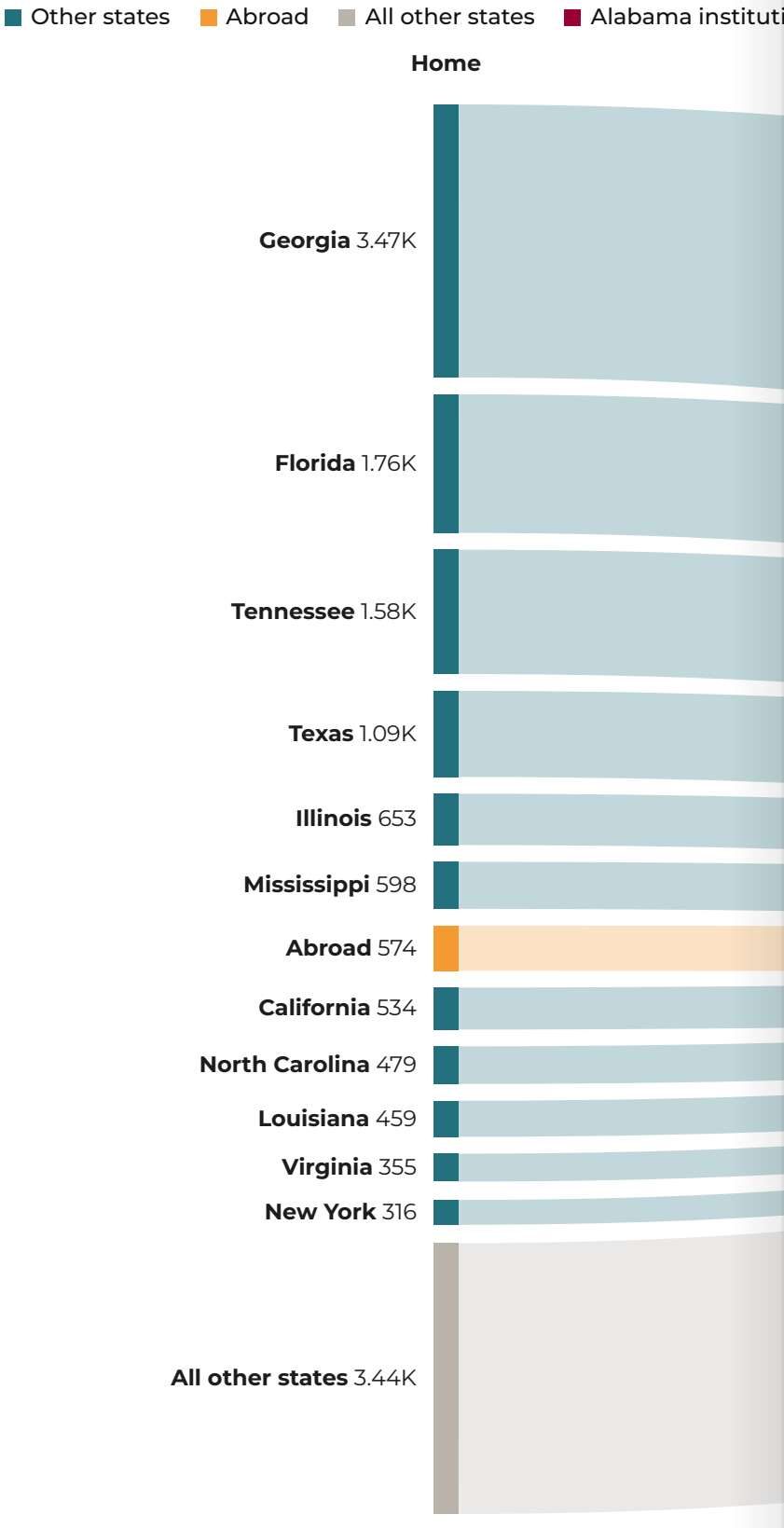
First-time students from abroad, 2024

U.S. **3.1%** · **45th** of 51 · −0.2 pp since 2016

68%

First-time students from in state, 2024

32nd of 51 · −3.0 pp since 2016



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flo

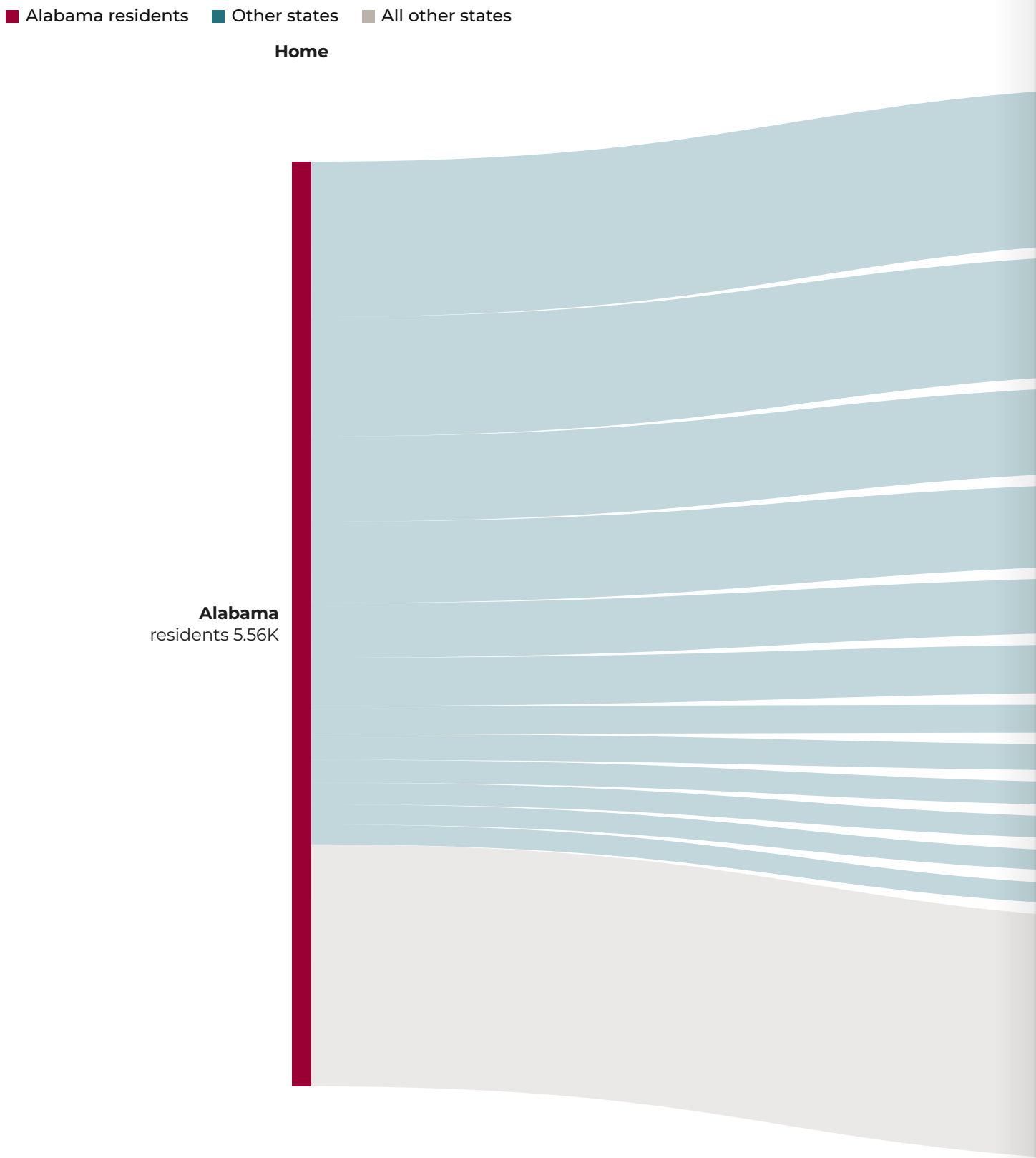
ions

Enrolled in



Alabama
institutions 15.3K

ws. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.



First-time degree-seeking undergraduates, fall 2024; the 12 largest flows. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

Figure 13

Where Do Alabama's Residents Go When They Leave?

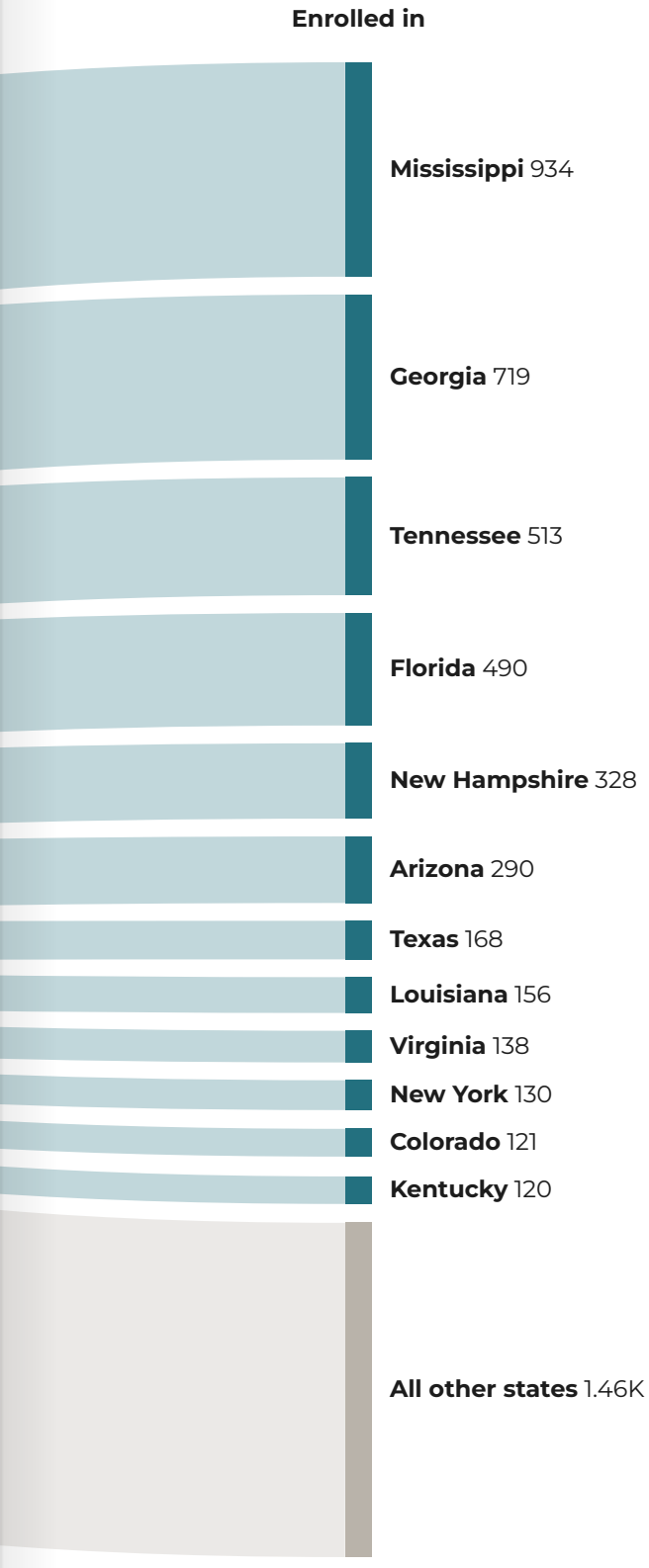
The bands show where Alabama residents who left the state to start college in fall 2024 enrolled: the 12 largest destination states, with all other states grouped. Band widths are proportional to the number of students. Residents who enrolled in the state are not shown.

Residents leaving for other states. The number was 5.56K in fall 2024, down 0.1% from 5.57K in fall 2022 and up 3.4% since fall 2016, when it was 5.38K.

5.56K
Residents who started college in another state, fall 2024
Arrivals **15.3K**

+23
Net migration per 100 residents, 2024
9th of 51 · +4.2 since 2016

934
Went to Mississippi
The largest destination

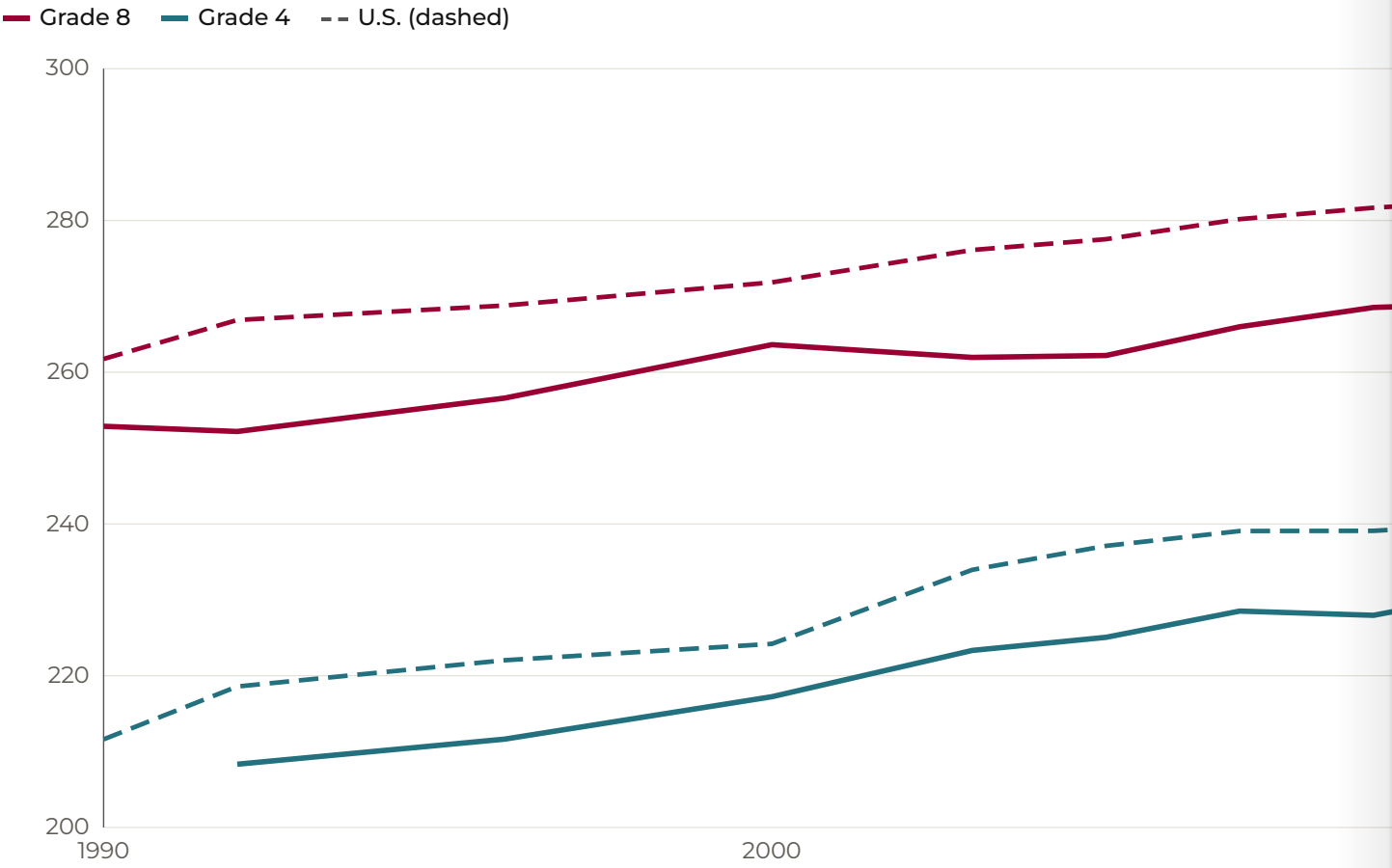


SECTION 4

K-12 Preparation

Alabama ranks 48th of 51 states on the average grade 8 mathematics score, at 262 in 2024 against 272 for the U.S.

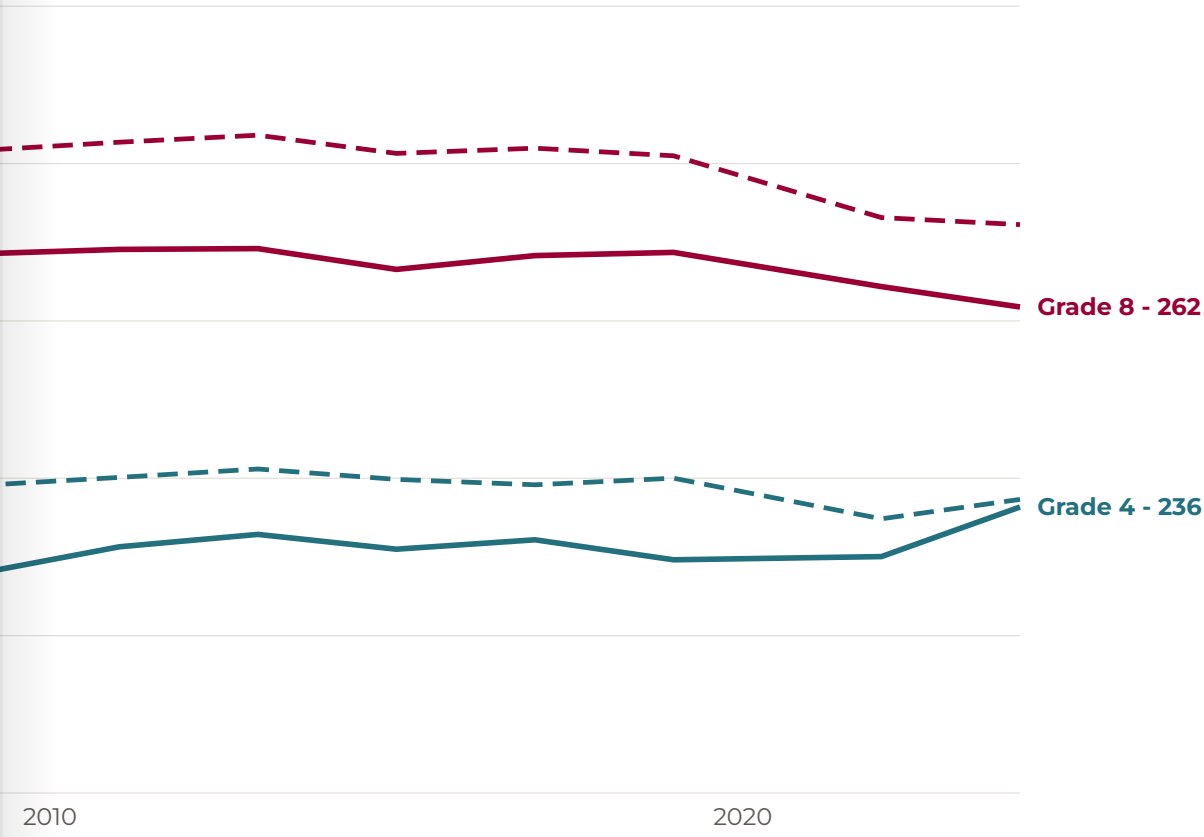
Figure 14 How Well Prepared in Mathematics Are Alabama's Students?



Average NAEP mathematics score, public schools, 0–500 scale; state solid, U.S. public schools dashed. Data from NCES, N

The talent pipeline starts in school. Alabama's eighth graders averaged 262 in mathematics on the 2024 NAEP, against 272 for U.S. public schools, 48th of 51 among the states.

18% scored at or above the Proficient level (U.S. 27%). Differences of a point or two are often within the margin of error.



lational Assessment of Educational Progress.

262

Grade 8 math score (NAEP), 2024

U.S. **272** · **48th** of 51 · −4.8 since 2015

18%

Grade 8 math, at or above Proficient, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **48th** of 51 · +1.2 pp since 2015

250

Grade 8 reading score (NAEP), 2024

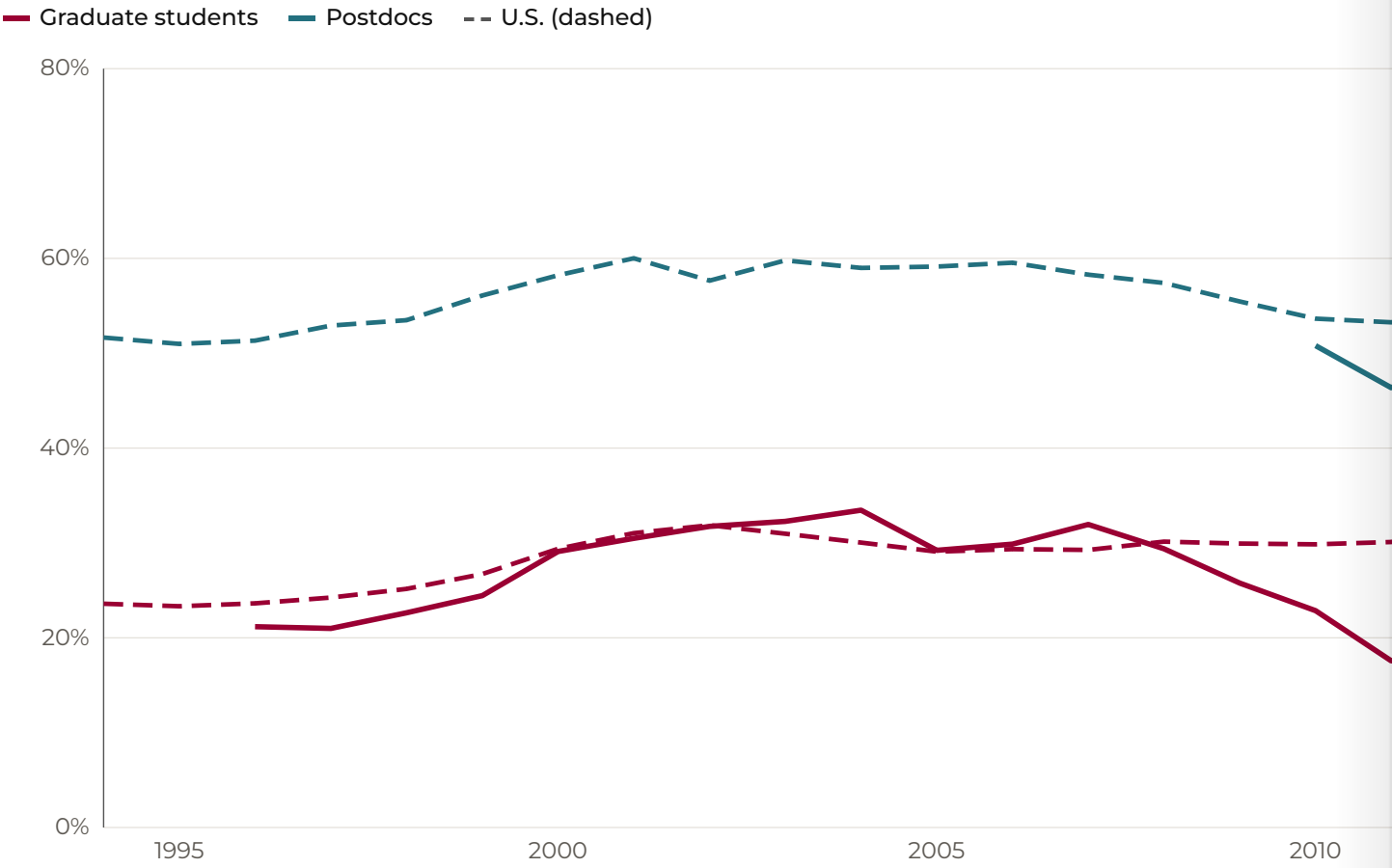
U.S. **257** · **46th** of 51 · −9.2 since 2015

SECTION 5

Graduate Research

Alabama ranks 15th of 51 states on the temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs, at 60% in 2016 against 56% for the U.S.

Figure 15 How Many of Alabama's Science and Engineering Graduate Students Hold Te



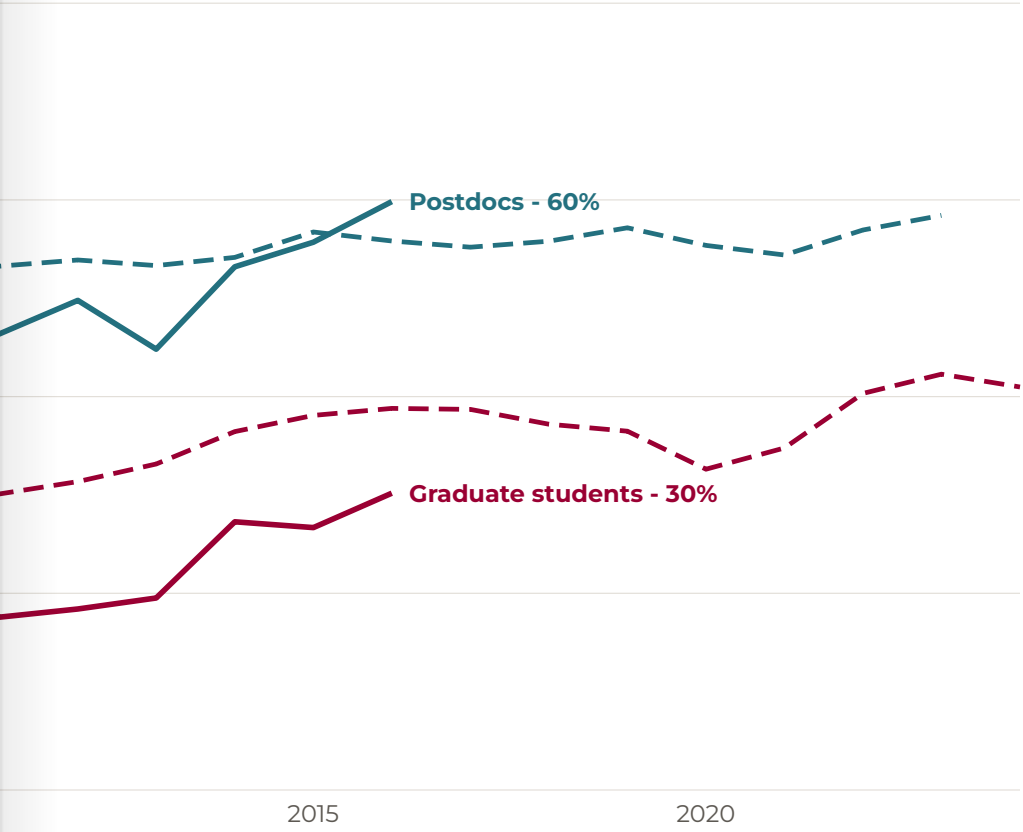
Temporary-visa share of science and engineering graduate students and postdoctoral appointees, by the institution's sta
Students and Postdoctorates.

In 2016, the last year NSF published state tables, 30% of Alabama's science and engineering graduate students held temporary visas (U.S. 39%; 32nd of 51).

Among postdoctoral researchers, the share was 60% (U.S. 56%). Postdocs are the stage of research training most dependent on international talent, and IPEDS does not count them.

The state's institutions awarded 771 research doctorates in 2025, 1.3% of the U.S. total (Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Earned Doctorates; NSF publishes doctorates by citizenship only for the nation).

emporary Visas?



te; state solid, U.S. dashed. NSF stopped publishing state tables after 2016. Data from NSF NCSES, Survey of Graduate

30%

S&E grad students on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **39%** · **32nd** of 51 · +3.5 pp since 2015

60%

S&E postdocs on temporary visas, 2016

U.S. **56%** · **15th** of 51 · +4.1 pp since 2015

771

Research doctorates awarded (NSF SED), 2025

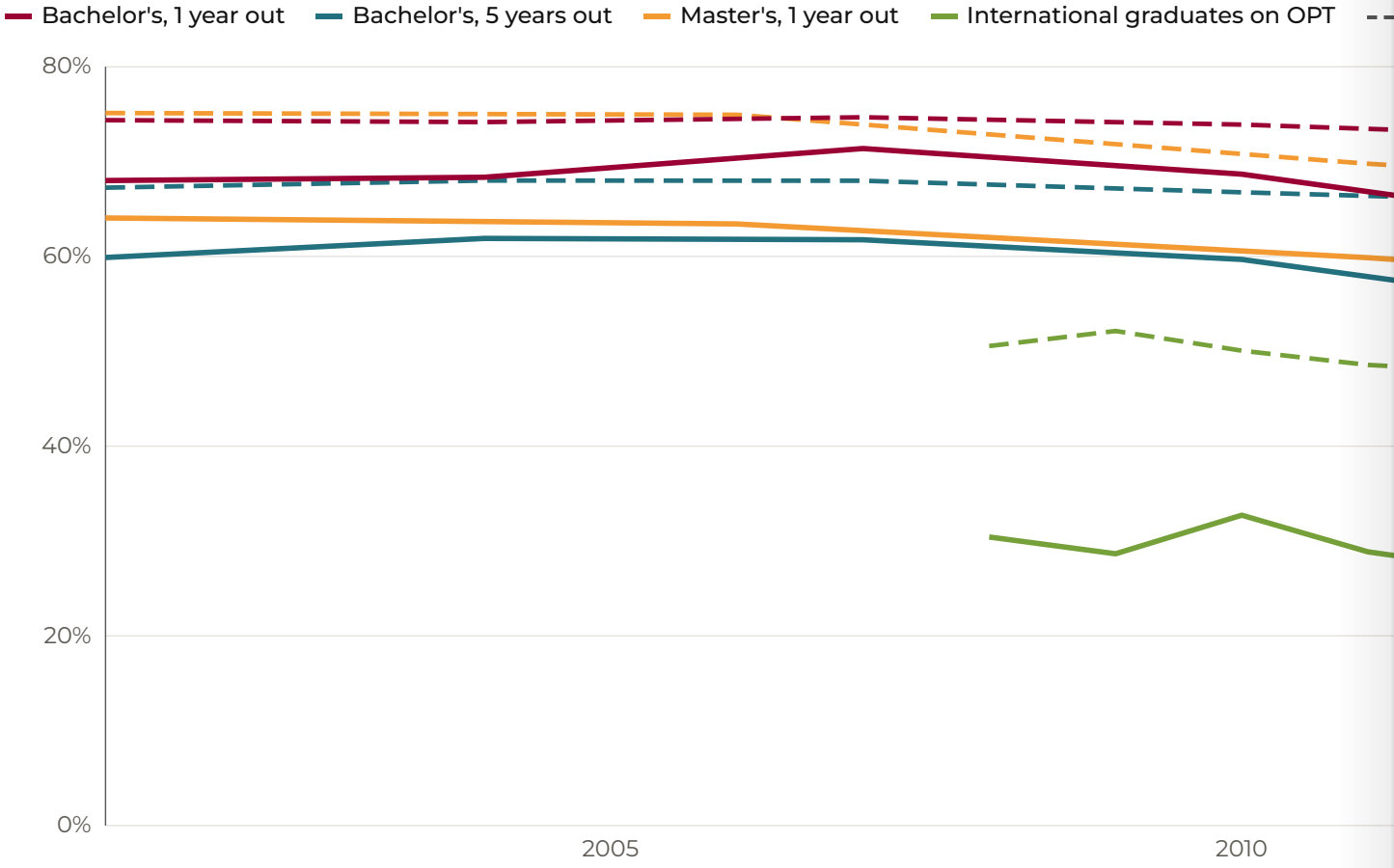
U.S. **59K** · **24th** of 51 · +11% since 2015

SECTION 6

Do Graduates Stay?

Alabama ranks 29th of 33 states on the share of bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating, at 53% in 2019 against 72% for the U.S.

Figure 16 How Many of Alabama's Graduates Go On to Work in the State?

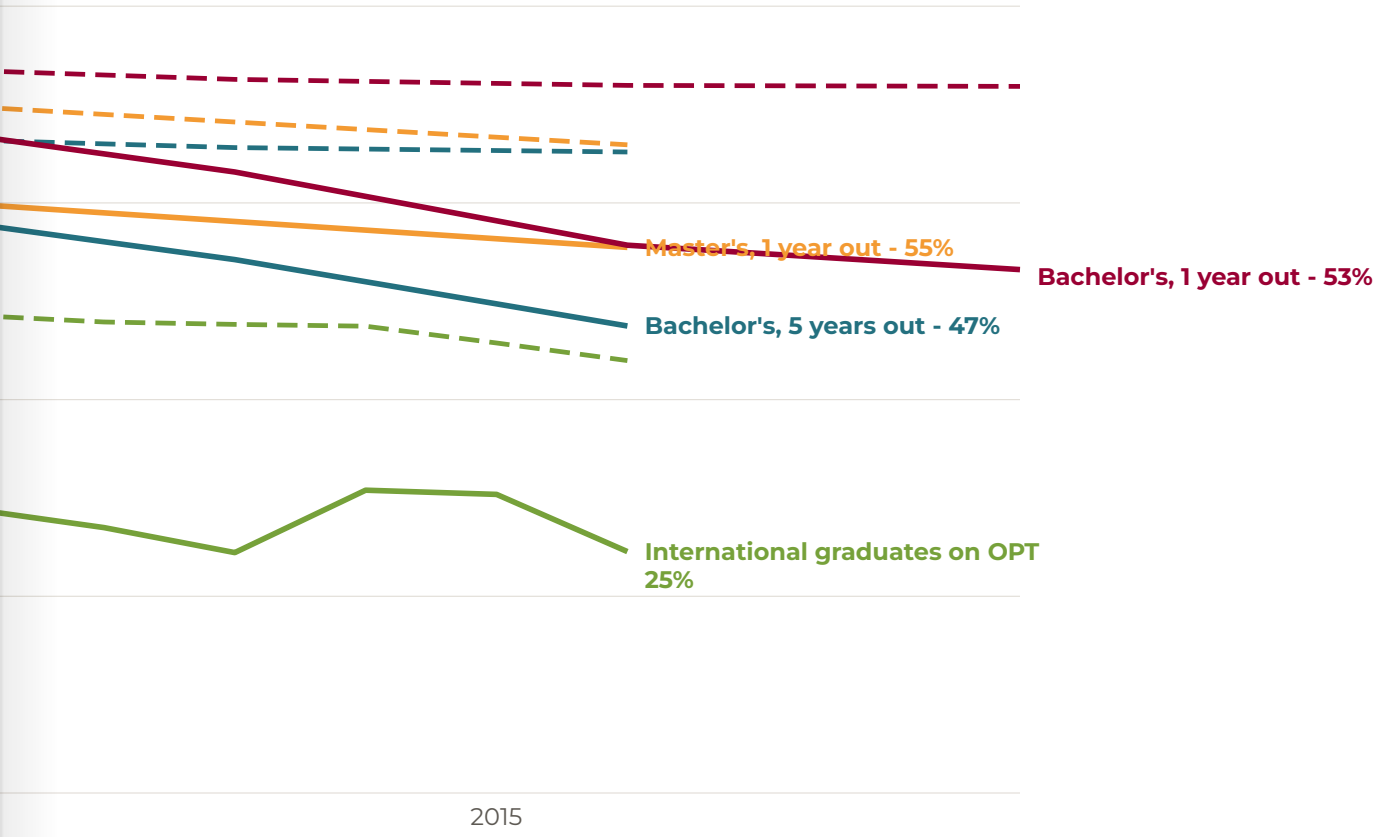


Share of employed graduates working in the state of their institution, by graduating cohort (Data from U.S. Census Burea
state where they studied (Data from ICE, SEVIS FOIA releases; shares only, the file is truncated). State solid, U.S. or particip

Of Alabama's bachelor's graduates who were working a year after graduating, 53% worked in the state (participating states 72%). Five years out the share was 47%.

Among international graduates on Optional Practical Training in 2016, 25% worked in the state where they studied (U.S. 44%). Through migration between states, the state gained 5.1 bachelor's-plus adults per 1,000 such residents in 2025 (Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American Community Survey).

U.S. (dashed)



au, Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes; participating institutions only); international graduates' OPT jobs in the
pating states dashed.

53%

Bachelor's grads working in-state, 1 year out, 2019

U.S. **72%** · **29th** of 33 · −2.5 pp since 2016

25%

OPT graduates working in the state, 2016

U.S. **44%** · **41st** of 51 · −5.8 pp since 2015

+5.1

Net migration, bachelor's-plus, per 1,000, 2025

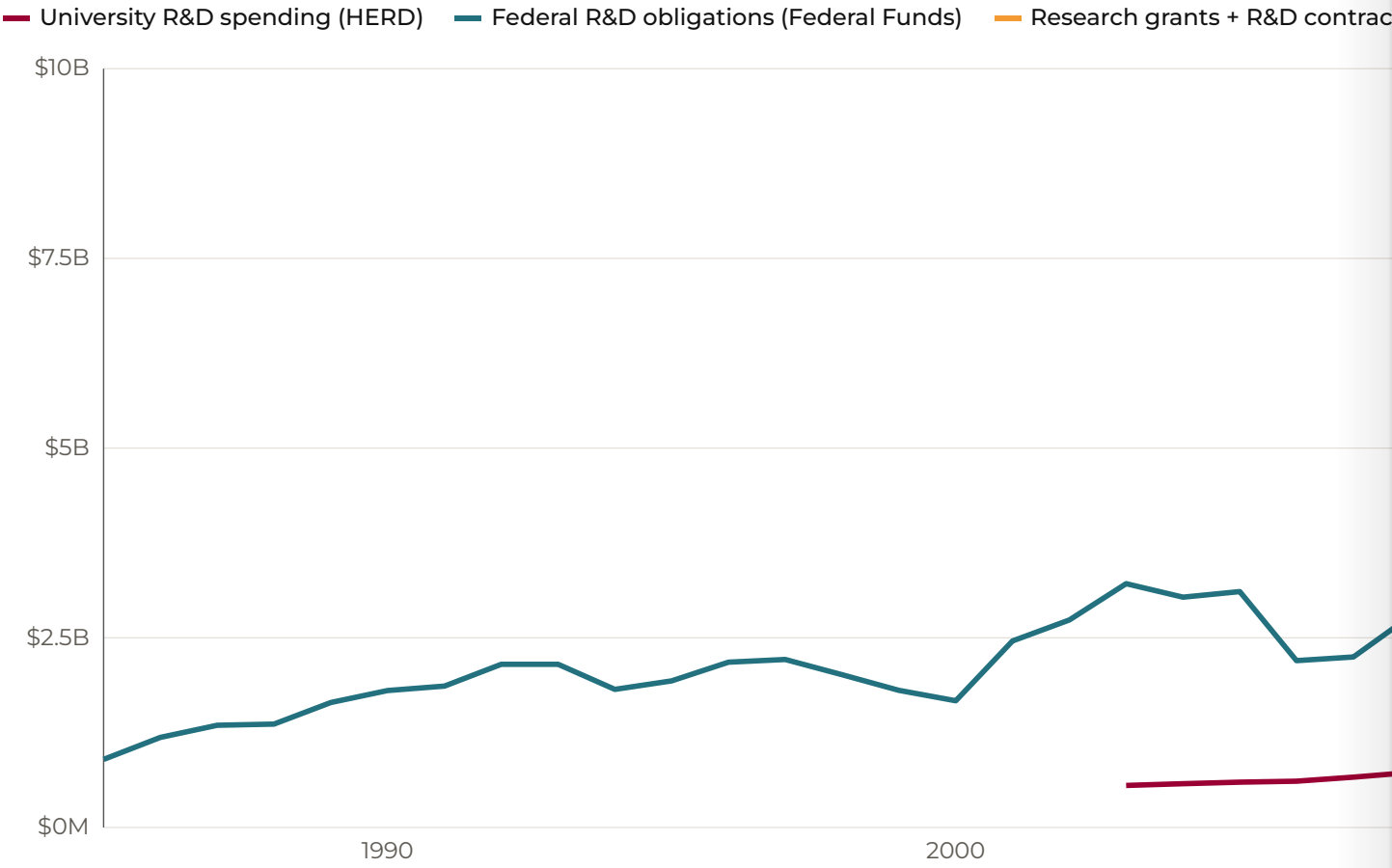
· **13th** of 51 · +5.4 since 2015

SECTION 7

Research Funding

Alabama ranks 8th of 51 states on federal R&D obligations to the state, at $7.78B in 2024 against $193B for the U.S.

Figure 17 How Much Research Money Flows Into Alabama?

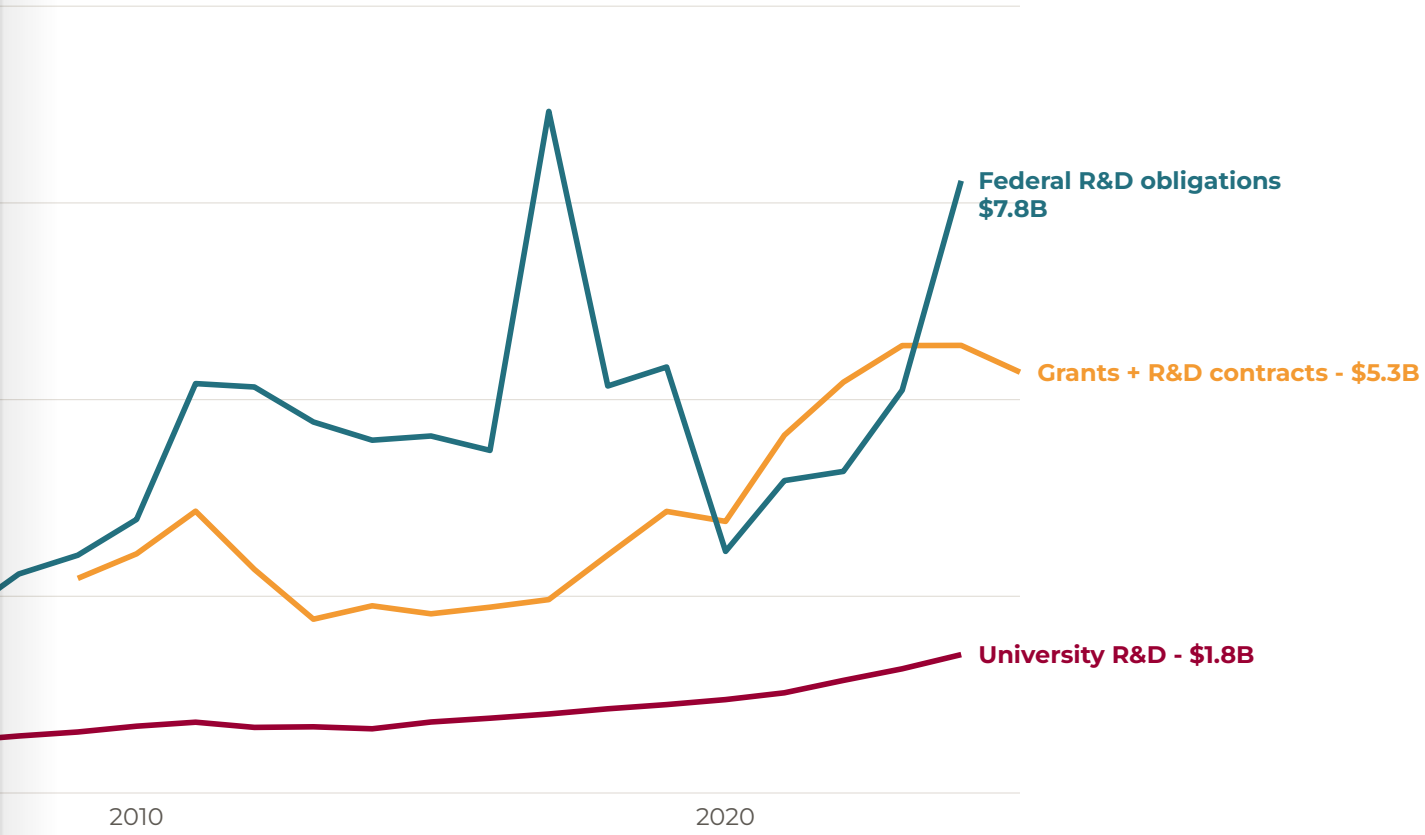


Millions of nominal dollars, fiscal years. University R&D: Data from NSF NCSES, Higher Education Research and Developm
Survey of Federal Funds for R&D (coverage widens in FY2021). Grants from NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science plus R&D co

Alabama's universities spent $1.76B on research and development in FY2024, 23rd of 51 among the states; 54% of it was federally funded (U.S. 55%).

Federal agencies obligated $7.78B for R&D performed in the state in FY2024. Research funding drives demand for graduate students and postdocs, the stage of training most dependent on international talent.

ts (USAspending)



ent Survey (FY2003-09 predecessor survey). Federal R&D obligations by state of performance: Data from NSF NCSES, ntracts: Data from USAspending.gov.

$1.76B

University R&D spending, 2024

U.S. **$118B** · **23rd** of 51 · +95% since 2015

54%

Federal share of university R&D, 2024

U.S. **55%** · **21st** of 51 · −4.4 pp since 2015

$7.78B

Federal R&D obligations, 2024

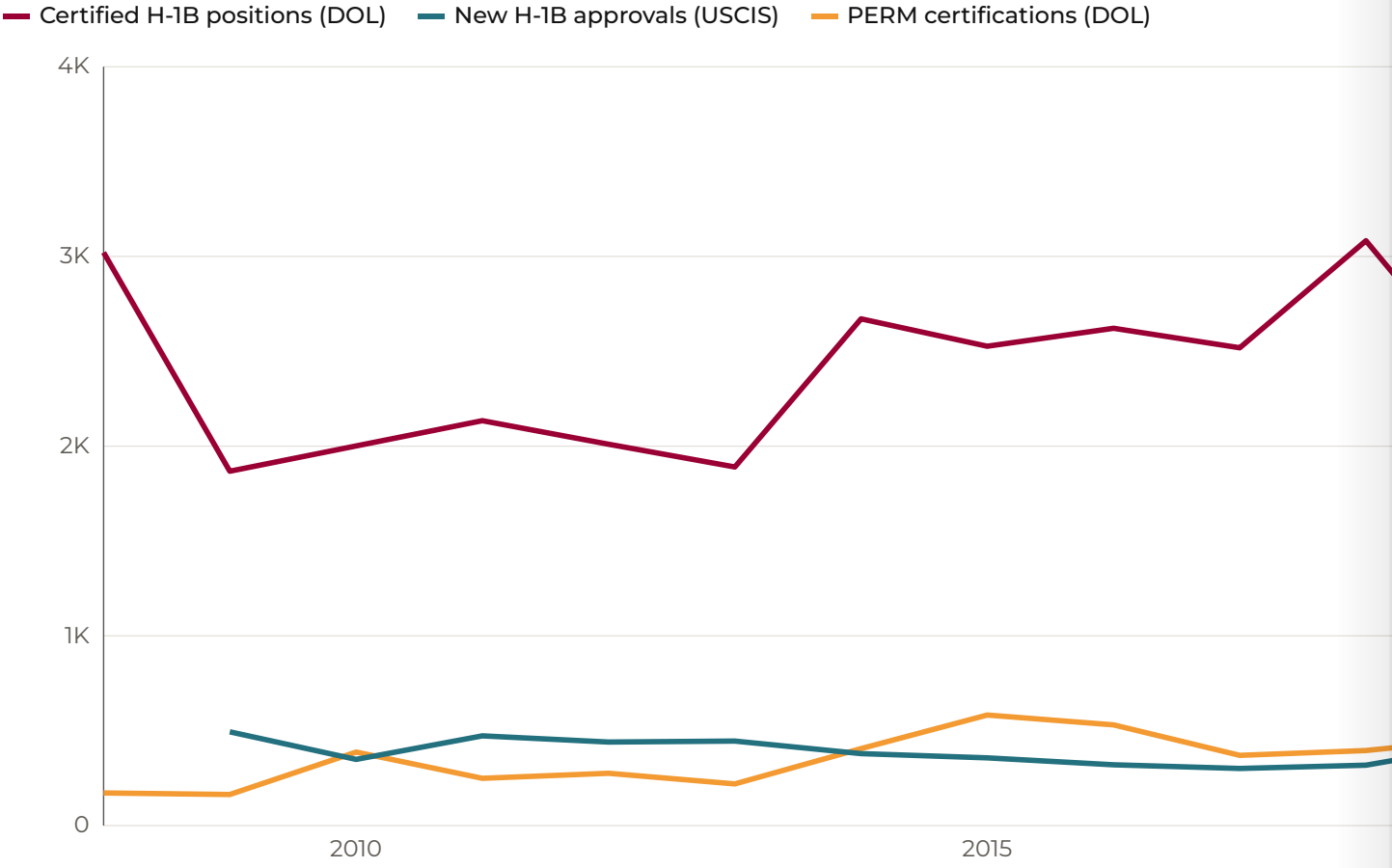
U.S. **$193B** · **8th** of 51 · +71% since 2015

SECTION 8

H-1B Jobs and Green Cards

Alabama ranks 16th of 51 states on green-card labor certifications, at 2.55K in 2025 against 138K for the U.S.

Figure 18 How Many Skilled-Visa Jobs and Green-Card Certifications Does Alabama Ge

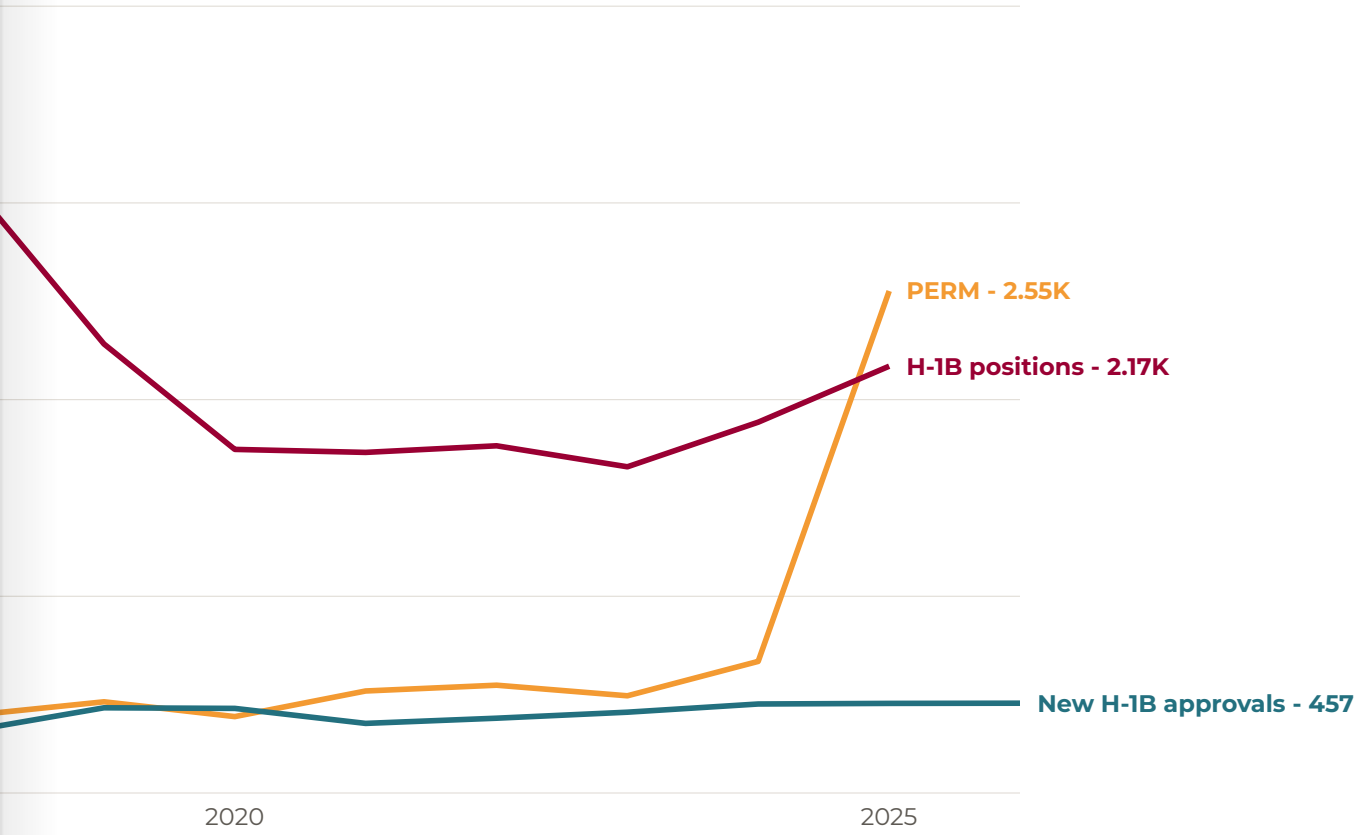


Certified H-1B positions on labor condition applications by worksite and certified PERM green-card applications, by fiscal
from USCIS, H-1B Employer Data Hub).

Employers were certified for 2.17K H-1B positions at Alabama worksites in FY2025, 35th of 51 among the states. A labor certification comes before the petition, so this overstates hires; USCIS approved 457 new H-1B petitions from employers in the state in FY2026.

DOL certified 2.55K PERM applications, the employer's step toward an employment-based green card, for jobs in the state in FY2025. In FY2024, 7.2% were for workers still on F-1 student visas (U.S. 8.7%): the most direct link from classroom to permanent residence.

nerate?



year (Data from DOL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification); new H-1B petition approvals by the employer's address (Data

2.17K

Certified H-1B positions (worksite), 2025

U.S. **914K** · **35th** of 51 · −14% since 2015

2.55K

PERM green-card certifications, 2025

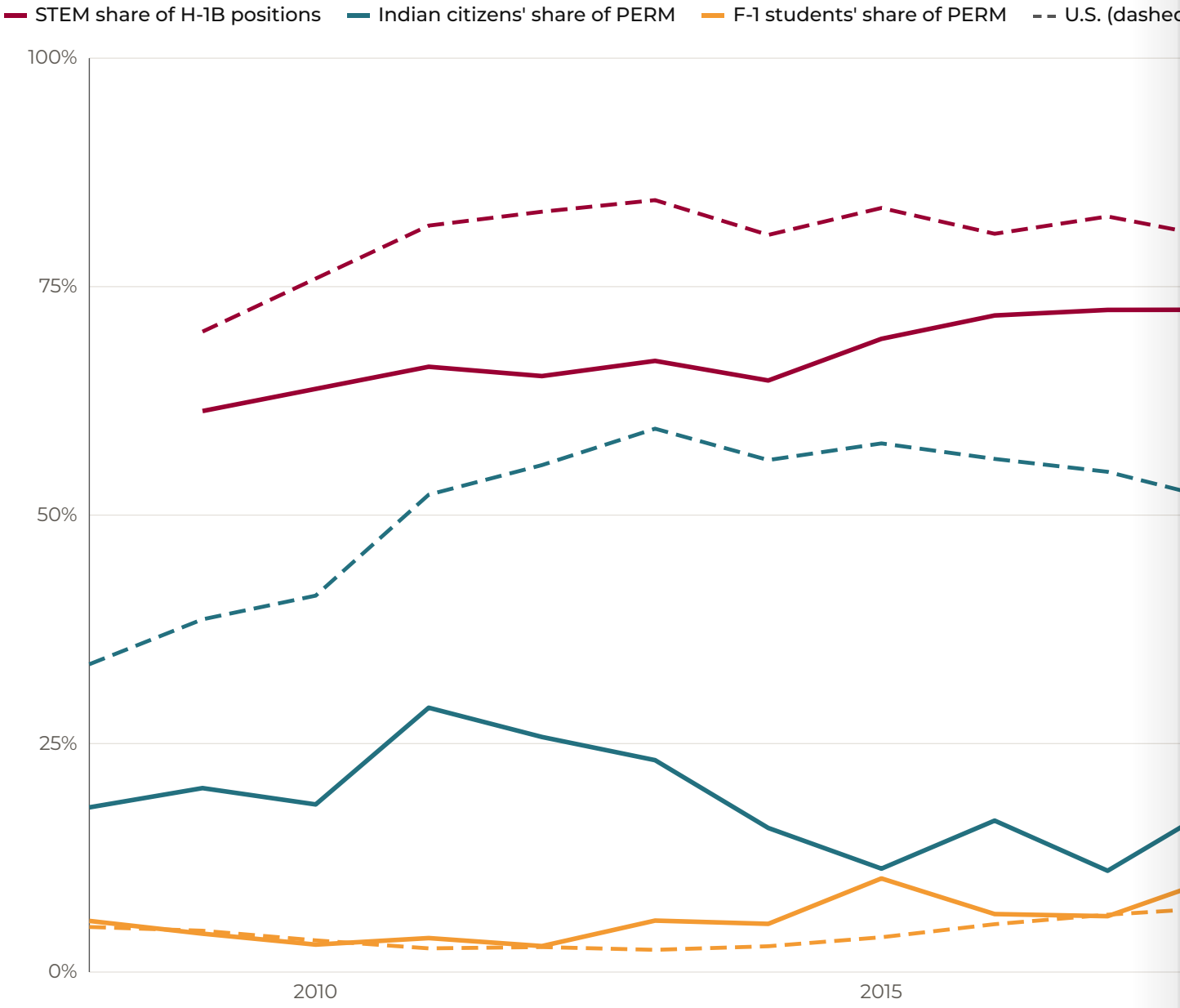
U.S. **138K** · **16th** of 51 · 4.38× since 2015

7.2%

PERM workers on F-1 student visas, 2024

U.S. **8.7%** · **36th** of 51 · −3.1 pp since 2015

Figure 19 Who Holds Alabama's Skilled-Visa Jobs?

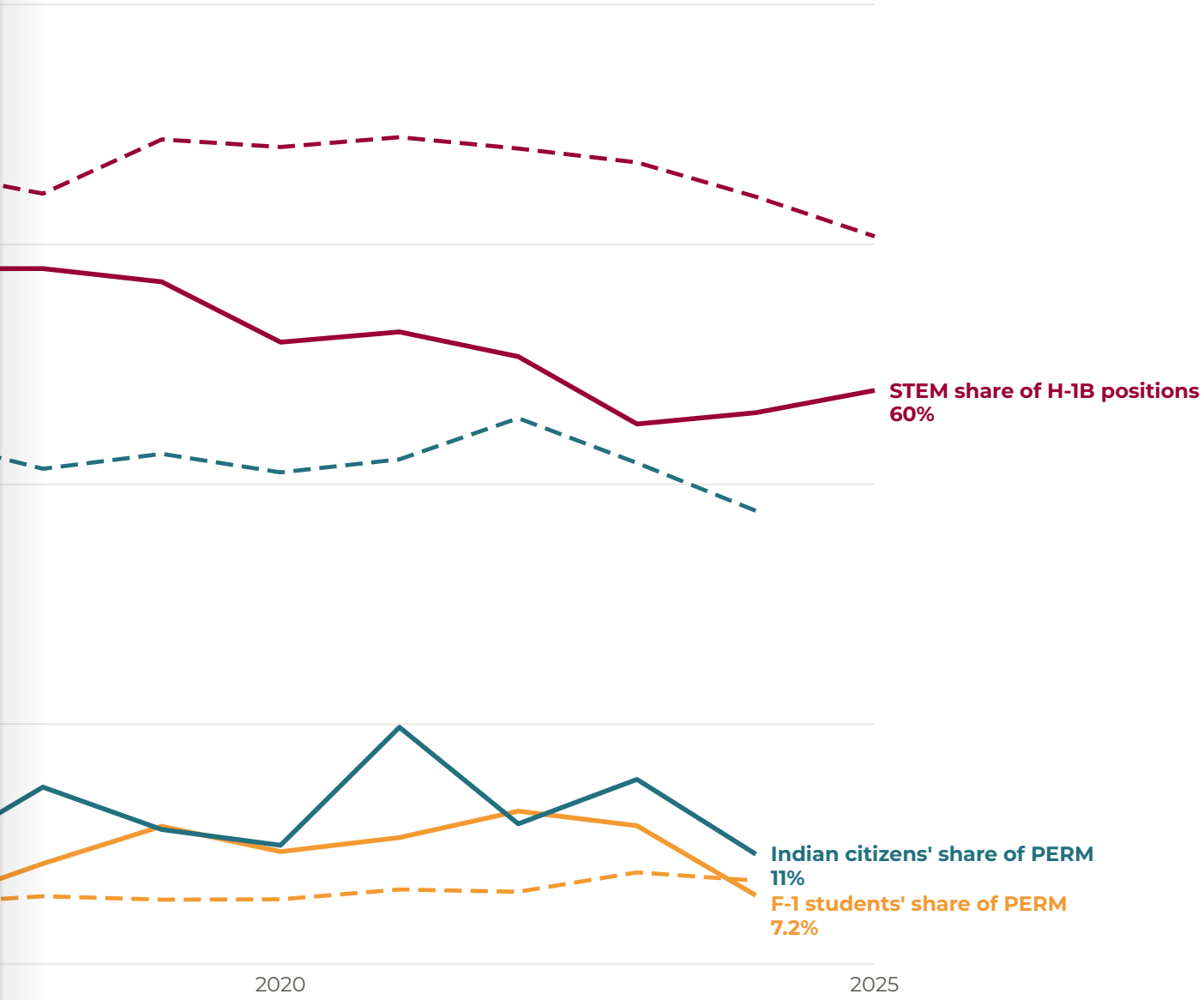


State solid, U.S. dashed. PERM citizenship and class of admission are not on the form DOL uses from FY2025. Data from D

60% of the state's certified H-1B positions were in STEM occupations in FY2025 (U.S. 76%).

Citizens of India held 11% of the state's PERM certifications in FY2024 (U.S. 47%). Under per-country caps they face the longest waits for a green card, so this share measures the state's exposure to the backlog.

d)



OL, Office of Foreign Labor Certification.

60%

STEM share of H-1B positions, 2025

U.S. **76%** · **34th** of 51 · −9.5 pp since 2015

11%

PERM certifications for Indian citizens, 2024

U.S. **47%** · **45th** of 51 · +0.1 pp since 2015

$89.4K

Median offered H-1B wage (nominal), 2025

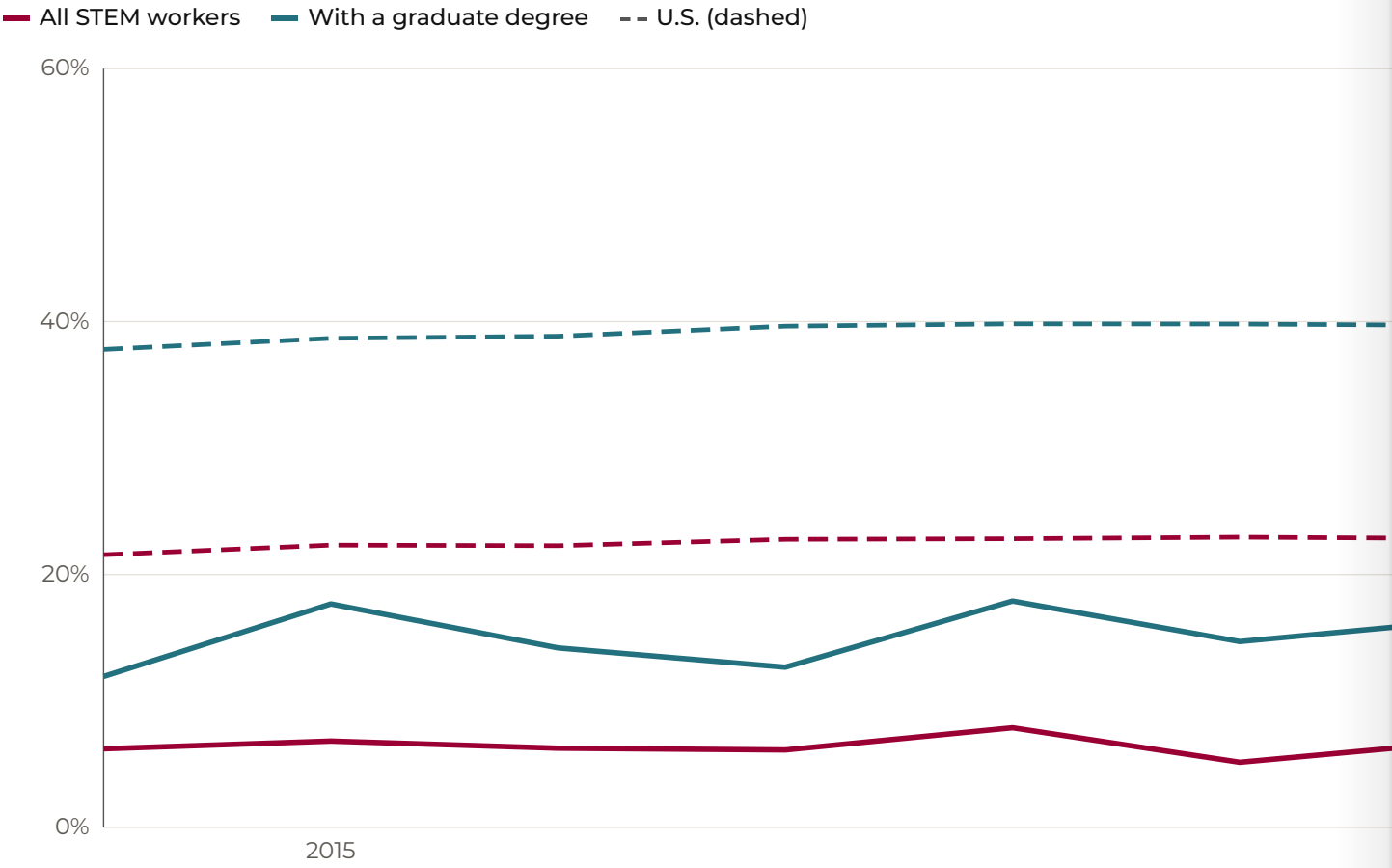
U.S. **$119K** · **43rd** of 51 · +40% since 2015

SECTION 9

STEM Workforce

Alabama ranks 37th of 44 states on the foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree, at 20% in 2024 against 41% for the U.S.

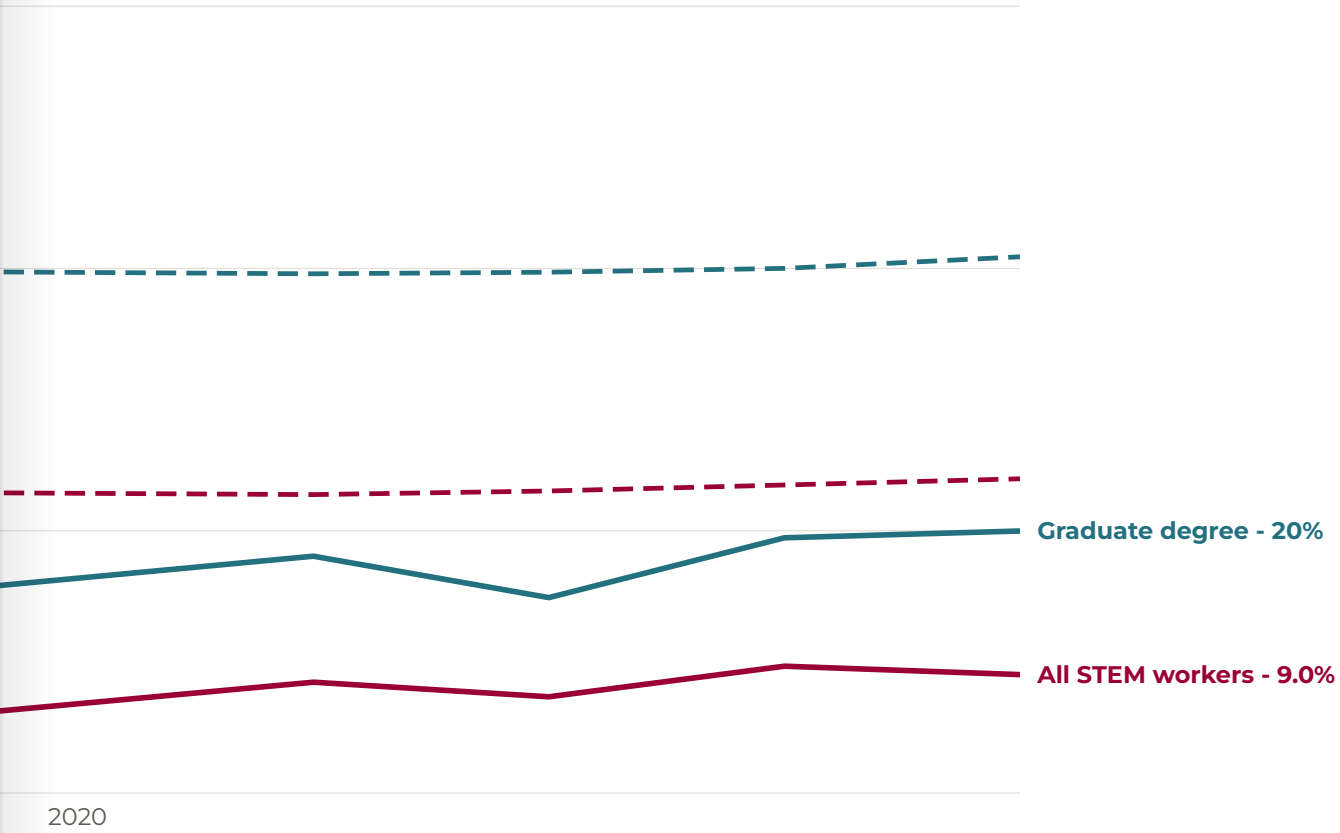
Figure 20 How Much of Alabama's STEM Workforce Was Born Abroad?



Foreign-born share of employed workers in STEM occupations, by state of residence; state solid, U.S. dashed. Shares resti
Community Survey.

In 2024, 9.0% of the people working in STEM occupations in Alabama were born abroad (U.S. 24%; 41st of 51).

The share rises with education: 20% of STEM workers with a graduate degree were foreign-born (U.S. 41%). 3.9% of all STEM workers were not U.S. citizens.



ng on fewer than 100 survey records are left out. No 2020 (experimental data). Data from U.S. Census Bureau, American

9.0%

Foreign-born share of STEM workers, 2024

U.S. **24%** · **41st** of 51 · +2.2 pp since 2015

20%

Foreign-born, STEM workers with grad degrees, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **37th** of 44 · +2.3 pp since 2015

3.9%

Noncitizen share of STEM workers, 2024

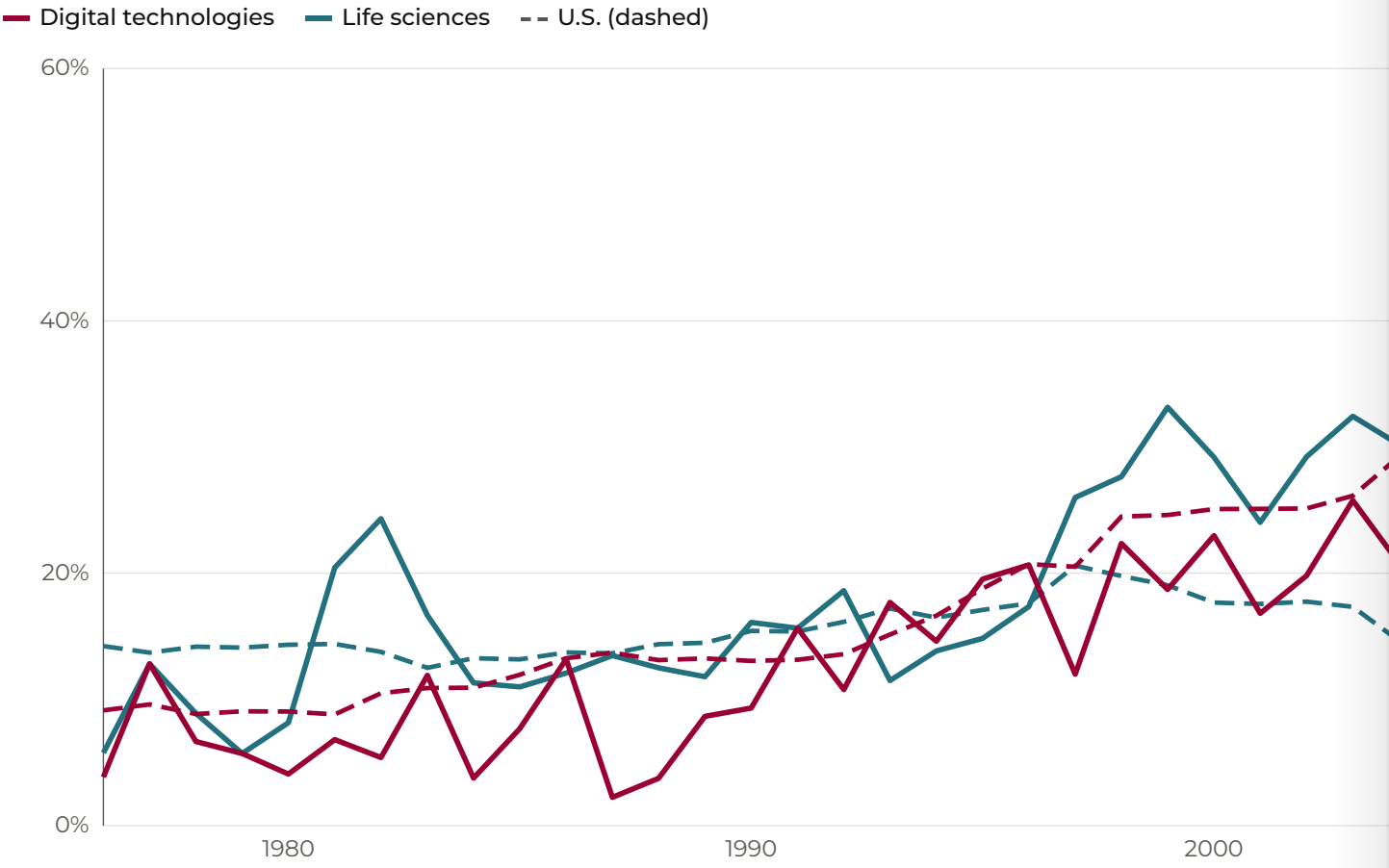
U.S. **11%** · **44th** of 51 · +0.1 pp since 2015

SECTION 10

Patents

Alabama ranks 38th of 51 states on patents granted to assignees in the state, at 278 in 2025 against 135K for the U.S.

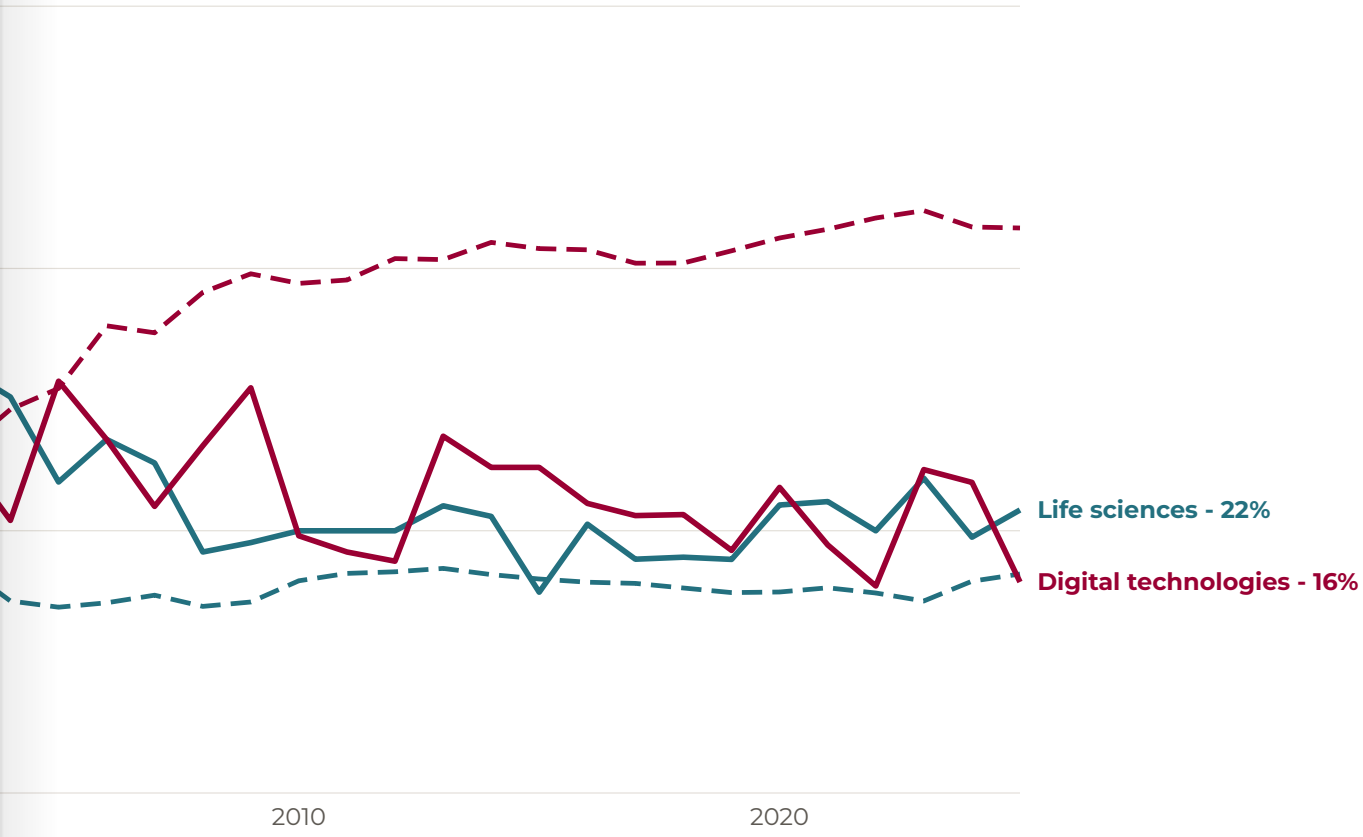
Figure 21 What Kinds of Technology Does Alabama Patent?



Share of patents granted to owners in the state, by WIPO technology field of the first classification; state solid, U.S. dashed

Organizations and people in Alabama were granted 278 U.S. patents in 2025, 0.2% of all patents with a U.S. owner (38th of 51).

16% were in digital technologies (U.S. 43%) and 22% in the life sciences (U.S. 17%).



d. Fractional counts by the owner's (assignee's) location, not where inventors live. Data from USPTO, PatentsView.

278

Patents granted to owners in the state, 2025

U.S. **135K** · **38th** of 51 · −2.6% since 2015

16%

Patents in digital technologies, 2025

U.S. **43%** · **31st** of 51 · −8.7 pp since 2015

22%

Patents in life sciences, 2025

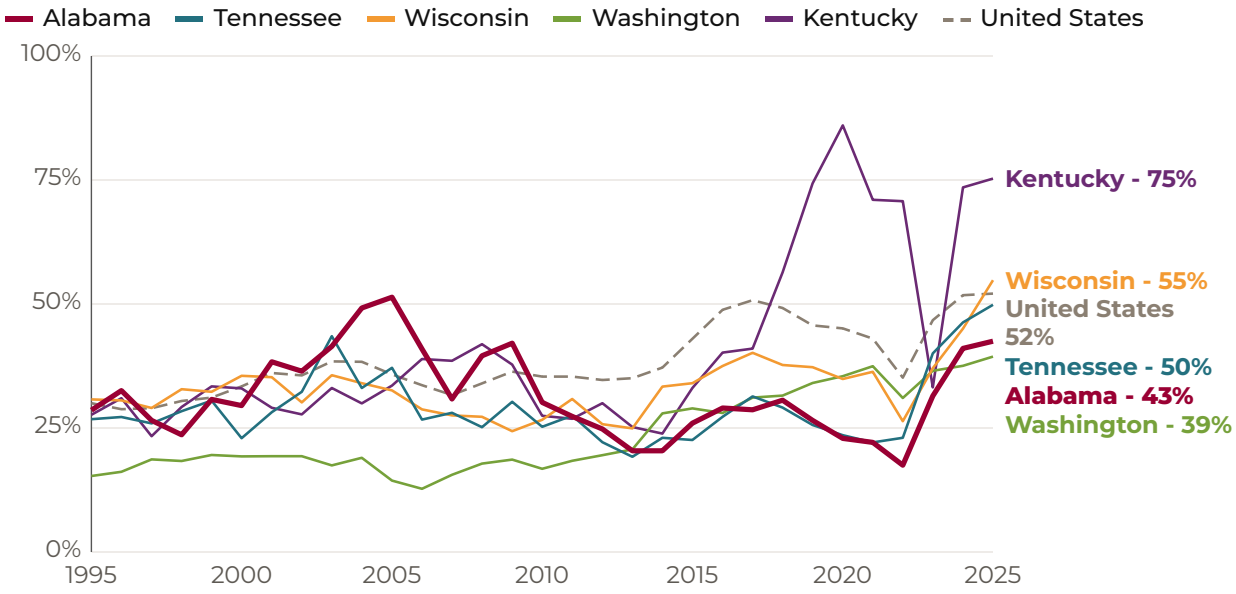
U.S. **17%** · **19th** of 51 · +6.3 pp since 2015

SECTION 11

Competitors

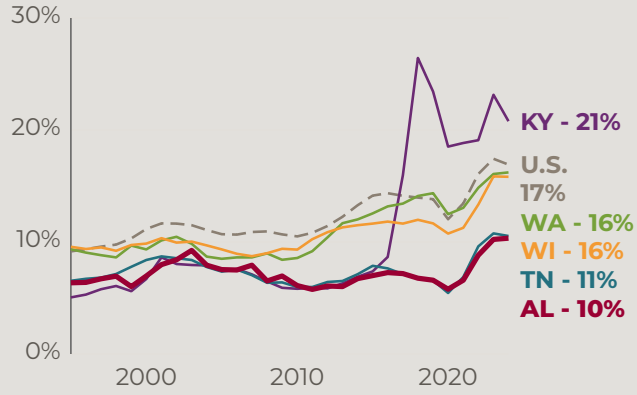
The four states closest in size are Tennessee, Wisconsin, Washington, Kentucky. Alabama ranks 4th of the five on the international share of STEM master's; Kentucky is the most dependent at 75%.

Figure 22 How Dependent Are Alabama and Its Peers on International STEM Master's?



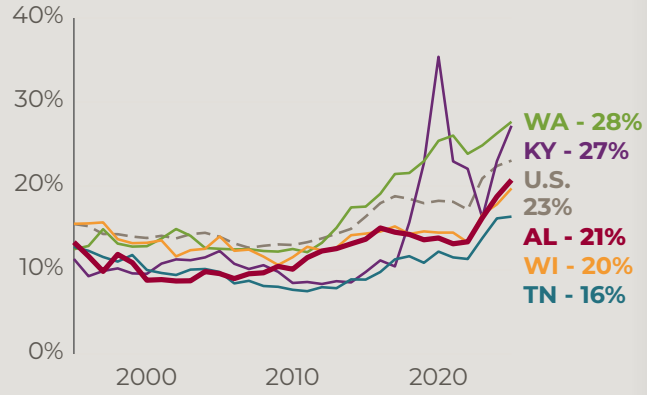
Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Figure 23 Int. share of grad students



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 24 STEM share of master's



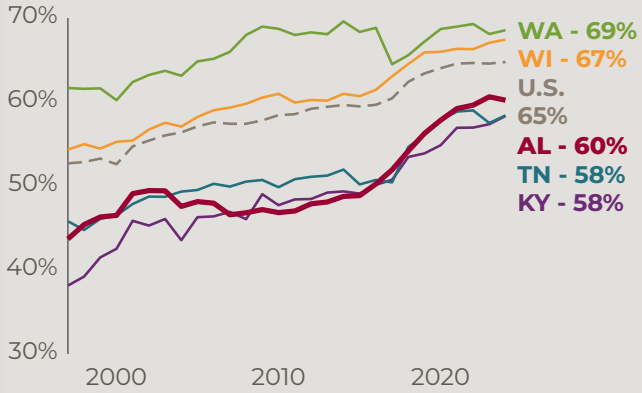
Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Table 4 How Does Alabama Compare With States of Similar Size?

Measure	AL	TN	WI	WA	KY	U.S.
Students enrolled	**311K**	325K	328K	331K	290K	19.7M
Graduate share of students	**18%**	17%	13%	12%	21%	17%
STEM share of bachelor's	**24%**	18%	26%	32%	17%	24%
STEM share of master's	**21%**	16%	20%	28%	27%	23%
International STEM master's	**1.47K**	1.14K	1.29K	1.22K	4.04K	117K
Share of U.S. international STEM master's	**1.3%**	1.0%	1.1%	1.0%	3.5%	–
Int. share of STEM master's	**43%**	50%	55%	39%	75%	52%
Int. share of STEM research doctorates	**49%**	35%	37%	34%	44%	43%
Int. share of grad students	**10%**	11%	16%	16%	21%	17%
Int. share of undergraduate enrollment	**1.5%**	2.0%	2.6%	4.1%	1.4%	3.0%
Six-year graduation rate	**60%**	58%	67%	69%	58%	65%
In-state tuition, public 4-year	**$11.6K**	$11K	$9.42K	$8K	$11.9K	$9.71K
Appropriations per student	**$11.4K**	$12.1K	$11.4K	$11.5K	$7.45K	$11.4K
Average faculty salary	**$86.4K**	$92.8K	$96.1K	$102K	$76.7K	$106K
First-time students from in state	**68%**	76%	73%	85%	77%	–
Net migration per 100 residents	**+23**	+1	+6	−15	+7	–

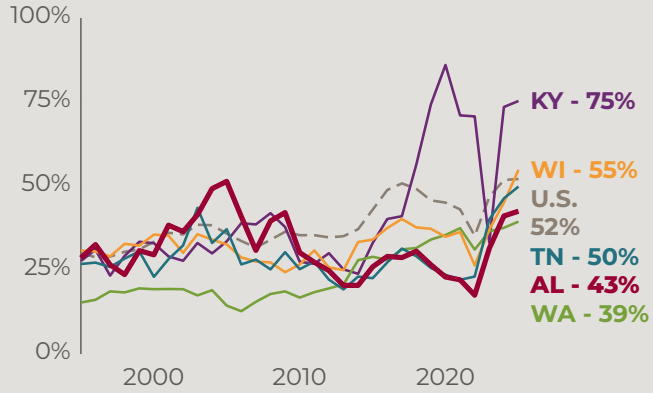
Latest year for each measure. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 25 Six-year graduation rate



Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Figure 26 Int. share of STEM master's

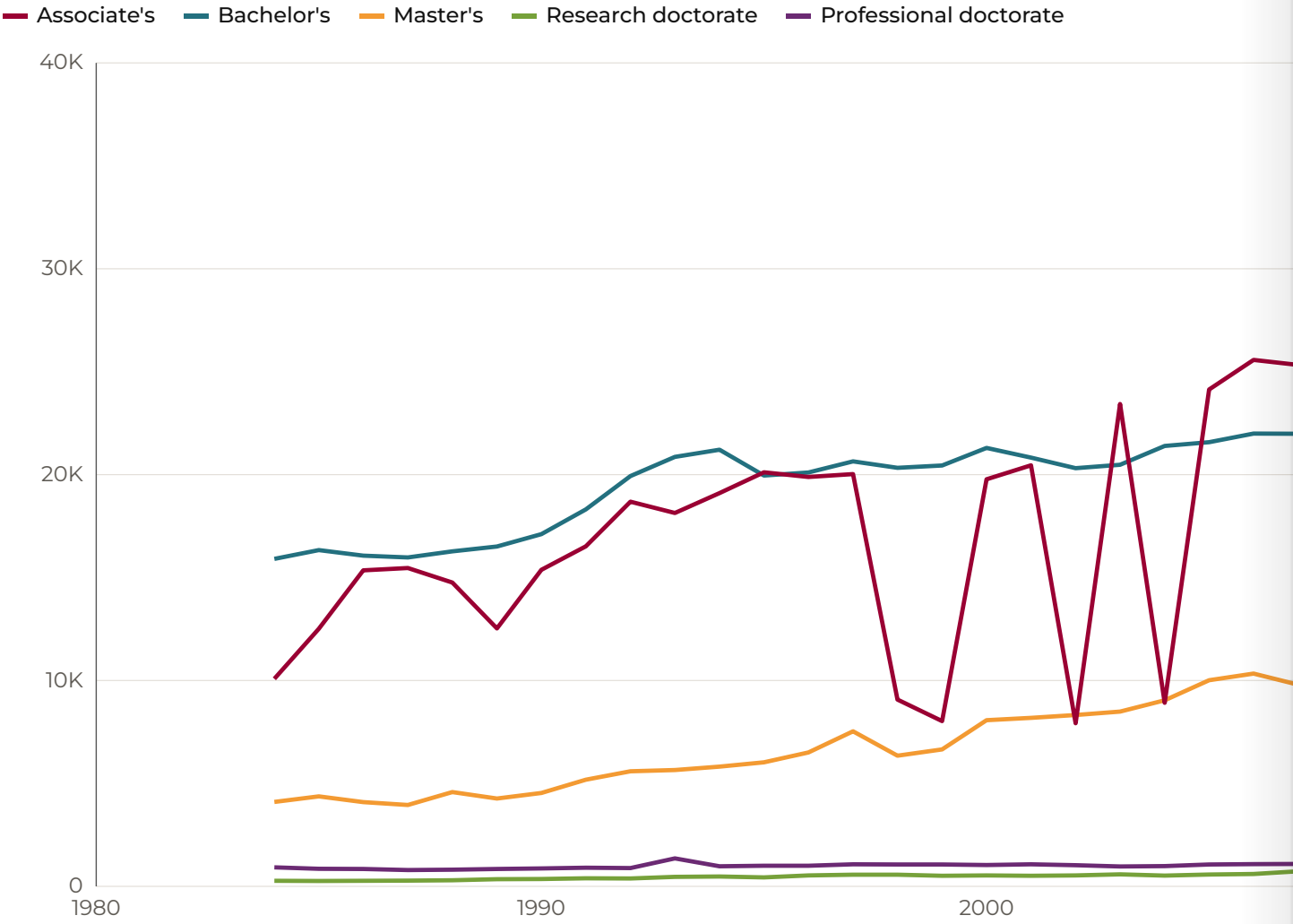


Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 12

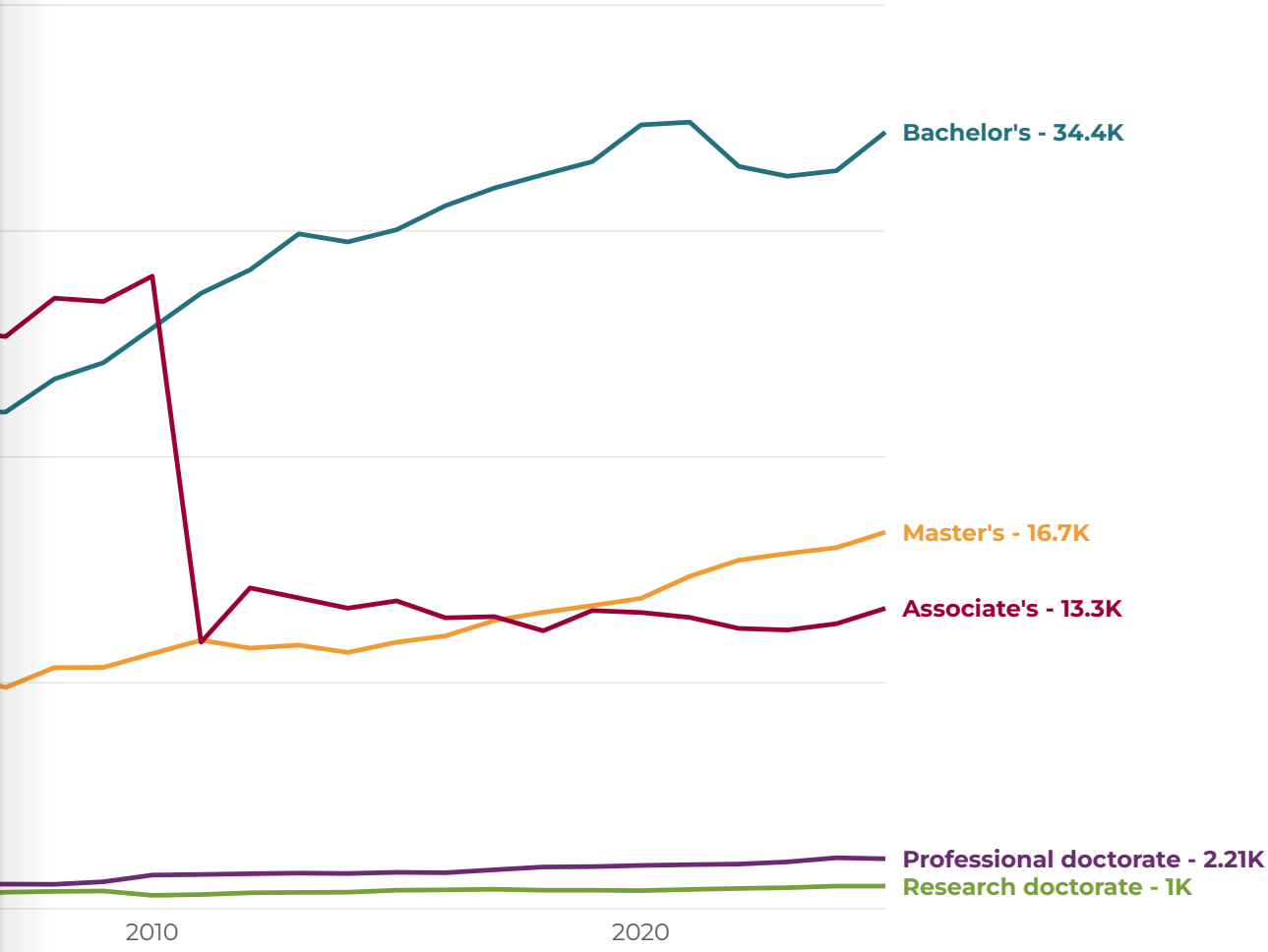
Fields of Study

Figure 27 How Many Degrees Does Alabama Award?



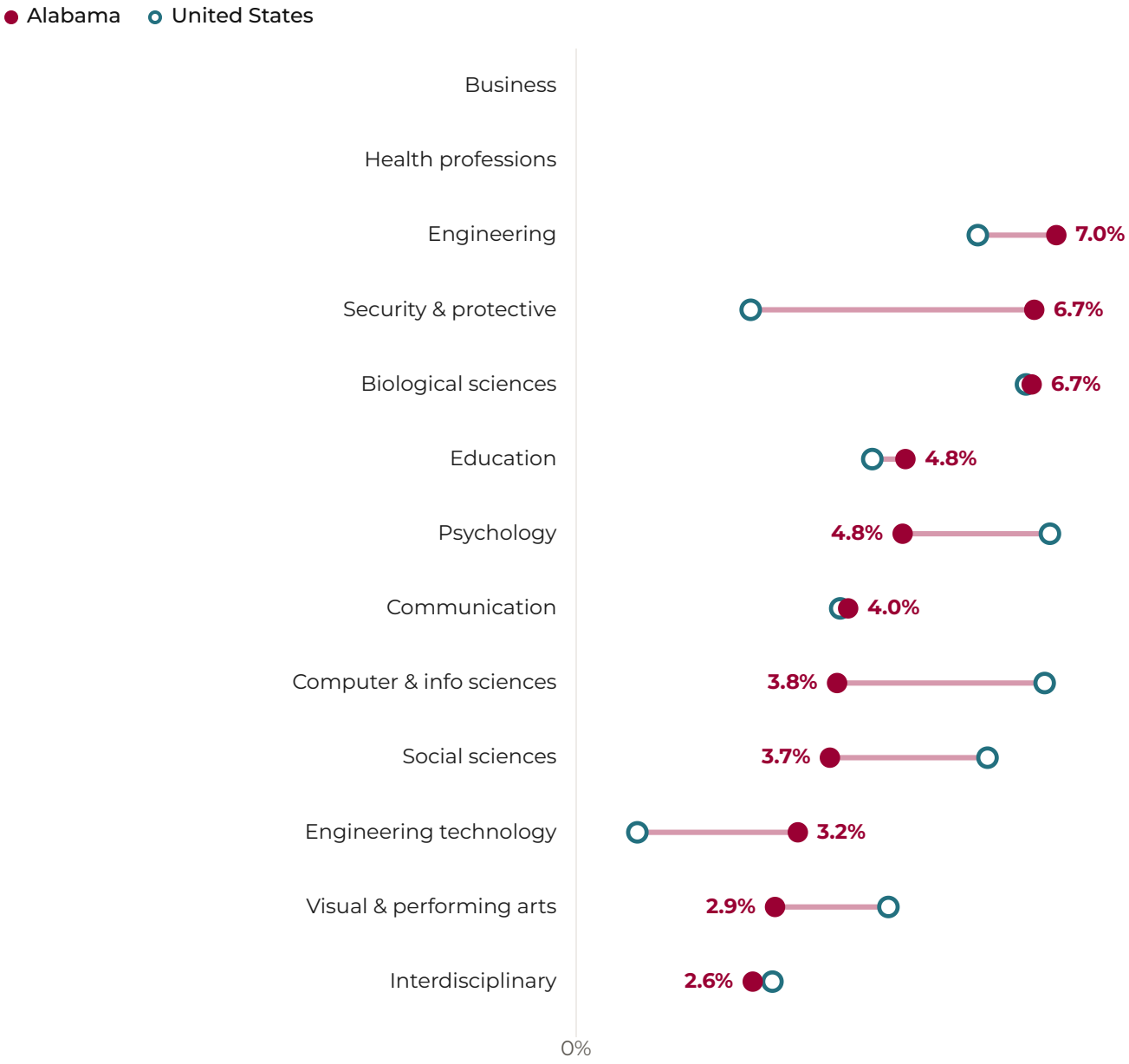
Degrees awarded by level, first majors. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

In 2025, Alabama's institutions awarded 13.3K associate's degrees, 34.4K bachelor's degrees, 16.7K master's degrees, 1K research doctorate degrees, 2.21K professional doctorate degrees.



Since 2015: associate's down 2%; bachelor's up 14%; master's up 41%; research doctorate up 23%; professional doctorate up 37%. The state awards 13.4 bachelor's degrees for every 100 undergraduates (U.S. 12.3).

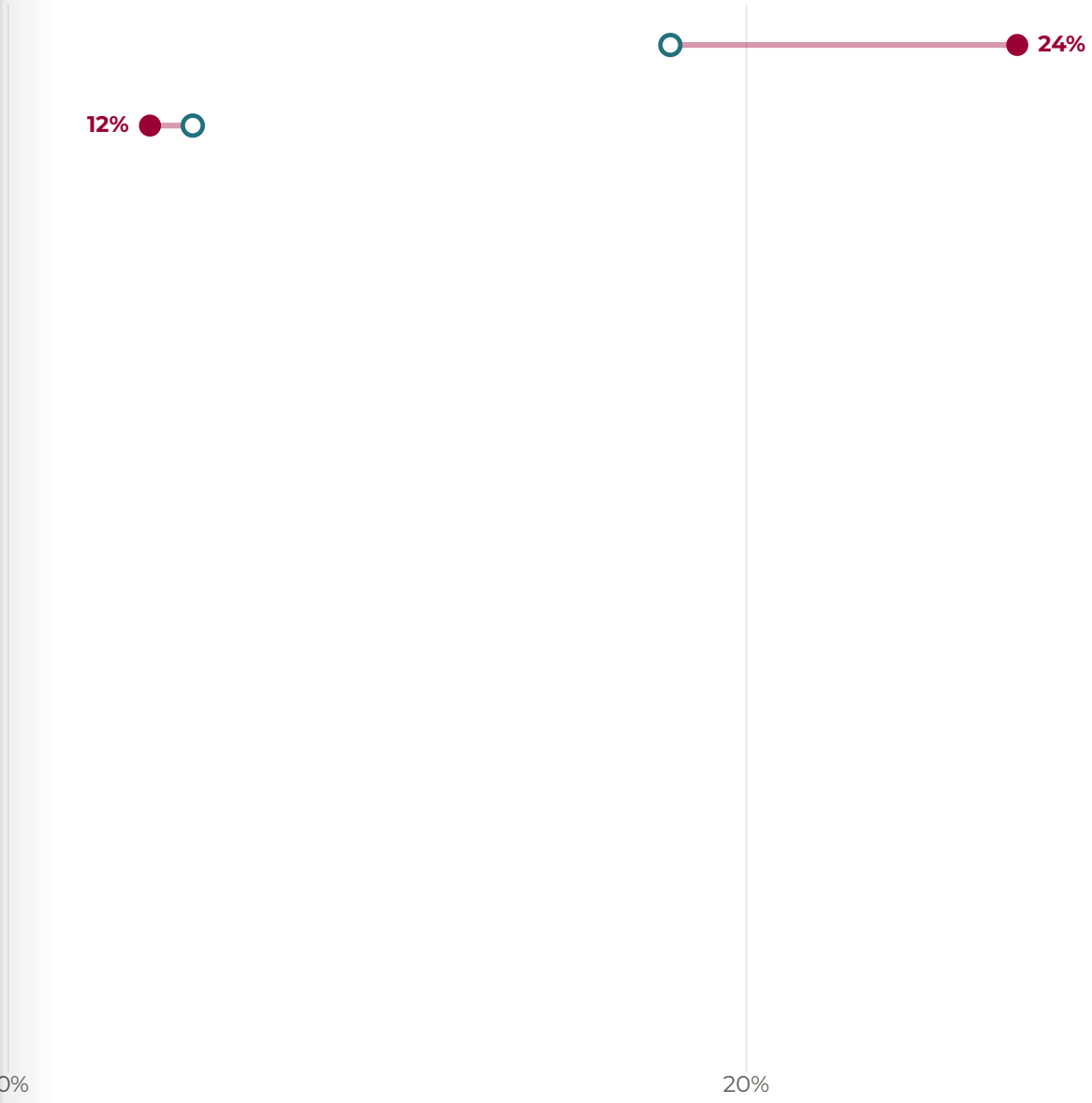
Figure 28 What Do Alabama's Bachelor's Graduates Study?



Share of bachelor's degrees by field, 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Alabama's largest bachelor's fields are business (24%; U.S. 19%), health professions (12%; U.S. 13%), engineering (7.0%; U.S. 5.9%).

Relative to the nation, Alabama's bachelor's degrees are most concentrated in engineering technology (3.62× the U.S. share), family & consumer sci. (2.63× the U.S. share), security & protective (2.63× the U.S. share).



3.8%

Bachelor's in computer science, 2025

U.S. **6.9%** · **41st** of 51 · +1.5 pp since 2015

10%

Bachelor's in engineering, 2025

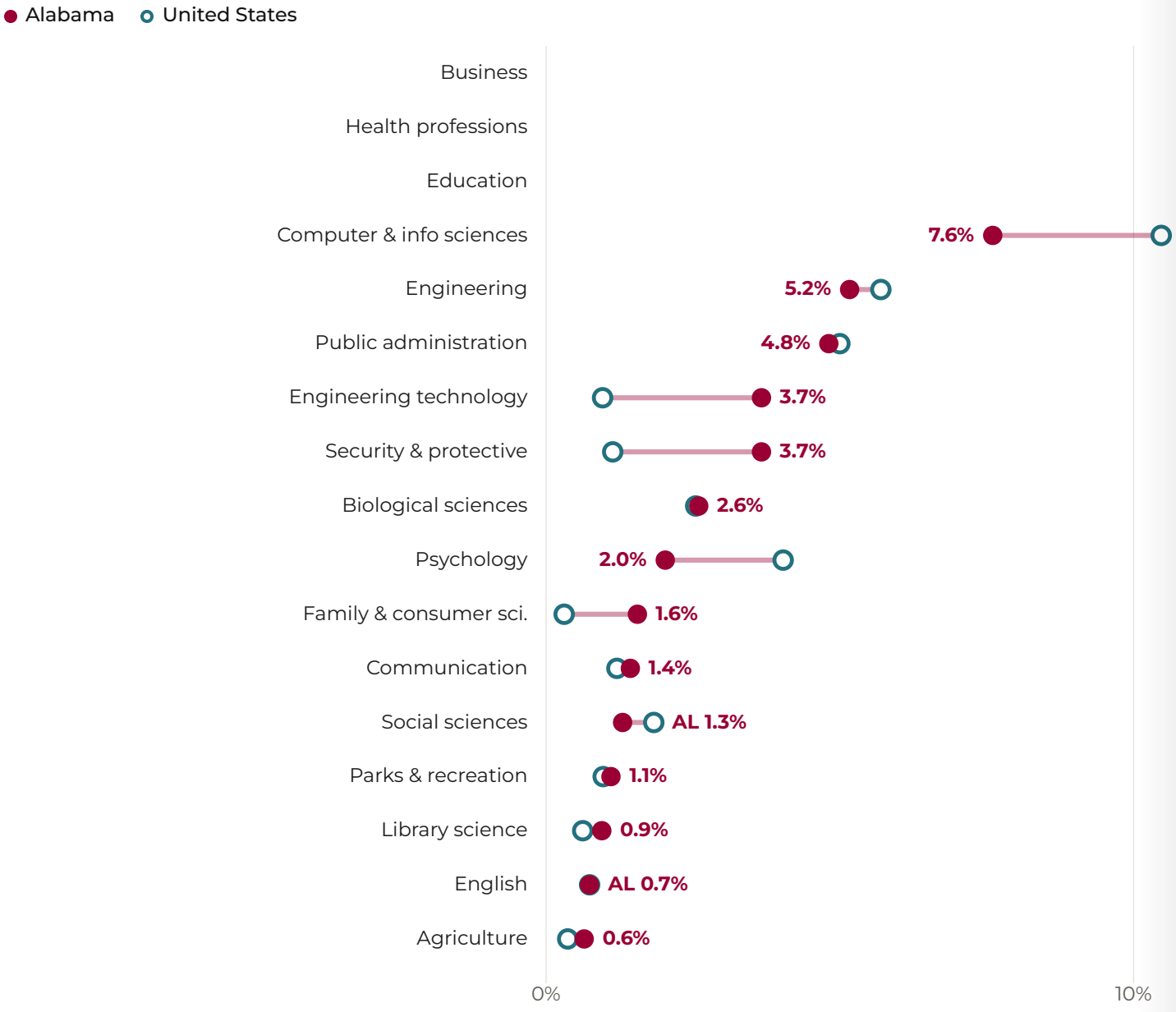
U.S. **6.8%** · **4th** of 51 · +1.1 pp since 2015

24%

Bachelor's in business, 2025

U.S. **19%** · **6th** of 51 · −0.3 pp since 2015

Figure 29 What Do Alabama's Master's Graduates Study?



Share of master's degrees by field, 2025; largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Alabama's largest master's fields are business (26%; U.S. 21%), health professions (18%; U.S. 15%), education (14%; U.S. 15%).

International students earn 11% of all master's degrees in the state (U.S. 22%), and STEM fields account for 21% of them.



21%

STEM share of master's, 2025

U.S. **23%** · **26th** of 51 · +7.0 pp since 2015

11%

Int. share of all master's, 2025

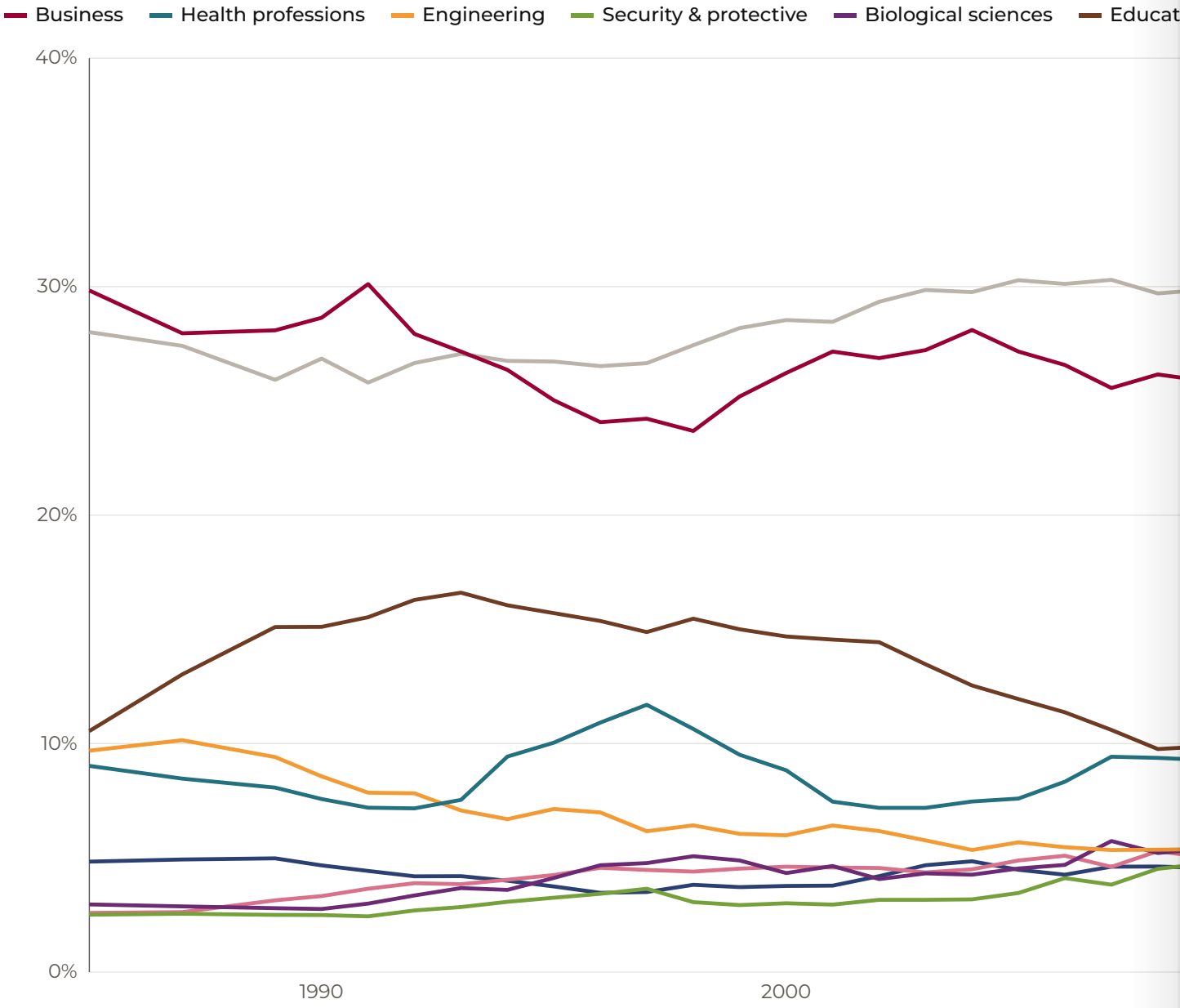
U.S. **22%** · **36th** of 51 · +4.7 pp since 2015

82%

Int. share of CS master's, 2025

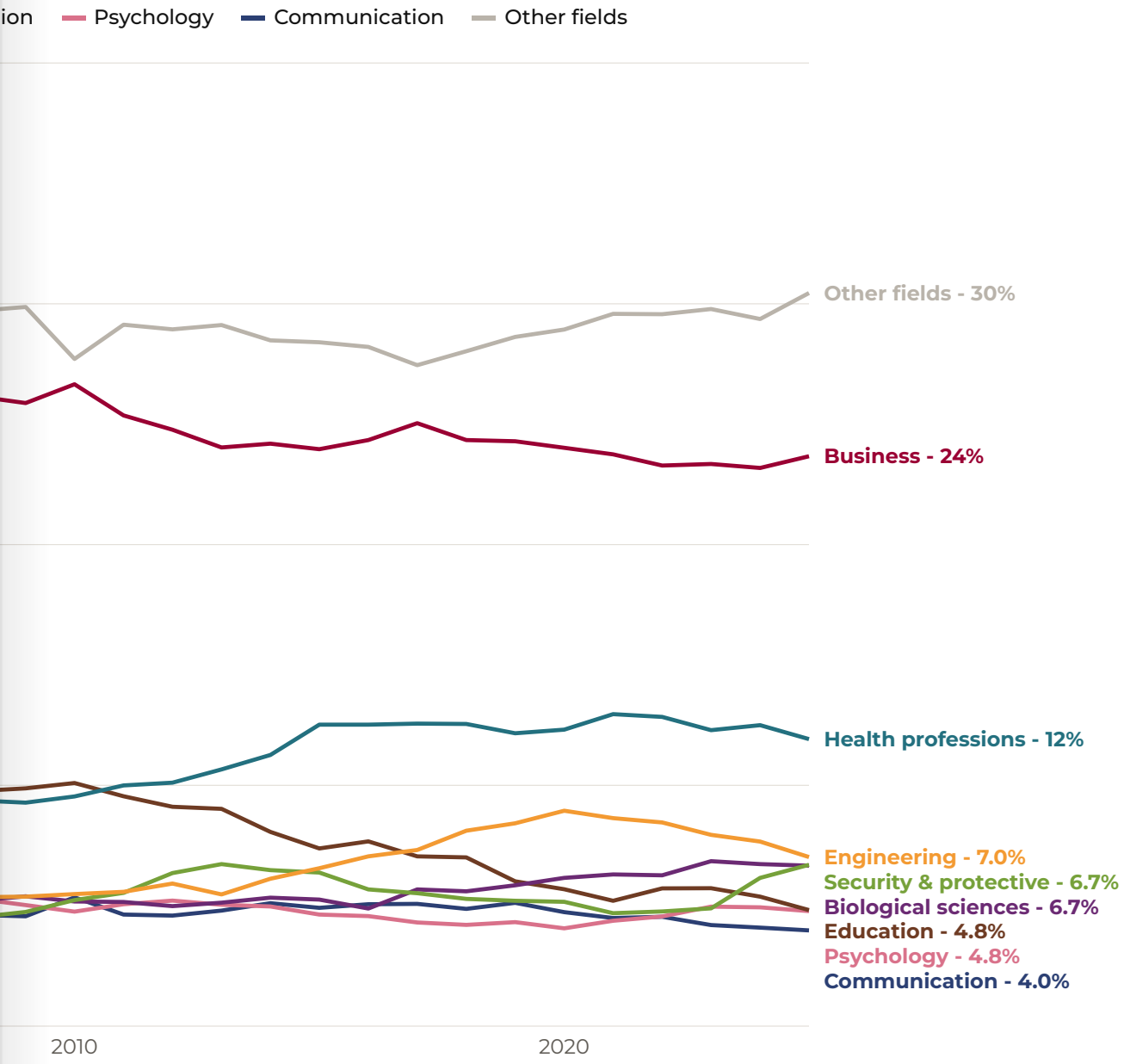
U.S. **65%** · **9th** of 47 · +32.0 pp since 2015

Figure 30 How Has Alabama's Bachelor's Field Mix Changed?



Share of bachelor's degrees in the largest fields. Data from NCES, IPEDS Completions.

Since 2015, biological sciences has gained the most ground, 1.4 points of the state's bachelor's degrees, while education lost the most (2.6 points).



The chart follows the share of bachelor's degrees in each of the state's largest fields; smaller fields are grouped as other fields.

SECTION 12 · FIELDS OF STUDY

Where Is Alabama Specialized, and What Do Its Doctoral Graduates Study?

The location quotient divides a field's share of Alabama's bachelor's degrees by its share of all U.S. bachelor's degrees in 2025. A quotient of 1.00 means the same share as the nation; 2.00 means twice the national share. The table lists the 10 fields with the highest quotients among fields with at least 50 degrees.

Highest location quotients. Engineering technology (3.62, with 3.2% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 0.9% for the U.S.), family & consumer sci. (2.63, with 2.2% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 0.8% for the U.S.), and security & protective (2.63, with 6.7% of the state's bachelor's degrees against 2.6% for the U.S.) had the highest quotients.

Table 5 Where Is Alabama Most Specialized?

Field	Location quotient	State share	U.S. share	Degrees
Engineering technology	**3.62**	3.2%	0.9%	1.11K
Family & consumer sci.	**2.63**	2.2%	0.8%	742
Security & protective	**2.63**	6.7%	2.6%	2.3K
Transportation	**1.40**	0.5%	0.4%	175
Business	**1.25**	24%	19%	8.14K
Engineering	**1.20**	7.0%	5.9%	2.42K
Education	**1.11**	4.8%	4.3%	1.66K
Communication	**1.03**	4.0%	3.9%	1.37K
Biological sciences	**1.01**	6.7%	6.6%	2.29K
Architecture	**0.98**	0.6%	0.6%	192

Bachelor's degrees; location quotient = state share ÷ U.S. share; fields with 50+ degrees. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

24%
STEM share of bachelor's, 2025
U.S. **24%** · **23rd** of 51

3.8%
Bachelor's in computer science, 2025
U.S. **6.9%** · **41st** of 51

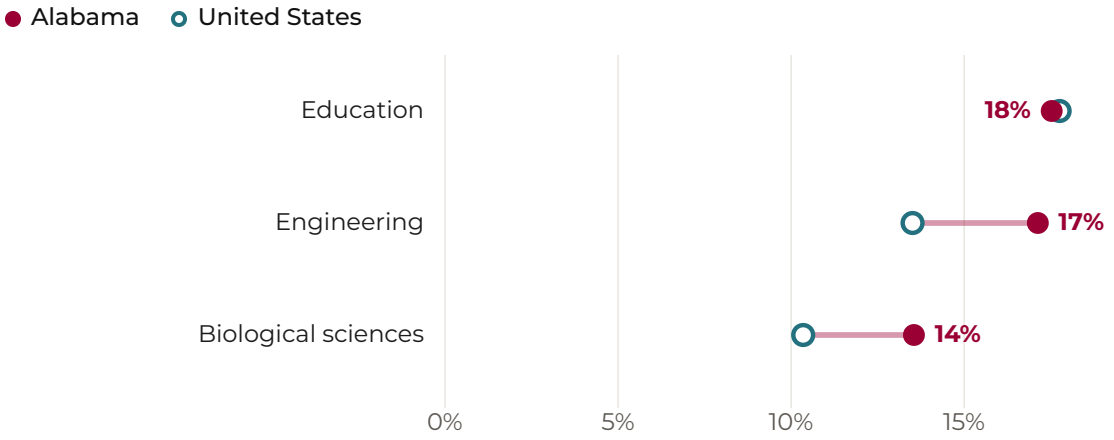
10%
Bachelor's in engineering, 2025
U.S. **6.8%** · **4th** of 51

24%
Bachelor's in business, 2025
U.S. **19%** · **6th** of 51

Each row is a field's share of the research doctorates awarded in Alabama in 2025 (filled dot), against its share nationally (open dot), for the ten largest fields with at least 20 doctorates. Research doctorates exclude professional doctorates such as the M.D. and J.D.

Largest doctoral fields. The state's largest doctoral fields were education (18% of research doctorates, against 18% for the U.S.), engineering (17% of research doctorates, against 14% for the U.S.), and biological sciences (14% of research doctorates, against 10% for the U.S.).

Figure 31 What Do Alabama's Doctoral Graduates Study?



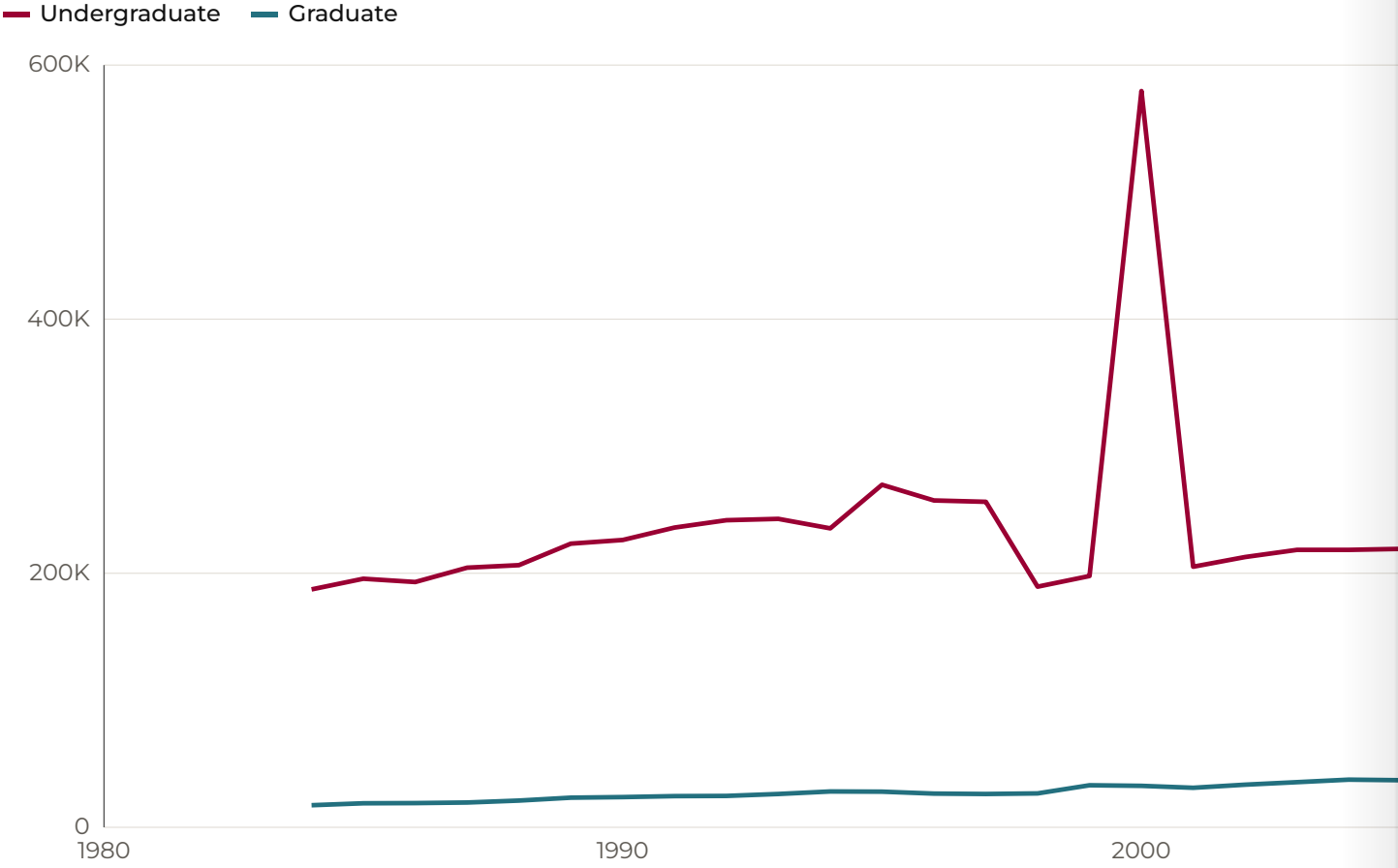
Share of research doctorates by field, 2025; fields with 20+ doctorates. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 13

Students and Money

Alabama ranks 37th of 51 states on the share of students enrolled part-time, at 35% in 2024 against 39% for the U.S.

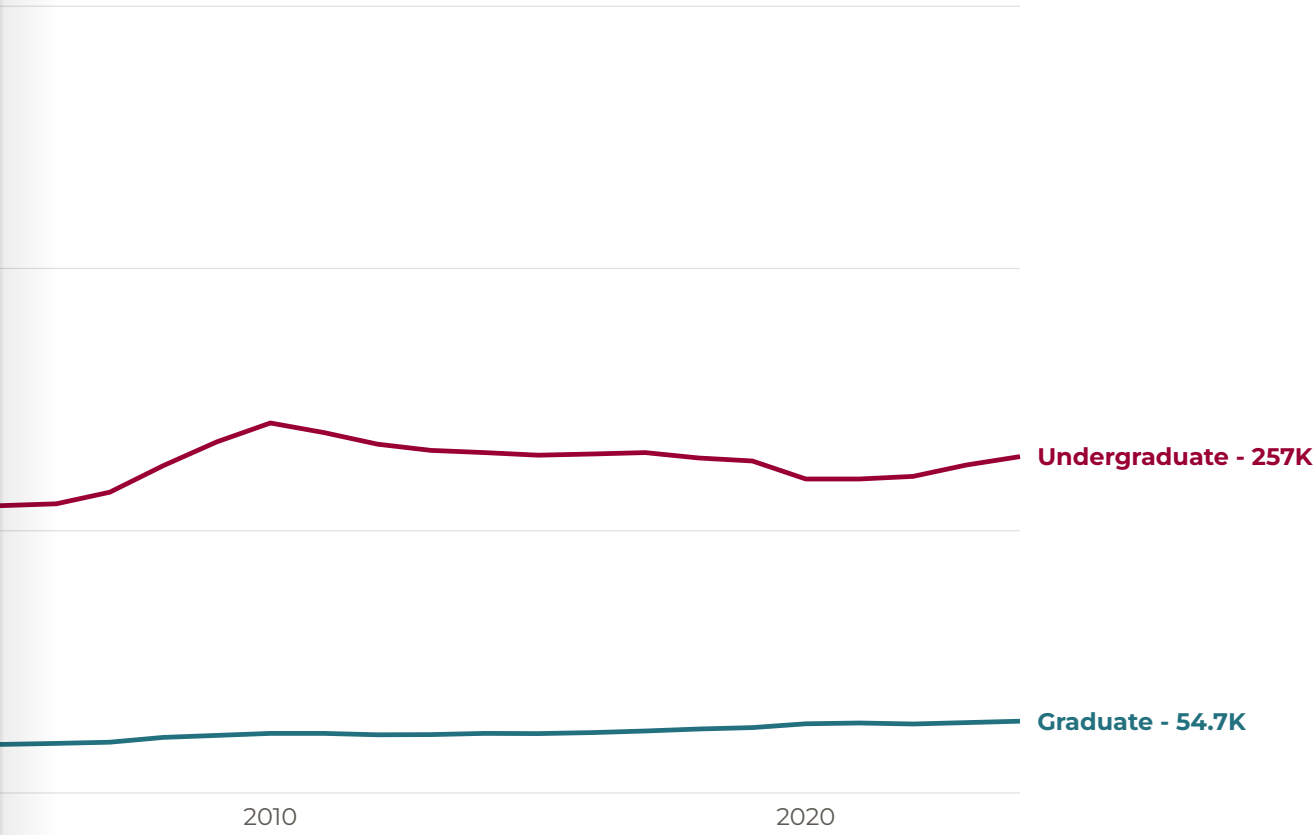
Figure 32 How Has Enrollment Changed?



Fall headcount enrollment. Data from NCES, IPEDS Fall Enrollment.

In fall 2024, Alabama enrolled 257K undergraduates and 54.7K graduate students, 311K in all (24th of 51).

Undergraduate enrollment is roughly flat since 2015 and graduate enrollment up 21% since 2015. Graduate students are 18% of all students (U.S. 17%).



311K

Students enrolled, 2024

U.S. **19.7M** · **24th** of 51 · +2.7% since 2015

18%

Graduate share of students, 2024

U.S. **17%** · **18th** of 51 · +2.6 pp since 2015

35%

Students attending part-time, 2024

U.S. **39%** · **37th** of 51 · +3.2 pp since 2015

SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

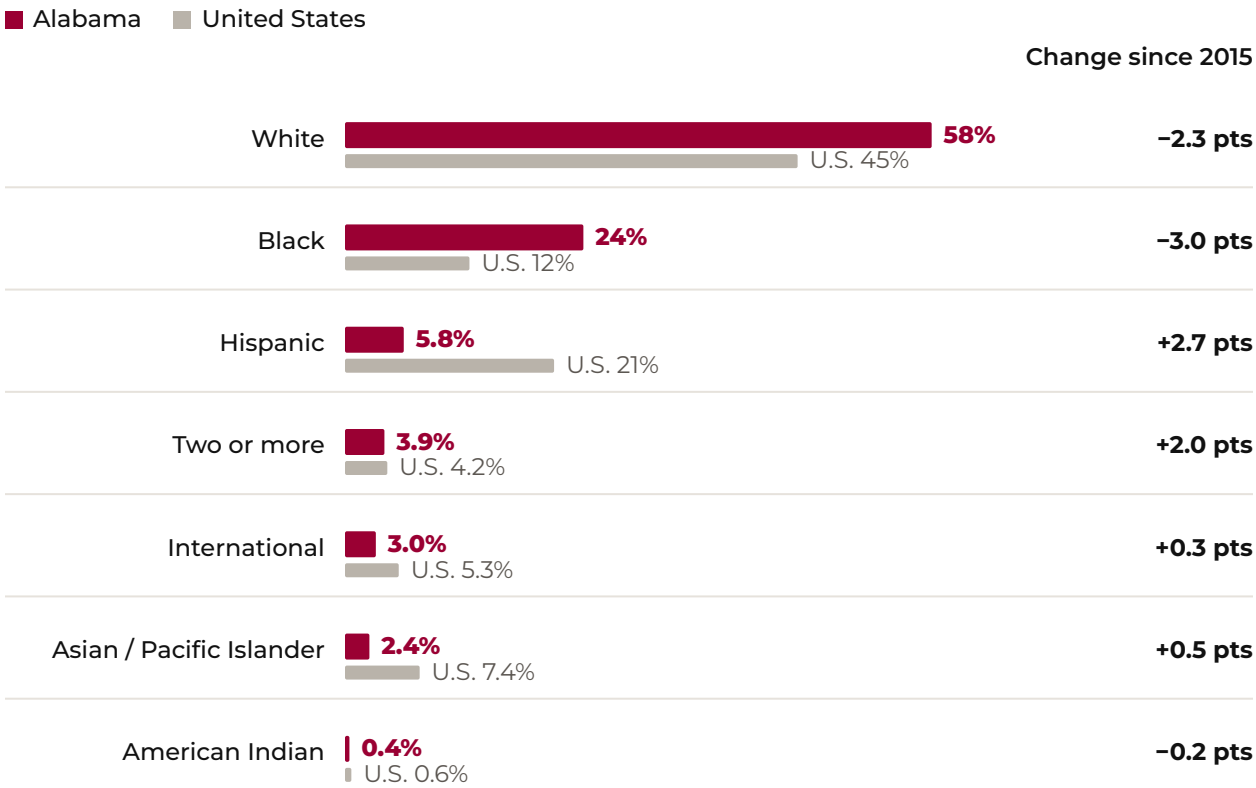
Who Enrolls in Alabama, and Where?

In fall 2024, White students were the largest group at Alabama's degree-granting institutions, **58%** of enrollment against 45% nationally, down 2.3 points since 2015.

Black students were **24%** (U.S. 12%), down 3.0 points since 2015, and Hispanic students were **5.8%** (U.S. 21%), up 2.7 points since 2015.

Students of two or more races were **3.9%** (U.S. 4.2%), up 2.0 points since 2015, and International students were **3.0%** (U.S. 5.3%), up 0.3 points since 2015. "International" counts U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, whatever their race.

Figure 33 Who Enrolls in Alabama?



Share of fall 2024 headcount enrollment by race and ethnicity; students of unknown race are left out of the chart. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

58%
White students
U.S. **45%** · −2.3 pp since 2015

24%
Black students
U.S. **12%** · −3.0 pp since 2015

58%
At public 4-year institutions
+3.6 pp since 2015

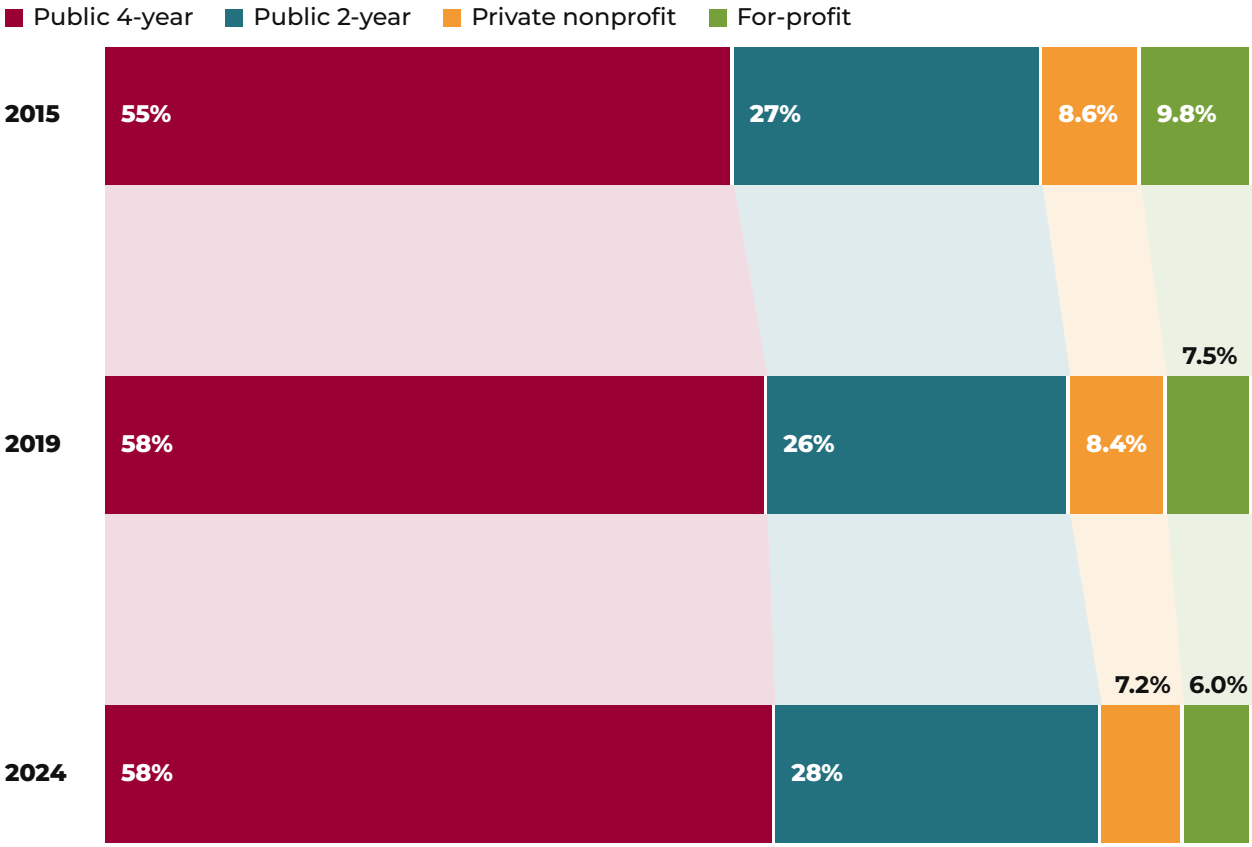
28%
At public 2-year institutions
+1.5 pp since 2015

In fall 2024, public 4-year institutions enrolled **58%** of students, up 3.6 points from 55% in 2015. Public 2-year institutions enrolled **28%** of students, up 1.5 points from 27% in 2015.

Private nonprofit institutions enrolled **7.2%** of students, down 1.4 points from 8.6% in 2015, and for-profit institutions enrolled **6.0%** of students, down 3.7 points from 9.8% in 2015.

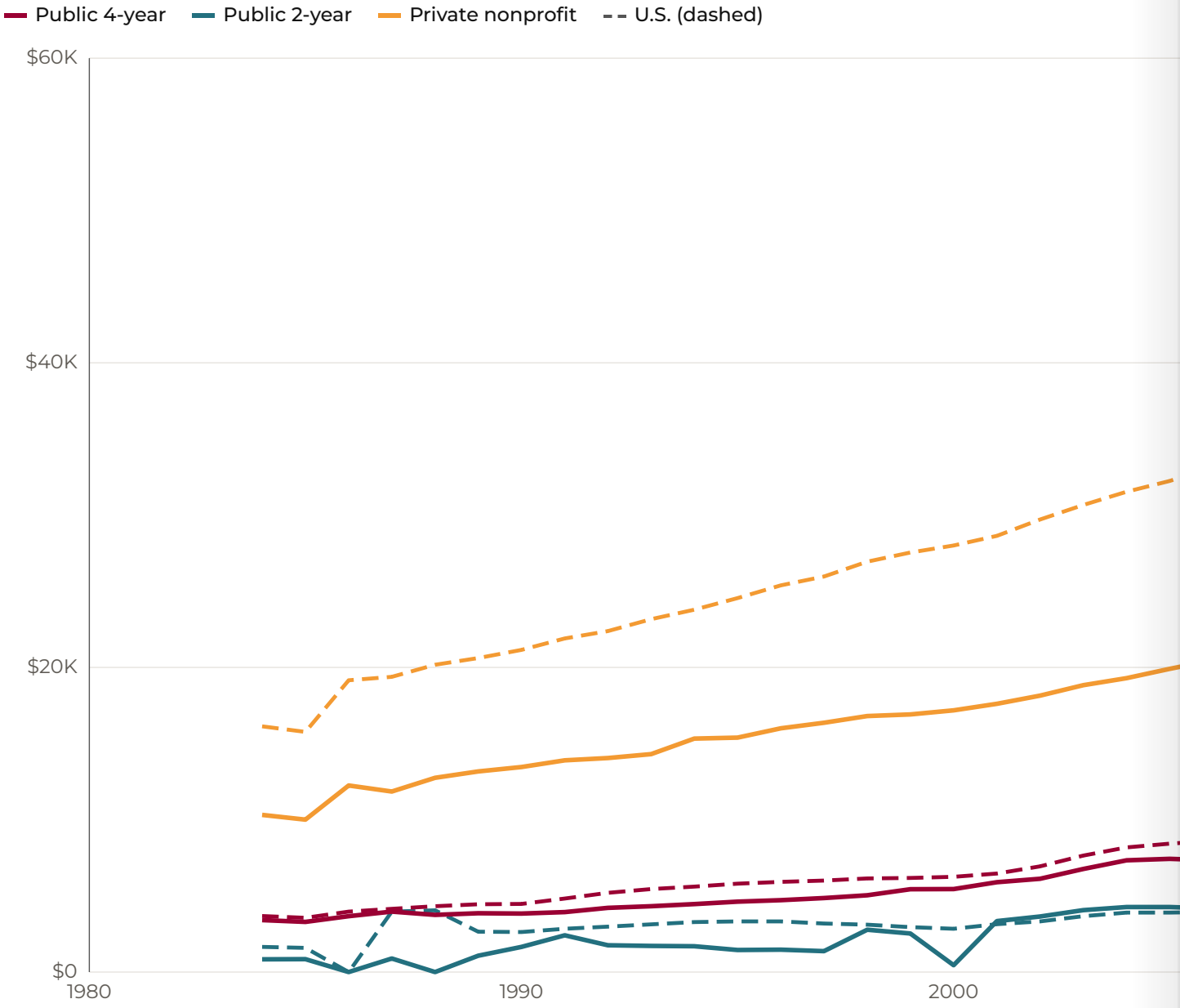
Public institutions together enrolled **87%** of students, against 73% nationally, 13th among the states.

Figure 34 Where Do Students Enroll?



Share of fall headcount enrollment by sector, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

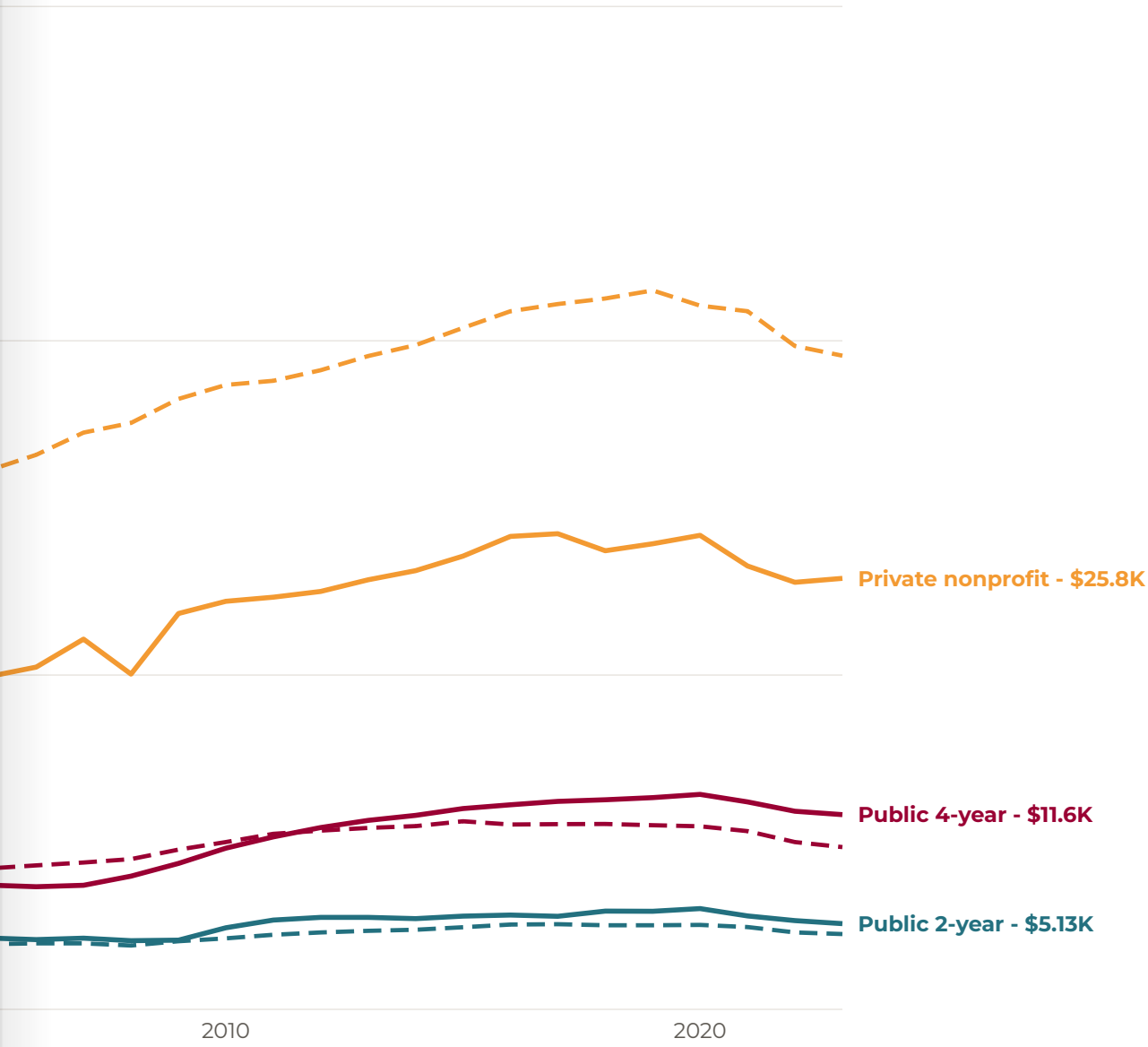
Figure 35 What Does In-State Tuition Cost?



Published in-state tuition and fees, 2024 dollars (CPI-U); state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

In-state tuition and fees at Alabama's public four-year institutions are $11.6K (2023, 2024 dollars), 20% above the U.S. ($9.71K); the state ranks 16th of 51.

State and local appropriations come to $11.4K per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions (20th of 51), and tuition makes up 47% of their core revenue (U.S. 43%).



$11.6K

In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023

U.S. **$9.71K** · **16th** of 51 · −3.0% since 2015

$11.4K

Appropriations per student, 2024

U.S. **$11.4K** · **20th** of 51 · +25% since 2015

47%

Tuition share of public revenue, 2024

U.S. **43%** · **25th** of 51 · −9.3 pp since 2015

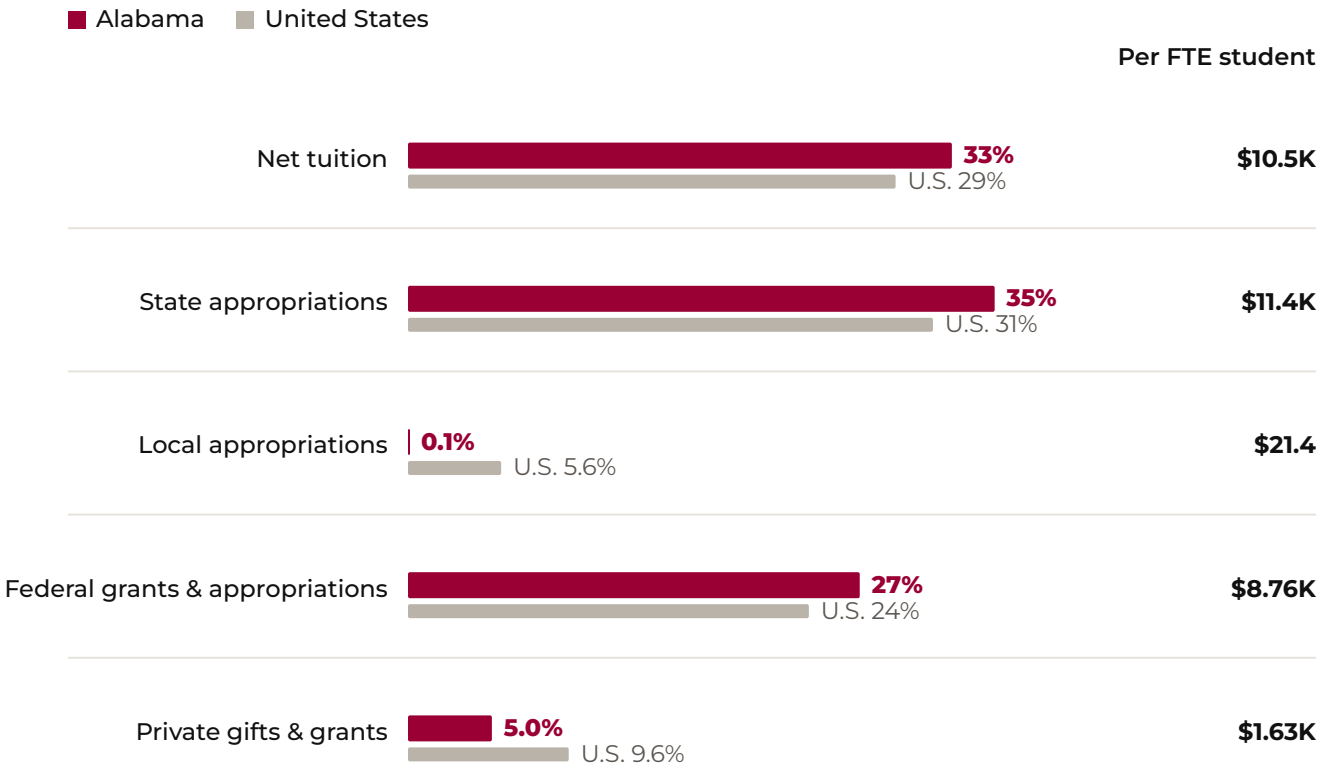
SECTION 13 · STUDENTS AND MONEY

How Are Alabama's Public Institutions Funded, and What Do They Produce?

The bars give each source's share of the core revenue of Alabama's public institutions, with the nation for comparison, and at right the dollars per full-time-equivalent (FTE) student it provides. Values are in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Net tuition is tuition and fees after institutional discounts and allowances.

Net tuition per FTE student. The figure was $10.5K in FY2024, against $8.96K for the U.S., down 1.9% from $10.8K in FY2023 and down 9.1% since FY2015, when it was $11.6K.

Figure 36 How Are Public Institutions Funded?



Share of core revenue per FTE student by source, public institutions, FY2024; dollars per FTE at right, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data from NCES, IPEDS Finance.

$11.6K
In-state tuition, public 4-year, 2023
U.S. **$9.71K** · **16th** of 51

$11.4K
Appropriations per student, 2024
U.S. **$11.4K** · **20th** of 51

47%
Tuition share of public revenue, 2024
U.S. **43%** · **25th** of 51

60%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **30th** of 51

The table brings together five measures of what public higher education costs and what it produces in Alabama: in-state tuition at public four-year institutions, state and local appropriations per full-time-equivalent student, tuition's share of public institutions' core revenue, the six-year bachelor's graduation rate, and the average full-time faculty salary.

In-state tuition, public 4-year. The figure was $11.6K in 2023, against $9.71K for the U.S., 16th among the states, down 1.8% from $11.9K in 2022 and down 3.0% since 2015, when it was $12K.

Table 6 Money and Results

Measure	Year	Alabama	U.S.	Rank	Change since 2015
In-state tuition, public 4-year	2023	**$11.6K**	$9.71K	16th of 51	−3.0%
Appropriations per student	2024	**$11.4K**	$11.4K	20th of 51	+25%
Tuition share of public revenue	2024	**47%**	43%	25th of 51	−9.3 pp
Six-year graduation rate	2024	**60%**	65%	30th of 51	+11.4 pp
Average faculty salary	2024	**$86.4K**	$106K	37th of 51	−6.7%

Rank among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 14

Student Outcomes

Alabama ranks 16th of 51 states on bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates, at 13.4 in 2025 against 12.3 for the U.S.

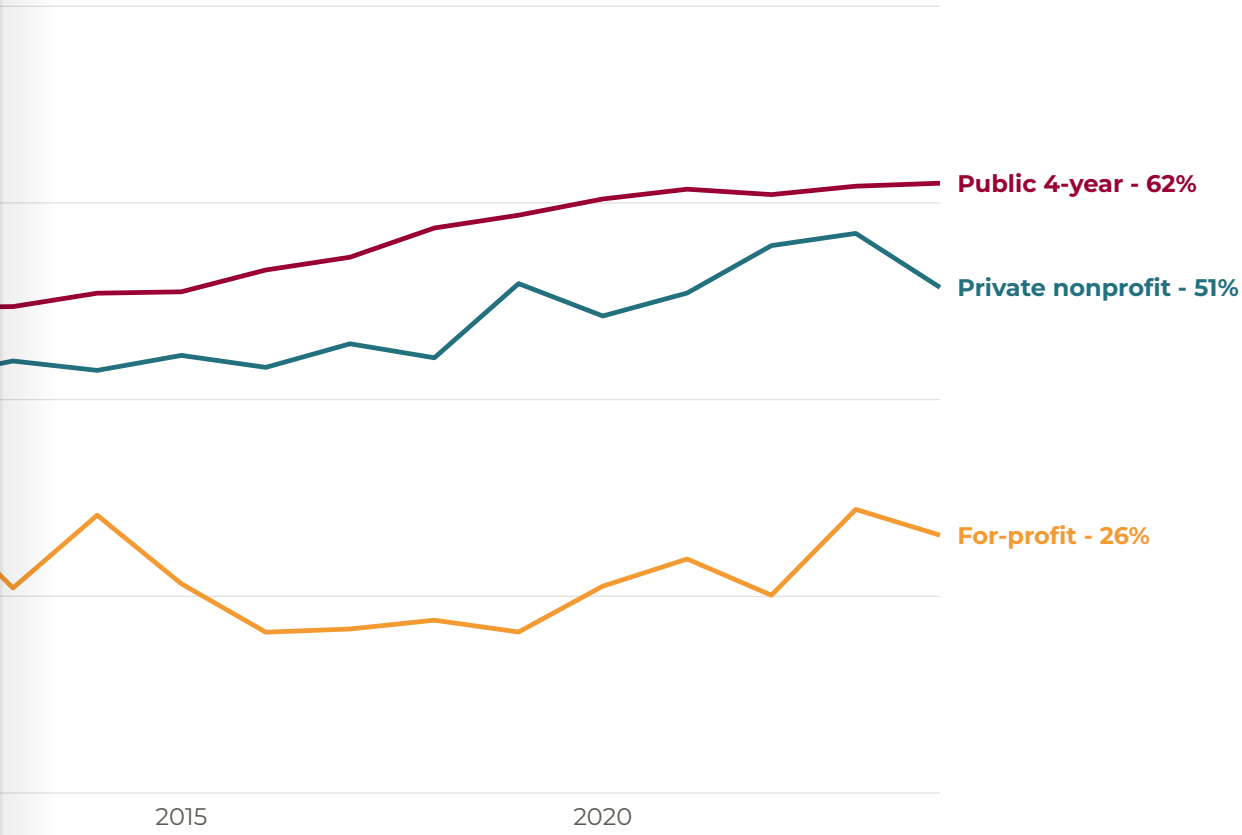
Figure 37 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Sector?



Six-year bachelor's graduation rate by sector of institution. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

60% of students who started a bachelor's degree at a four-year institution in Alabama graduated within six years (2024), 4.6 points below the U.S. (65%); the state ranks 30th of 51.

By sector: public 4-year 62%, private nonprofit 51%, for-profit 26%. At two-year institutions, 37% complete within 150% of normal time (U.S. 41%).



60%

Six-year graduation rate, 2024

U.S. **65%** · **30th** of 51 · +11.4 pp since 2015

37%

Two-year completion rate, 2024

U.S. **41%** · **30th** of 50 · +16.0 pp since 2015

13.4

Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025

U.S. **12.3** · **16th** of 51 · +1.8 since 2015

SECTION 14 · STUDENT OUTCOMES

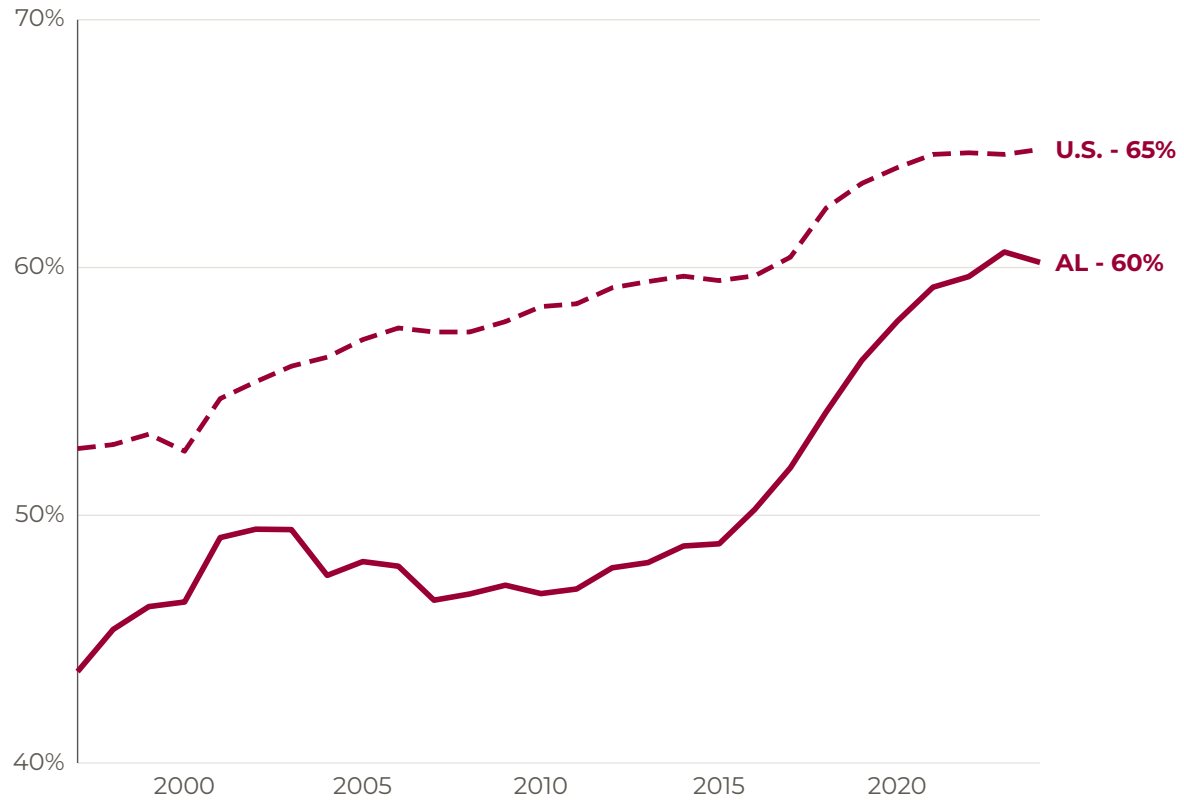
How Many of Alabama's Students Graduate?

The line follows the share of first-time, full-time bachelor's-degree students at Alabama's four-year institutions who graduated from the institution where they started within six years (150% of normal time). Each year is the cohort that entered six years earlier. The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Six-year graduation rate. The rate was 60% in 2024, against 65% for the U.S., down 0.4 points from 61% in 2023 and up 11.4 points since 2015, when it was 49%.

Public 4-year institutions. The rate was 62% in 2024, up 0.3 points from 62% in 2023 and up 11.0 points since 2015, when it was 51%.

Figure 38 Six-Year Bachelor's Graduation Rate



Four-year institutions; state solid, U.S. dashed. Data from NCES, IPEDS Graduation Rates.

60%
Six-year graduation rate, 2024
U.S. **65%** · **30th** of 51

37%
Two-year completion rate, 2024
U.S. **41%** · **30th** of 50

13.4
Bachelor's per 100 undergraduates, 2025
U.S. **12.3** · **16th** of 51

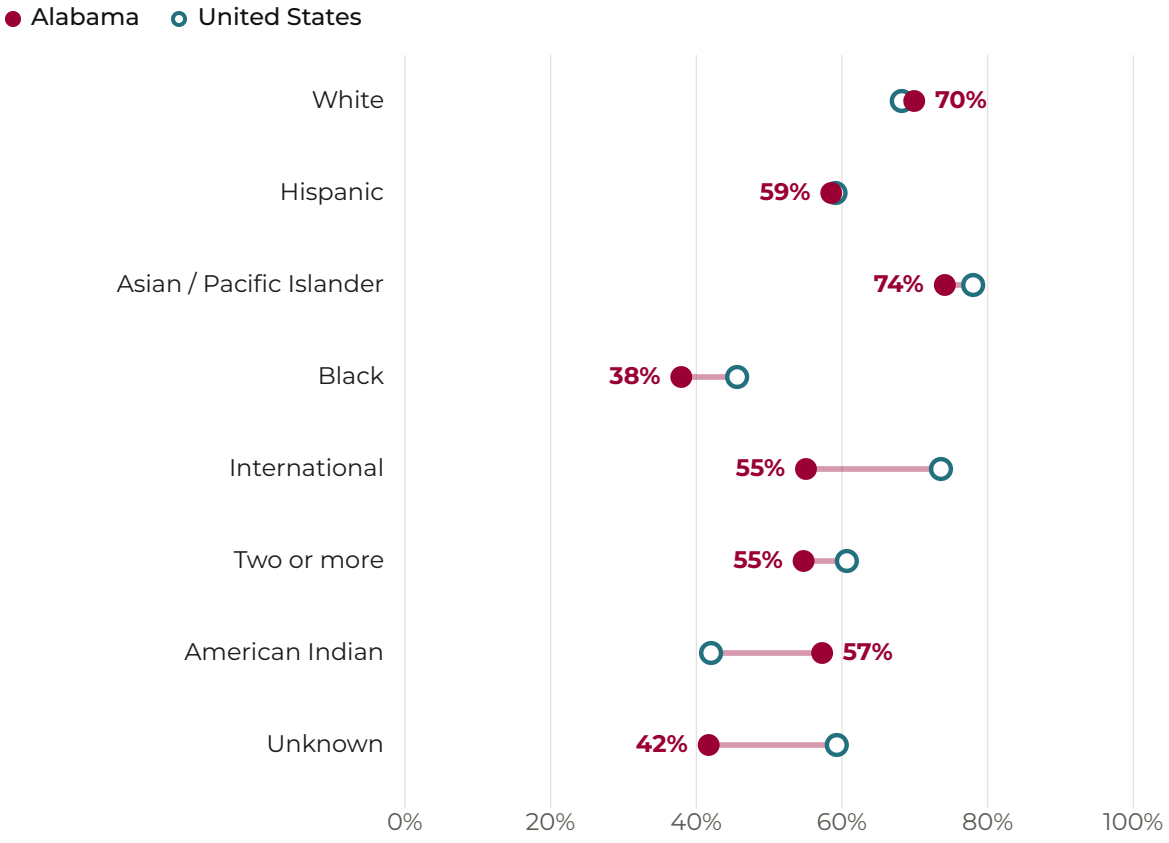
Each row is the six-year bachelor's graduation rate for one racial or ethnic group of students at Alabama's four-year institutions (filled dot), against the national rate for the same group (open dot). Groups with fewer than 100 students in the cohort are left out.

White. The six-year rate was 70% in 2024, against 68% for the U.S.

Hispanic. The six-year rate was 59% in 2024, against 59% for the U.S.

Asian / Pacific Islander. The six-year rate was 74% in 2024, against 78% for the U.S.

Figure 39 How Do Graduation Rates Differ by Race and Ethnicity?



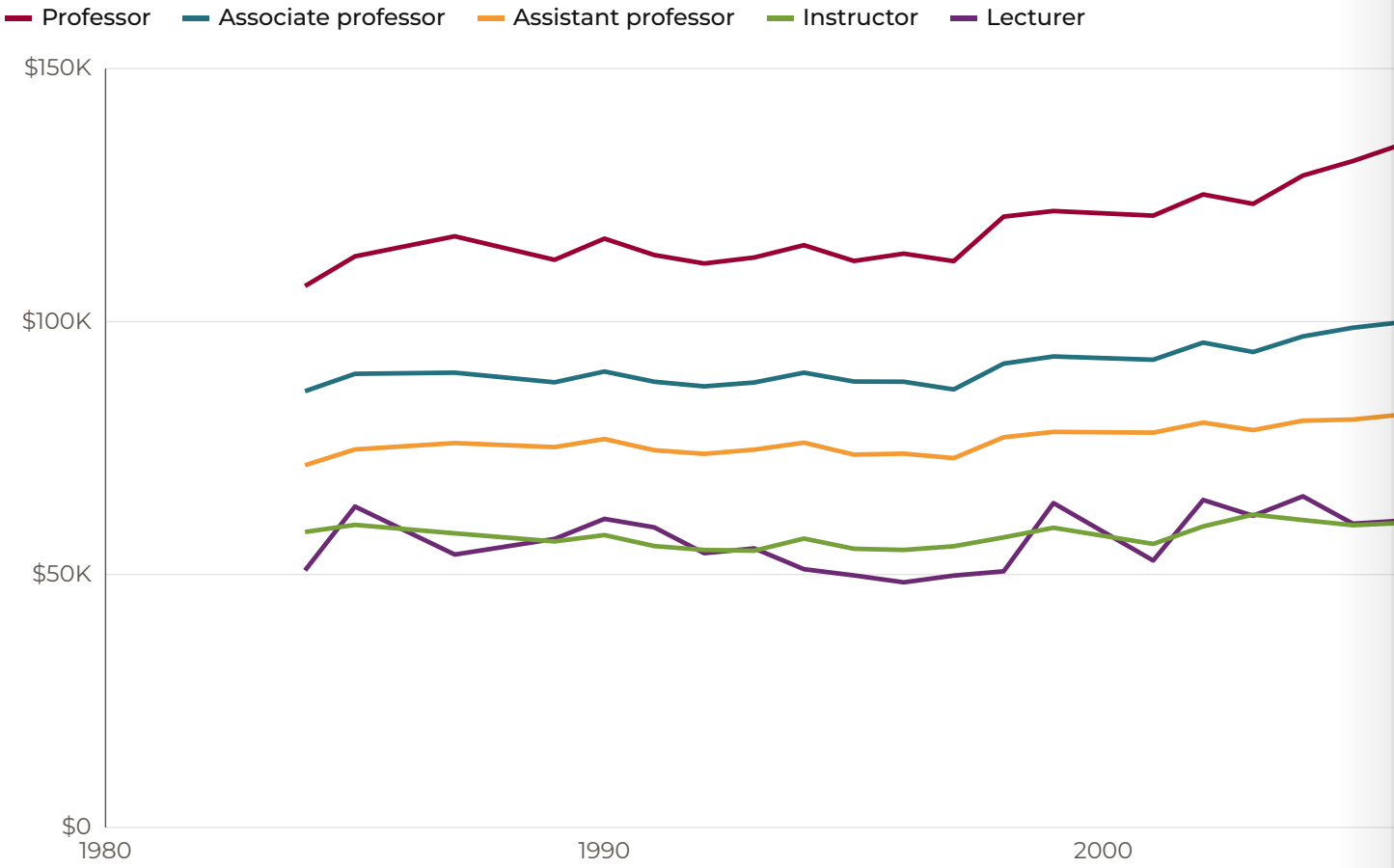
Six-year rate, 2024; groups with 100+ students. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 15

Faculty

Alabama ranks 37th of 51 states on the average full-time faculty salary, at $86.4K in 2024 against $106K for the U.S.

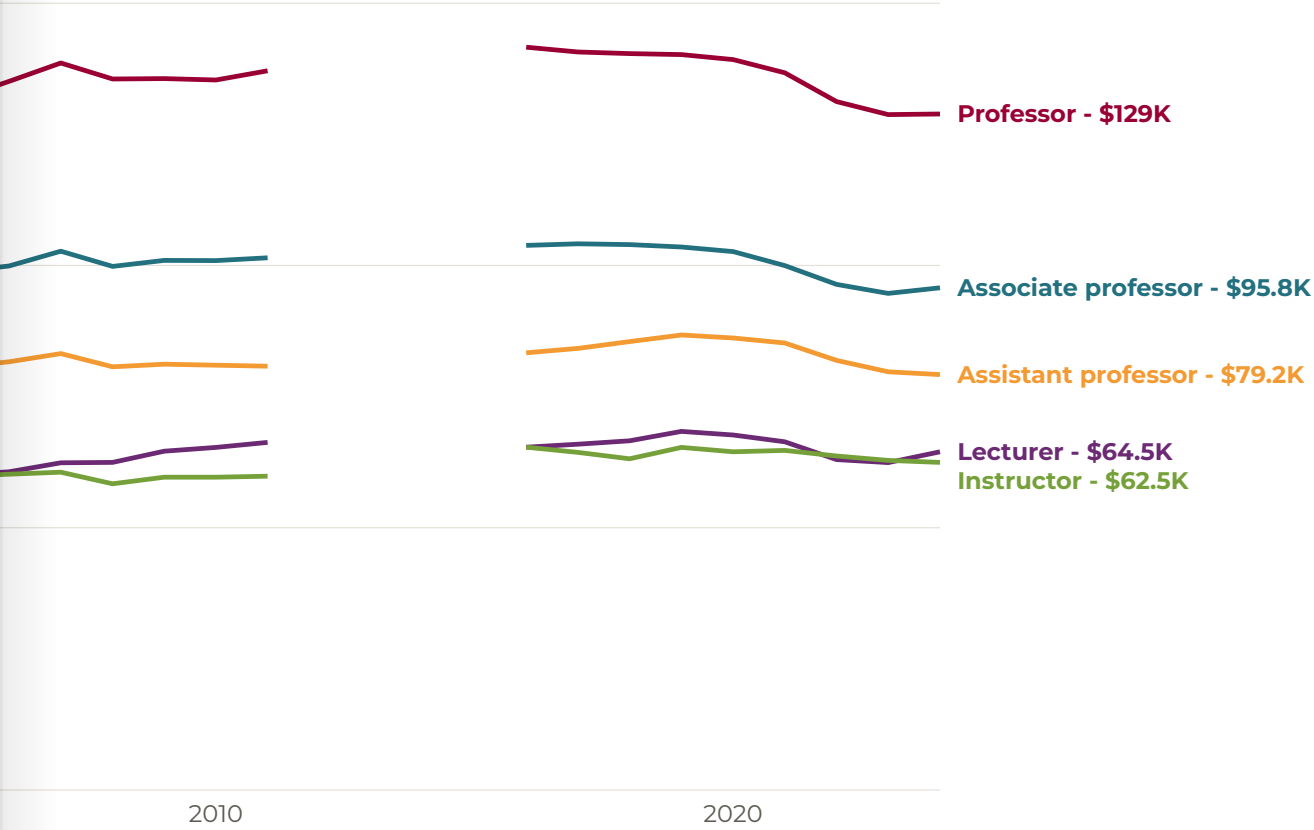
Figure 40 What Do Alabama's Faculty Earn, by Rank?



Average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts, by academic rank, 2024 dollars (CPI-U). Data fro

Full-time instructional faculty on 9/10-month contracts at Alabama's institutions earned an average of $86.4K in 2024 (2024 dollars), 18% below the U.S. ($106K); the state ranks 37th of 51. By rank (2024): professors $129K, associate professors $95.8K, assistant professors $79.2K, instructors $62.5K, lecturers $64.5K.

Alabama's institutions had 12.8K full-time instructional staff in 2024, up 10% since 2015. Average salary across all ranks is down 7% since 2016.



m NCES, IPEDS Human Resources.

15

$86.4K

Average faculty salary, 2024

U.S. **$106K** · **37th** of 51 · −6.7% since 2016

SECTION 15 · FACULTY

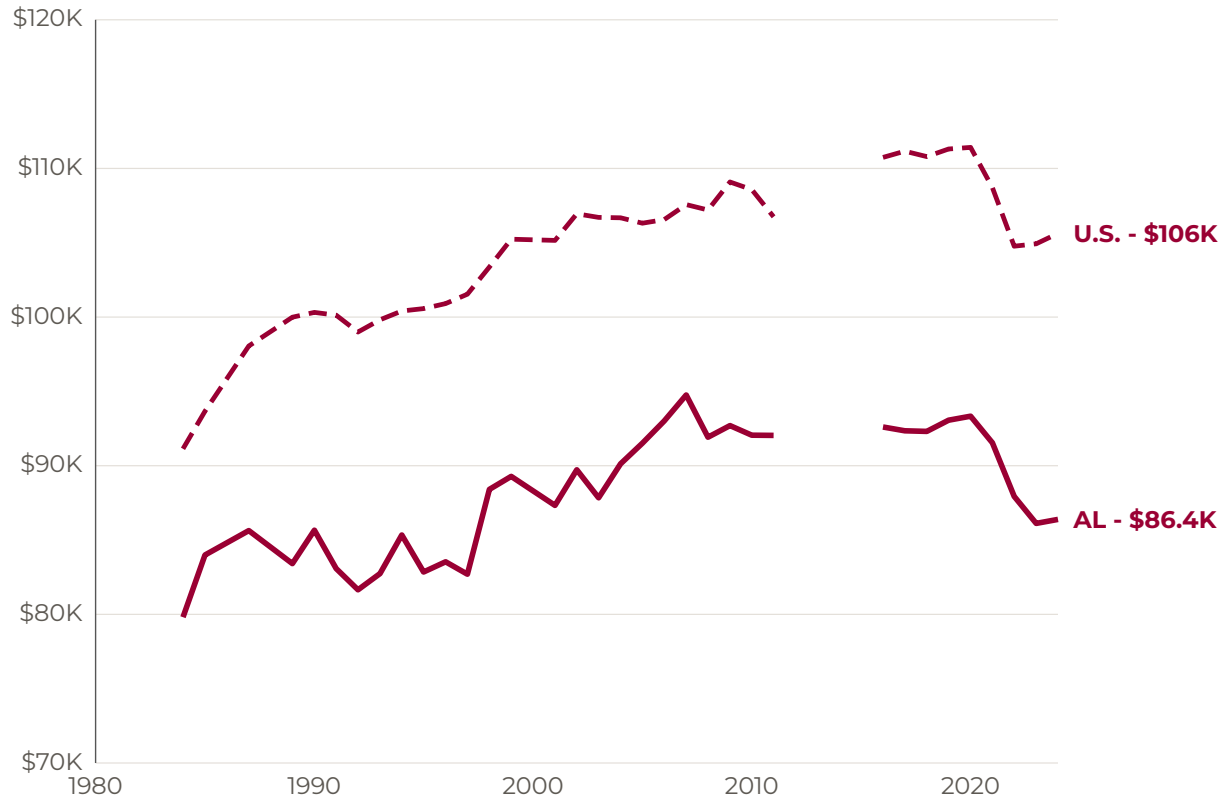
What Do Alabama's Faculty Earn, and How Many Hold Tenure?

The line follows the average salary of full-time instructional faculty on 9- or 10-month contracts at Alabama's degree-granting institutions, all ranks combined, in 2024 dollars (CPI-U). The state is solid and the United States dashed.

Average salary. The figure was $86.4K in 2024, against $106K for the U.S., 37th among the states, up 0.3% from $86.1K in 2023 and down 6.7% since 2016, when it was $92.6K.

Full-time instructional staff. The number was 12.8K in 2024, up 1.2% from 12.6K in 2023 and up 9.8% since 2015, when it was 11.6K.

Figure 41 Average Faculty Salary



Full-time instructional faculty, 9/10-month, 2024 dollars. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

$86.4K
Average faculty salary, 2024
U.S. **$106K** · **37th** of 51

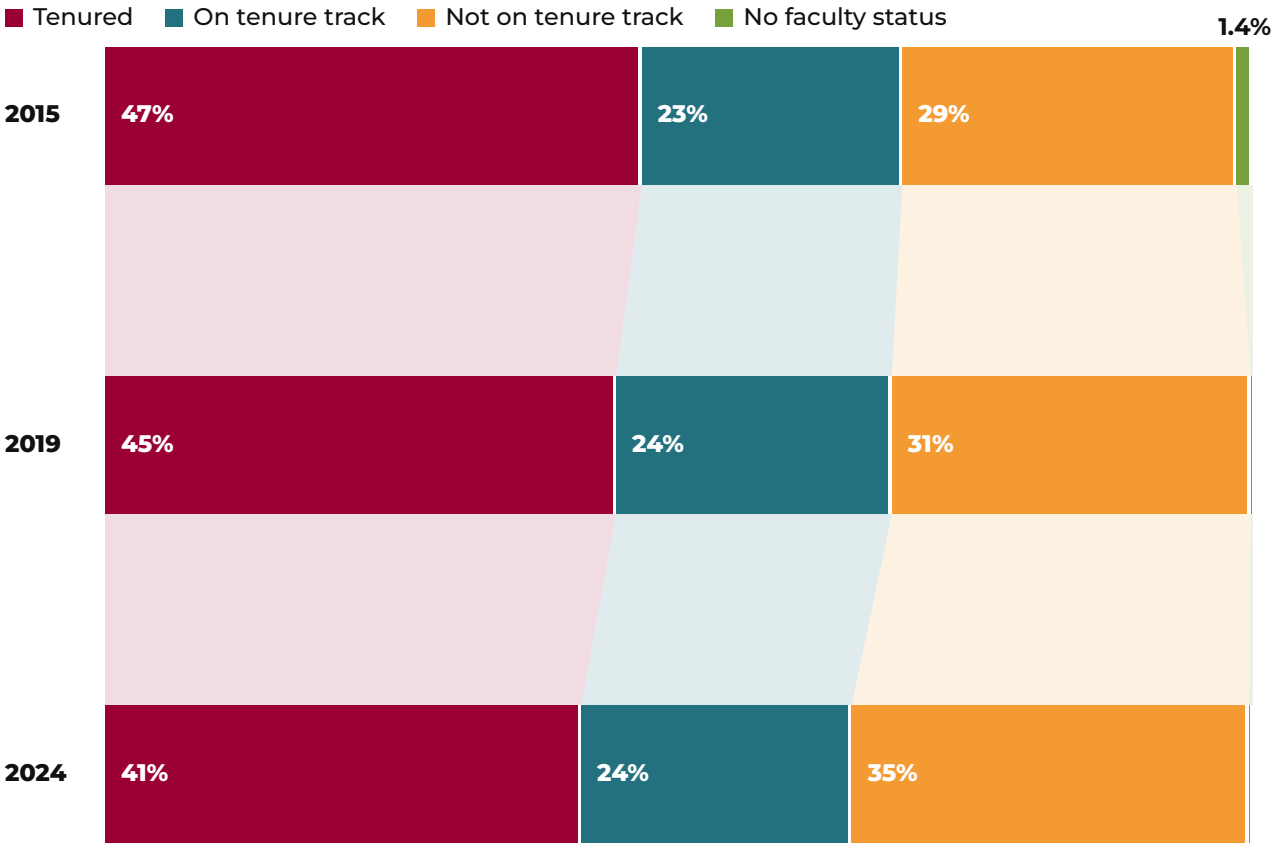
12.8K
Full-time instructional staff, 2024

41%
Tenured, 2024

The bars divide Alabama's full-time instructional staff by tenure status in 2015, 2019 and 2024: tenured, on the tenure track, not on the tenure track (for example, lecturers on fixed-term contracts), and staff at institutions with no tenure system.

Tenured, share of full-time instructional staff. The share was 41% in 2024, down 0.6 points from 42% in 2023 and down 5.3 points since 2015, when it was 47%.

Figure 42 Tenure Status



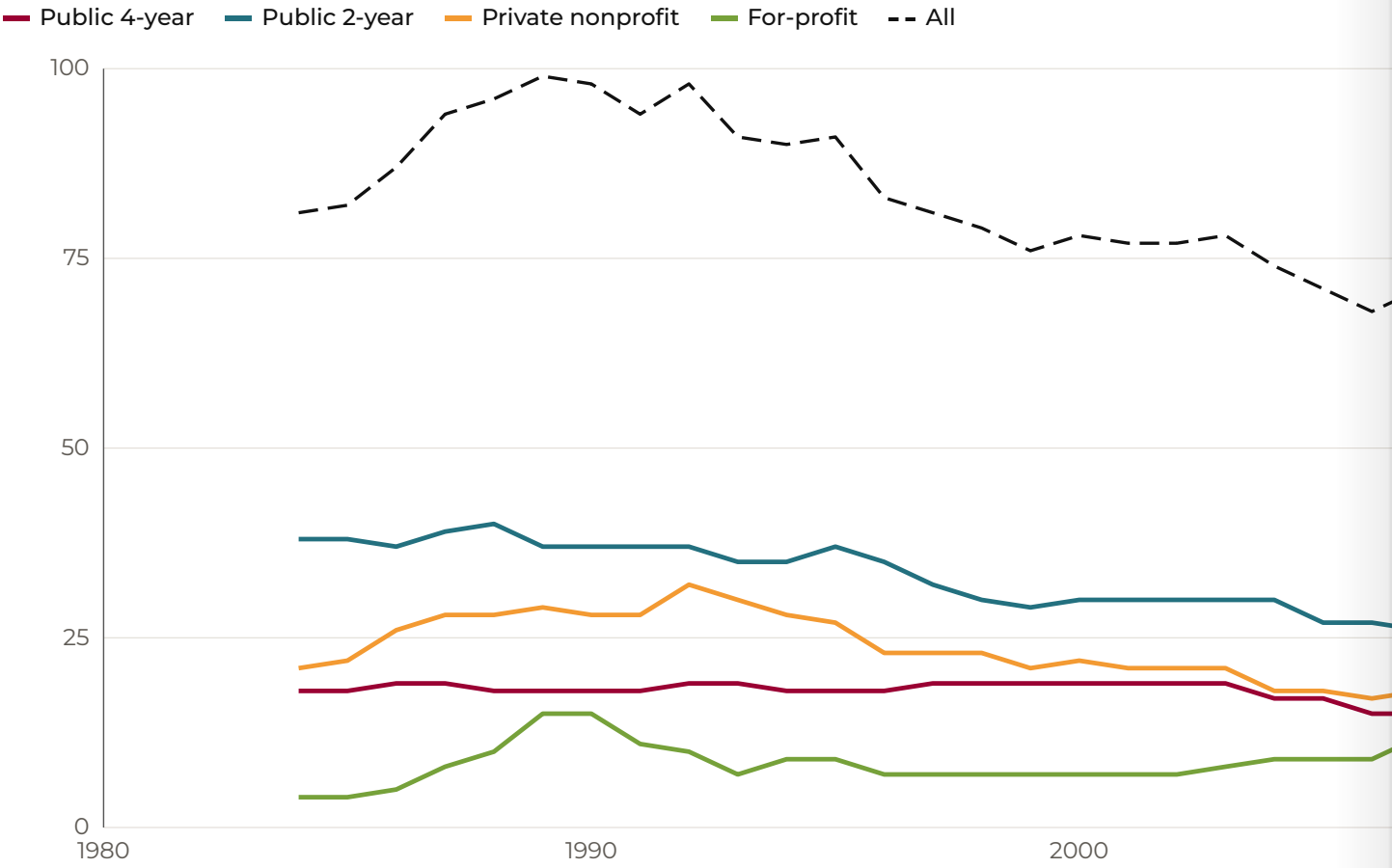
Full-time instructional staff by tenure status, 2015, 2019, 2024. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

SECTION 16

Institutions

Alabama ranks 11th of 51 states on the share of enrollment at for-profit institutions, at 6.0% in 2024 against 5.5% for the U.S.

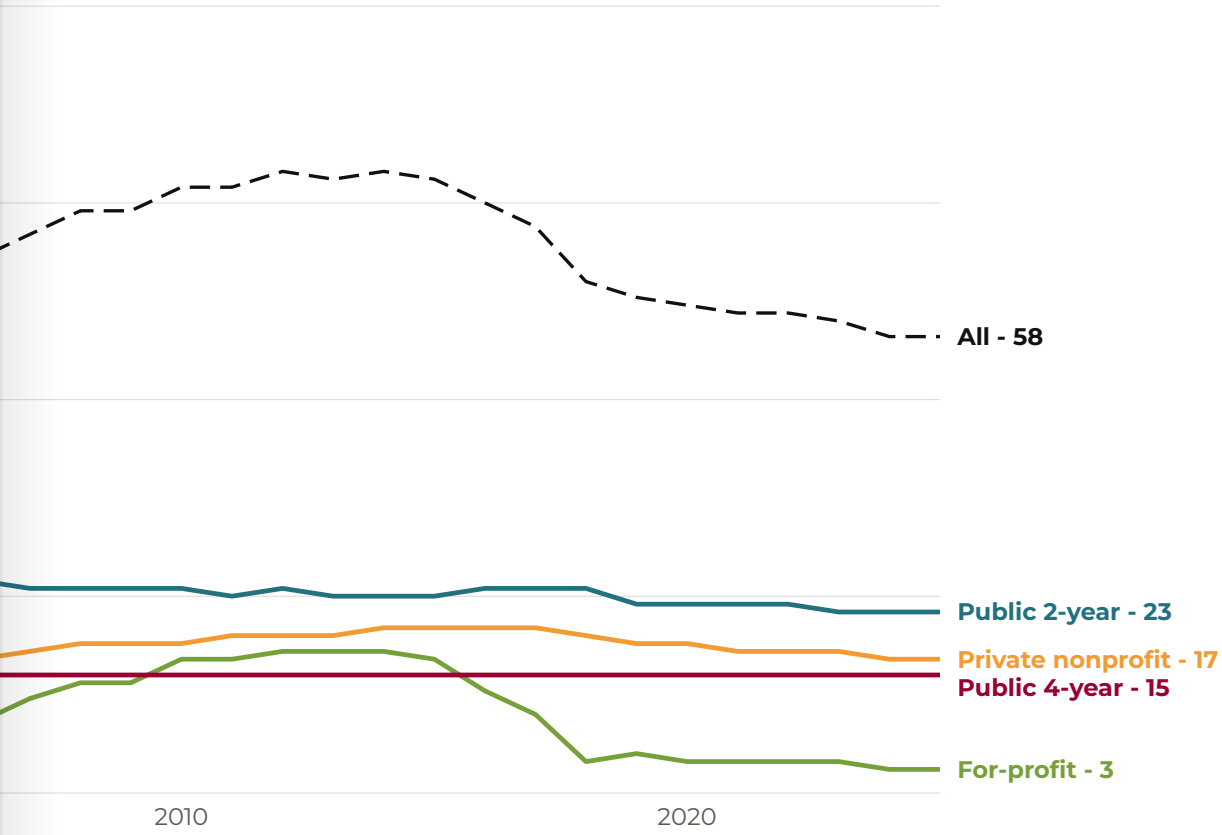
Figure 43 How Many Institutions Does Alabama Have?



Degree-granting institutions by sector. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

Alabama has 58 degree-granting institutions:15 public 4-year, 23 public 2-year, 17 private nonprofit, 3 for-profit (2025).

The number of institutions is down 26% since 2015. 87% of students attend public institutions and 6.0% attend for-profit ones.



87%

Students at public institutions, 2024

U.S. **73%** · **13th** of 51 · +5.2 pp since 2015

6.0%

Students at for-profit institutions, 2024

U.S. **5.5%** · **11th** of 51 · −3.7 pp since 2015

29%

Students fully online, 2024

U.S. **27%** · **18th** of 51 · +9.4 pp since 2015

SECTION 16 · INSTITUTIONS

Which Institutions Lead in Alabama?

The table ranks institutions in Alabama by the STEM master's degrees and research doctorates they awarded to international students in 2025, the two counted together. The share columns give international students' share of each institution's STEM degrees at that level.

Largest. Auburn University at Montgomery (636 international STEM master's degrees and – doctorates), University of Alabama at Birmingham (461 international STEM master's degrees and 38 doctorates), and Auburn University (161 international STEM master's degrees and 86 doctorates) awarded the most.

Table 7 Which Institutions Train the Most International STEM Graduates?

Institution	Intl STEM master's	Int. share	Intl STEM doctorates	Int. share
Auburn University at Montgomery Montgomery · Public 4-year	**636**	98%	–	–
University of Alabama at Birmingham Birmingham · Public 4-year	**461**	57%	38	37%
Auburn University Auburn · Public 4-year	**161**	31%	86	58%
The University of Alabama Tuscaloosa · Public 4-year	**66**	28%	59	58%
University of Alabama in Huntsville Huntsville · Public 4-year	**54**	20%	16	39%
University of South Alabama Mobile · Public 4-year	**43**	40%	7	39%
Troy University Troy · Public 4-year	**29**	48%	–	–
Alabama A & M University Normal · Public 4-year	**8**	13%	–	–%

Degrees awarded in 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

58
Degree-granting institutions, 2025

87%
Students at public institutions, 2024
U.S. **73%** · **13th** of 51

6.0%
Students at for-profit institutions, 2024
U.S. **5.5%** · **11th** of 51

29%
Students fully online, 2024
U.S. **27%** · **18th** of 51

The table lists Alabama's largest degree-granting institutions by fall 2024 headcount enrollment, with the international share of graduate students, STEM bachelor's degrees awarded in 2025, the six-year graduation rate and the admission rate (a dash where the institution admits all applicants or does not report one).

Largest. The three largest were The University of Alabama (40.8K students), Auburn University (34.1K students), and University of Alabama at Birmingham (20.9K students).

Degree-granting institutions. The state had 58 in 2025, and 57 of them reported the enrollment and degree data in these tables.

Table 8 What Are Alabama's Largest Institutions?

Institution	Enrollment	Int. share, grad	STEM bachelor's	Six-year grad rate	Admit rate
The University of Alabama	**40.8K**	13%	1.12K	73%	77%
Auburn University	**34.1K**	21%	2.18K	82%	46%
University of Alabama at Birmingham	**20.9K**	17%	772	64%	88%
Columbia Southern University	**17.8K**	0.1%	1.29K	26%	–
University of South Alabama	**14K**	3.6%	496	52%	71%
Troy University	**13.7K**	3.7%	172	49%	96%
University of North Alabama	**10.2K**	3.4%	197	55%	87%
Jacksonville State University	**9.96K**	2.5%	182	55%	78%
Jefferson State Community College	**9.24K**	–	–	–	–
John C Calhoun State Community College	**9.12K**	–	–	–	–

Fall 2024 enrollment; degrees 2025. Data from NCES, IPEDS.

NOTES

About These Data

International students

U.S. nonresidents on temporary visas, as IPEDS defines them. IPEDS does not record country of citizenship. Permanent residents count with U.S. citizens.

STEM

CIP families 03, 04, 11, 14, 15, 26, 27 and 40. Doctorates are research and scholarship doctorates; professional doctorates appear only in the degree-count figure. Degrees are first majors only.

Universe

Degree-granting institutions located in the state; Title IV participants from 1996. Geography is the institution's location, not the student's home. Enrollment is fall headcount.

Migration

First-time degree-seeking undergraduates by home state, reported in even years before 2001 and every year since; odd years with incomplete reporting are omitted. Net migration is students arriving from other states minus residents leaving, per 100 resident first-time students.

Money

All dollar values are in 2024 dollars using the CPI-U. Appropriations and revenue are per full-time-equivalent student at public institutions.

Race and ethnicity

IPEDS did not collect race and ethnicity in every year before 2010, and categories changed in 2008–2010; “Two or more” exists only from then.

Countries of citizenship

From DHS SEVIS by the Numbers: active F-1 and M-1 student records in the month named, at every level from primary school to doctorate, by the state of the school. IPEDS records only whether a student is a U.S. nonresident, not where they come from. SEVIS counts are monthly snapshots and are not directly comparable with IPEDS fall enrollment or degree counts.

Peers

Comparison states are the four closest in total fall enrollment.

Source

National Center for Education Statistics, Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS): Institutional Characteristics, Fall Enrollment, Completions, Graduation Rates, Finance, Human Resources and Admissions components, 1980–2025, harmonized into a state panel. Department of Homeland Security, SEVIS by the Numbers data mapping tool, 2014–2026. Generated November 2026.

This page intentionally left blank.

Alabama – By the Numbers

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION							
Grade 8 mathematics, average score	267	**262**[2024]	−4.8 ▼	272	−9.0 ▼	#48	[5]
Grade 8 mathematics: at or above Proficient	17%	**18%**[2024]	+1.2 pp ▲	27%	−5.3 pp ▼	#48	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics, average score	231	**236**[2024]	+5.4 ▲	237	−2.5 ▼	#31	[5]
Grade 4 mathematics: at or above Proficient	26%	**37%**[2024]	+10.8 pp ▲	39%	0.0 pp	#35	[5]
Grade 8 reading, average score	259	**250**[2024]	−9.2 ▼	257	−7.3 ▼	#46	[5]
Grade 8 reading: at or above Proficient	26%	**21%**[2024]	−4.3 pp ▼	29%	−4.0 pp ▼	#48	[5]
Grade 4 reading, average score	217	**213**[2024]	−3.8 ▼	214	−7.1 ▼	#33	[5]
Grade 8 science, average score, 2009 framework	–	**141**[2015]	–	153	–	#45	[5]
Current spending per public-school pupil	$12K	**$12.6K**[2021]	+5.5% ▲	$16.8K	+12% ▲	#43	[3]
Public high school 4-year graduation rate, ACGR	89%	**88%**[2022]	−1.0 pp ▼	87%	+4.0 pp ▲	#13	[3]
Public high school graduates	45.4K	**48.1K**[2024]	+5.8% ▲	3.49M	+8.8% ▲	#24	[3]
Average public-school teacher salary	$63.6K	**$61.3K**[2022]	−3.6% ▼	$72.9K	−3.0% ▼	#32	[3]
Pupils per teacher, public schools	18.2	**17.9**[2022]	−0.3 ▼	15.4	−0.6 ▼	#8	[3]
Public elementary and secondary enrollment	744K	**751K**[2024]	+1.0% ▲	49.4M	−2.1% ▼	#24	[3]
Public-school students eligible for free or reduced-price lunch	52%	**60%**[2023]	+8.4 pp ▲	53%	+1.5 pp ▲	#10	[3]
English learners as a share of public-school students	2.9%	**4.7%**[2022]	+1.8 pp ▲	11%	+1.0 pp ▲	#39	[3]
Charter-school share of public-school enrollment	0.0%	**0.8%**[2023]	+0.8 pp ▲	7.6%	+2.2 pp ▲	#38	[3]
High schools offering calculus	54%[2016]	**40%**[2024]	−14.3 pp ▼	51%	−5.8 pp ▼	#40	[14]
High schools offering physics	61%[2016]	**54%**[2024]	−6.8 pp ▼	64%	−2.4 pp ▼	#36	[14]
High schools offering chemistry	88%[2016]	**86%**[2024]	−2.5 pp ▼	81%	+0.7 pp ▲	#20	[14]
High schools offering Algebra II	89%[2016]	**95%**[2024]	+5.5 pp ▲	87%	+1.3 pp ▲	#11	[14]
High schools offering computer science	62%[2021]	**66%**[2024]	+4.3 pp ▲	55%	+2.0 pp ▲	#21	[14]
High schools offering any AP course	59%[2016]	**61%**[2024]	+1.6 pp ▲	56%	0.0 pp	#24	[14]
High schools offering AP computer science	40%[2021]	**42%**[2024]	+2.5 pp ▲	25%	+2.6 pp ▲	#9	[14]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

ALABAMA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
K-12 PREPARATION (CONTINUED)							
High schools offering dual enrollment	77%[2016]	**90%[2024]**	+12.8 pp ▲	71%	+11.1 pp ▲	#3	[14]
AP course enrollments per 100 high-school students	11.6[2016]	**12.1[2024]**	+0.5 ▲	18.4	+1.0 ▲	#40	[14]
Calculus enrollments per 100 high-school students	2.6[2016]	**1.6[2024]**	−1.0 ▼	3.3	−1.0 ▼	#42	[14]
Physics enrollments per 100 high-school students	3.9[2016]	**3.9[2024]**	0.0	9.4	−0.4 ▼	#41	[14]
SAT or ACT takers per 100 high-school students	23.2[2016]	**23.6[2024]**	+0.4 ▲	18.1	−2.5 ▼	#11	[14]
Students in gifted and talented programs per 100 students	7.1[2016]	**6.3[2024]**	−0.8 ▼	7.0	+0.4 ▲	#18	[14]
ENROLLMENT AND INSTITUTIONS							
Pell Grant share of undergraduates	40%	**35%[2025]**	−4.7 pp ▼	36%	−0.8 pp ▼	#21	[15]
Fall enrollment	303K	**311K[2024]**	+2.7% ▲	19.7M	−1.7% ▼	#24	[4]
Share of enrollment at public institutions	82%	**87%[2024]**	+5.2 pp ▲	73%	0.0 pp	#13	[4]
Share of enrollment at for-profit institutions	9.8%	**6.0%[2024]**	−3.7 pp ▼	5.5%	−1.2 pp ▼	#11	[4]
Share of students enrolled part-time	32%	**35%[2024]**	+3.2 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#37	[4]
Share of students who are graduate students	15%	**18%[2024]**	+2.6 pp ▲	17%	+2.0 pp ▲	#18	[4]
Share of students enrolled exclusively online	19%	**29%[2024]**	+9.4 pp ▲	27%	+12.1 pp ▲	#18	[4]
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY							
Research doctorates awarded	695	**771[2025]**	+11% ▲	59K	+7.3% ▲	#24	[7]
Science & engineering research doctorates, excluding health	474	**540[2025]**	+14% ▲	44.4K	+14% ▲	#24	[7]
Share of U.S. research doctorates	1.3%	**1.3%[2025]**	0.0 pp	–	–	#24	[7]
Engineering research doctorates	133	**155[2025]**	+17% ▲	10.9K	+9.9% ▲	#22	[7]
Mathematics & computer science research doctorates	46	**49[2025]**	–	5.07K	+33% ▲	#25	[7]
STEM master's degrees per research doctorate	4.8	**8.2[2025]**	+3.4 ▲	6.4	+2.1 ▲	#10	[4]
STEM share of bachelor's	20%	**24%[2025]**	+3.8 pp ▲	24%	+5.3 pp ▲	#23	[4]
Share of bachelor's in computer & information sciences	2.3%	**3.8%[2025]**	+1.5 pp ▲	6.9%	+3.7 pp ▲	#41	[4]
Share of bachelor's in engineering & eng. technology	9.2%	**10%[2025]**	+1.1 pp ▲	6.8%	+0.7 pp ▲	#4	[4]
Share of bachelor's in mathematics & statistics	1.0%	**0.6%[2025]**	−0.3 pp ▼	1.2%	0.0 pp	#38	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

ALABAMA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
DEGREES AND FIELDS OF STUDY (CONTINUED)							
Share of bachelor's in biological & biomedical sciences	5.3%	**6.7%**[2025]	+1.4 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#22	[4]
Share of bachelor's in physical sciences	1.2%	**1.0%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	1.3%	−0.3 pp ▼	#42	[4]
Share of bachelor's in health professions	13%	**12%**[2025]	−0.6 pp ▼	12%	+1.1 pp ▲	#26	[4]
Share of bachelor's in business	24%	**24%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	19%	−0.1 pp ▼	#6	[4]
STEM share of master's	14%	**21%**[2025]	+7.0 pp ▲	23%	+6.7 pp ▲	#26	[4]
Share of master's in computer & information sciences	1.6%	**7.6%**[2025]	+6.0 pp ▲	10%	+6.3 pp ▲	#28	[4]
Share of master's in engineering & eng. technology	9.0%	**8.8%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	6.7%	−0.2 pp ▼	#7	[4]
Share of master's in mathematics & statistics	0.7%	**0.4%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	1.3%	+0.3 pp ▲	#42	[4]
Share of master's in biological & biomedical sciences	1.0%	**2.6%**[2025]	+1.6 pp ▲	2.5%	+0.6 pp ▲	#22	[4]
Share of master's in physical sciences	0.8%	**0.5%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	0.8%	−0.1 pp ▼	#33	[4]
Share of master's in health professions	20%	**18%**[2025]	−1.5 pp ▼	15%	+1.7 pp ▲	#9	[4]
Share of master's in business	26%	**26%**[2025]	−0.2 pp ▼	21%	−3.2 pp ▼	#7	[4]
STEM share of research doctorates	41%	**42%**[2025]	+0.9 pp ▲	39%	−2.2 pp ▼	#28	[4]
Share of research doctorates in computer & information sciences	1.1%	**1.0%**[2025]	−0.1 pp ▼	4.2%	+1.4 pp ▲	#48	[4]
Share of research doctorates in engineering & eng. technology	17%	**17%**[2025]	+0.4 pp ▲	14%	−1.0 pp ▼	#10	[4]
Share of research doctorates in mathematics & statistics	2.8%	**3.0%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	2.4%	−0.2 pp ▼	#16	[4]
Share of research doctorates in biological & biomedical sciences	14%	**14%**[2025]	−0.8 pp ▼	10%	−1.1 pp ▼	#16	[4]
Share of research doctorates in physical sciences	5.6%	**6.7%**[2025]	+1.0 pp ▲	7.1%	−1.1 pp ▼	#34	[4]
Share of research doctorates in health professions	3.5%	**6.5%**[2025]	+2.9 pp ▲	12%	+3.5 pp ▲	#36	[4]
Share of research doctorates in business	5.3%	**9.6%**[2025]	+4.3 pp ▲	5.6%	+1.3 pp ▲	#9	[4]
Bachelor's degrees per 100 undergraduates	11.6	**13.4**[2025]	+1.8 ▲	12.3	+1.4 ▲	#16	[4]
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS							
First-time students from outside the U.S.	1.4%[2016]	**1.2%**[2024]	−0.2 pp ▼	3.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#45	[4]
STEM master's degrees earned by international students	419	**1.47K**[2025]	3.50× ▲	117K	2.18× ▲	#20	[4]
Share of all U.S. international STEM master's degrees	0.8%	**1.3%**[2025]	+0.5 pp ▲	–	–	#20	[4]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

ALABAMA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
International share of undergraduate enrollment	2.0%	**1.5%**[2024]	−0.5 pp ▼	3.0%	−0.3 pp ▼	#44	[4]
International share of graduate enrollment	7.0%	**10%**[2024]	+3.3 pp ▲	17%	+2.8 pp ▲	#33	[4]
International share of all bachelor's	2.1%	**1.7%**[2025]	−0.4 pp ▼	4.1%	+0.1 pp ▲	#46	[4]
International share of STEM bachelor's	2.0%	**2.7%**[2025]	+0.7 pp ▲	6.6%	+0.8 pp ▲	#44	[4]
International share of all master's	6.7%	**11%**[2025]	+4.7 pp ▲	22%	+6.2 pp ▲	#36	[4]
International share of STEM master's	26%	**43%**[2025]	+16.5 pp ▲	52%	+9.1 pp ▲	#26	[4]
International share of computer & information sciences master's	50%	**82%**[2025]	+32.0 pp ▲	65%	+10.1 pp ▲	#9	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology master's	22%	**18%**[2025]	−4.0 pp ▼	50%	+0.9 pp ▲	#46	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics master's	46%	**24%**[2025]	−22.2 pp ▼	55%	+6.1 pp ▲	#35	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences master's	9.9%	**21%**[2025]	+11.1 pp ▲	23%	+6.2 pp ▲	#18	[4]
International share of physical sciences master's	33%	**44%**[2025]	+11.7 pp ▲	33%	+3.6 pp ▲	#7	[4]
International share of all research doctorates	25%	**27%**[2025]	+2.2 pp ▲	25%	−1.0 pp ▼	#22	[4]
International share of STEM research doctorates	45%	**49%**[2025]	+4.3 pp ▲	43%	−0.5 pp ▼	#10	[4]
International share of engineering & eng. technology research doctorates	60%	**64%**[2025]	+3.4 pp ▲	55%	−1.0 pp ▼	#8	[4]
International share of mathematics & statistics research doctorates	–	**50%**[2025]	–	53%	–	#17	[4]
International share of biological & biomedical sciences research doctorates	25%	**35%**[2025]	+9.8 pp ▲	23%	−4.3 pp ▼	#2	[4]
International share of physical sciences research doctorates	37%	**40%**[2025]	+3.3 pp ▲	38%	−1.1 pp ▼	#19	[4]
Active F-1/M-1 students, all levels	8.63K	**10.2K**[2026]	+19% ▲	1.19M	−0.1% ▼	#26	[20]
Share of U.S. active F-1/M-1 students	0.7%	**0.9%**[2026]	+0.1 pp ▲	–	–	#26	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from India	15%	**34%**[2026]	+19.2 pp ▲	27%	+11.4 pp ▲	#12	[20]
Share of F-1/M-1 students from China	32%	**5.6%**[2026]	−26.7 pp ▼	18%	−11.7 pp ▼	#38	[20]
Share from the two largest countries of origin	47%	**40%**[2026]	−7.5 pp ▼	45%	−0.3 pp ▼	#24	[20]
Countries of citizenship represented	163	**158**[2026]	−3.1% ▼	219	−2.7% ▼	#33	[20]
Active STEM F-1/M-1 students	3.9K	**6.3K**[2026]	+61% ▲	749K	+61% ▲	#25	[20]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

ALABAMA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
INTERNATIONAL STUDENTS (CONTINUED)							
Active STEM master's students	1.42K	**2.94K**[2026]	2.07× ▲	393K	+90% ▲	#25	[20]
Active STEM doctoral students	1.15K	**2.17K**[2026]	+89% ▲	158K	+61% ▲	#22	[20]
Share of STEM master's students from India	60%	**72%**[2026]	+12.2 pp ▲	58%	−1.8 pp ▼	#6	[20]
U.S. students studying abroad for credit, from the state's institutions	4K[2017]	**4.62K**[2024]	+16% ▲	–	–	#24	[1]
Economic contribution of international students	$314M[2018]	**$340M**[2024]	+8.2% ▲	$42.9B	+4.6% ▲	#25	[2]
Jobs supported by international students' spending	3.16K[2018]	**2.31K**[2024]	−27% ▼	356K	−22% ▼	#26	[2]
Share of U.S. student and exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.5%	**0.5%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#30	[16]
Share of U.S. F-1 student admissions, by destination	0.5%	**0.5%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#30	[16]
Share of U.S. J-1 exchange-visitor admissions, by destination	0.6%	**0.6%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#34	[16]
J-1 exchange visitors starting a program in the state	2.35K	**1.92K**[2025]	−18% ▼	275K	−14% ▼	#36	[18]
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH							
Graduate students in science & engineering	8.01K	**7.54K**[2016]	−5.8% ▼	620K	+0.4% ▲	#23	[9]
S&E graduate students on temporary visas	2.14K	**2.28K**[2016]	+6.5% ▲	241K	+2.3% ▲	#25	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E graduate students	27%	**30%**[2016]	+3.5 pp ▲	39%	+0.7 pp ▲	#32	[9]
Temporary-visa share of engineering graduate students	46%	**47%**[2016]	+0.5 pp ▲	57%	0.0 pp	#33	[9]
S&E postdoctoral appointees	228	**239**[2016]	+4.8% ▲	45.7K	+1.0% ▲	#31	[9]
Temporary-visa share of S&E postdocs	56%	**60%**[2016]	+4.1 pp ▲	56%	−0.9 pp ▼	#15	[9]
University R&D spending	$903M	**$1.76B**[2024]	+95% ▲	$118B	+71% ▲	#23	[6]
Share of U.S. university R&D	1.3%	**1.5%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#23	[6]
Federally funded share of university R&D	59%	**54%**[2024]	−4.4 pp ▼	55%	−0.2 pp ▼	#21	[6]
Business-funded share of university R&D	6.7%	**4.9%**[2024]	−1.9 pp ▼	5.4%	−0.4 pp ▼	#19	[6]
State- and locally funded share of university R&D	5.3%	**4.6%**[2024]	−0.7 pp ▼	5.2%	−0.4 pp ▼	#30	[6]
University R&D in mathematics and computer science	$44.1M	**$83.3M**[2024]	+89% ▲	$5.12B	+97% ▲	#17	[6]
University R&D in engineering	$141M	**$288M**[2024]	2.03× ▲	$19.3B	+74% ▲	#20	[6]
University R&D personnel, headcount	10.8K	**14.3K**[2024]	+33% ▲	1.09M	+20% ▲	#23	[6]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

ALABAMA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
GRADUATE EDUCATION AND RESEARCH (CONTINUED)							
Federal R&D obligations to the state	$4.54B	**$7.78B**[2024]	+71% ▲	$193B	+53% ▲	#8	[8]
Federal R&D obligations to universities in the state	$341M	**$658M**[2024]	+93% ▲	$44.4B	+64% ▲	#21	[8]
Defense R&D obligations to the state	$2.92B	**$6.56B**[2024]	2.24× ▲	$97.2B	+60% ▲	#4	[8]
Health (HHS/NIH) R&D obligations to the state	$295M	**$392M**[2024]	+33% ▲	$48.5B	+62% ▲	#26	[8]
NSF, NIH, NASA and DOE Science grants performed in the state	$318M	**$488M**[2025]	+53% ▲	$45B	+47% ▲	#25	[19]
Federal R&D contracts performed in the state	$1.96B	**$4.74B**[2026]	+2,777.1 ▲	$59.3B	+22,105.9 ▲	#5	[19]
COLLEGE COSTS AND OUTCOMES							
Median earnings 10 years after entering college	$43K[2020]	**$44K**[2022]	+2.4% ▲	$47.5K	+11% ▲	#38	[15]
Median earnings 1 year after completing	–	**$50.1K**[2025]	–	$47.5K	–	#18	[15]
Median debt of completers	$21.7K	**$21.3K**[2024]	−2.3% ▼	$17.6K	−4.6% ▼	#4	[15]
STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$71.9K**[2025]	–	$68.2K	–	#8	[15]
Non-STEM bachelor's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$51.6K**[2025]	–	$51.9K	–	#23	[15]
Bachelor's graduates: median earnings 5 years out	–	**$65.7K**[2025]	–	$68.1K	–	#30	[15]
STEM master's graduates: median earnings 1 year out	–	**$92.5K**[2025]	–	$91.6K	–	#16	[15]
Six-year bachelor's graduation rate, 4-year institutions	49%	**60%**[2024]	+11.4 pp ▲	65%	+5.3 pp ▲	#30	[4]
Completion within 150% of normal time, 2-year institutions	21%	**37%**[2024]	+16.0 pp ▲	41%	+12.1 pp ▲	#30	[4]
In-state tuition & fees, public 4-year	$12K	**$11.6K**[2023]	−3.0% ▼	$9.71K	−14% ▼	#16	[4]
State & local appropriations per FTE, public institutions	$9.14K	**$11.4K**[2024]	+25% ▲	$11.4K	+22% ▲	#20	[4]
Tuition share of core revenue, public institutions	56%	**47%**[2024]	−9.3 pp ▼	43%	−5.9 pp ▼	#25	[4]
Average full-time faculty salary (9/10-month)	$92.6K[2016]	**$86.4K**[2024]	−6.7% ▼	$106K	−4.6% ▼	#37	[4]
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO							
International graduates on OPT working in the state where they studied	30%	**25%**[2016]	−5.8 pp ▼	44%	−1.8 pp ▼	#41	[21]
OPT retention, bachelor's graduates	44%	**49%**[2016]	+4.7 pp ▲	58%	+0.3 pp ▲	#19	[21]
OPT retention, master's graduates	25%	**17%**[2016]	−7.2 pp ▼	39%	−2.5 pp ▼	#43	[21]
OPT retention, STEM graduates	27%	**19%**[2016]	−8.8 pp ▼	37%	−1.9 pp ▼	#45	[21]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

ALABAMA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WHERE STUDENTS AND GRADUATES GO (CONTINUED)							
OPT workers employed in the state per OPT graduate of its schools	0.60	**0.48**[2016]	−0.1 ▼	1.00	0.0	#43	[21]
STEM OPT extensions approved, by state of the school	203	**279**[2016]	+37% ▲	41.2K	+51% ▲	#30	[21]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year after graduating (PSEO)	56%[2016]	**53%**[2019]	−2.5 pp ▼	72%	−0.1 pp ▼	#29	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 5 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**47%**[2016]	–	65%	–	#31	[11]
Bachelor's graduates working in the state 10 years after graduating (PSEO)	–	**57%**[2010]	–	64%	–	#20	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	57%[2016]	**57%**[2019]	−0.3 pp ▼	67%	+1.5 pp ▲	#21	[11]
Master's graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**55%**[2016]	–	66%	–	#25	[11]
Doctoral graduates working in the state 1 year out (PSEO)	–	**38%**[2016]	–	49%	–	#30	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$49.2K[2016]	**$51K**[2019]	+3.7% ▲	$48.1K	+2.3% ▲	#5	[11]
Bachelor's graduates' median earnings 5 years out (PSEO)	–	**$71.4K**[2016]	–	$67.3K	–	#7	[11]
STEM bachelor's graduates' median earnings 1 year out (PSEO)	$64.2K[2016]	**$64.3K**[2019]	+0.1% ▲	$59.3K	+0.1% ▲	#4	[11]
Net domestic migration of bachelor's-plus adults, per 1,000 residents	−0.3	**+5.1**[2025]	+5.4 ▲	–	–	#13	[12]
Net domestic migration of graduate-degree holders	+1.99K	**+2.33K**[2025]	+341.0 ▲	–	–	#9	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved in from another state	2.8%	**3.0%**[2025]	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#22	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who moved out to another state	2.8%	**2.5%**[2025]	−0.3 pp ▼	–	–	#33	[12]
Bachelor's-plus adults who arrived from abroad in the past year	2.61K	**6.31K**[2025]	2.41× ▲	–	–	#24	[12]
First-time students who are in-state residents	71%[2016]	**68%**[2024]	−3.0 pp ▼	–	–	#32	[4]
Net student migration (per 100 resident first-time students)	+19[2016]	**+23**[2024]	+4.2 ▲	–	–	#9	[4]
Recent high school graduates who go to college out of state	12%[2016]	**13%**[2022]	+1.1 pp ▲	22%	+2.5 pp ▲	#49	[3]
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS							
Certified H-1B positions, by worksite	2.53K	**2.17K**[2025]	−14% ▼	914K	−24% ▼	#35	[17]
Share of U.S. certified H-1B positions	0.2%	**0.2%**[2025]	0.0 pp	–	–	#35	[17]
STEM share of certified H-1B positions	69%	**60%**[2025]	−9.5 pp ▼	76%	−7.8 pp ▼	#34	[17]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

ALABAMA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
WORK VISAS AND GREEN CARDS (CONTINUED)							
Median offered H-1B wage, nominal dollars	$64.1K	**$89.4K**[2025]	+40% ▲	$119K	+66% ▲	#43	[17]
H-1B positions at H-1B-dependent employers	28%	**11%**[2025]	−16.8 pp ▼	22%	−25.7 pp ▼	#37	[17]
Green-card labor certifications	583	**2.55K**[2025]	4.38× ▲	138K	+75% ▲	#16	[17]
Share of PERM certifications for citizens of India	11%	**11%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	47%	−10.6 pp ▼	#45	[17]
PERM certifications for workers on F-1 student visas	10%	**7.2%**[2024]	−3.1 pp ▼	8.7%	+4.9 pp ▲	#36	[17]
PERM workers with a master's or doctorate	18%	**15%**[2024]	−2.7 pp ▼	47%	−4.9 pp ▼	#46	[17]
STEM share of PERM certifications	27%	**8.0%**[2025]	−19.1 pp ▼	49%	−25.8 pp ▼	#50	[17]
Median offered PERM wage, nominal dollars	$38.1K	**$22.5K**[2025]	−41% ▼	$100K	+9.9% ▲	#51	[17]
New lawful permanent residents (green cards), by state of residence	3.93K	**5.01K**[2024]	+28% ▲	1.36M	+30% ▲	#35	[16]
Share of U.S. new green-card holders	0.4%	**0.4%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#35	[16]
People naturalized as U.S. citizens, by state of residence	2.83K	**3.1K**[2024]	+9.4% ▲	819K	+12% ▲	#35	[16]
Share of U.S. naturalizations	0.4%	**0.4%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#35	[16]
Share of U.S. temporary-worker admissions, by destination	0.4%	**0.4%**[2024]	0.0 pp	–	–	#31	[16]
Share of U.S. H-1B worker admissions, by destination	0.3%	**0.2%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#36	[16]
Share of U.S. L-1 intracompany-transferee admissions, by destination	0.5%	**0.7%**[2024]	+0.2 pp ▲	–	–	#24	[16]
Share of U.S. O-1 extraordinary-ability worker admissions, by destination	0.2%	**0.1%**[2024]	−0.1 pp ▼	–	–	#35	[16]
New H-1B approvals (initial), by employer state	357	**457**[2026]	+28% ▲	127K	+14% ▲	#31	[13]
Continuing H-1B approvals, by employer state	397	**676**[2026]	+70% ▲	268K	+52% ▲	#37	[13]
Share of U.S. new H-1B approvals	0.3%	**0.4%**[2026]	0.0 pp	–	–	#31	[13]
Denial rate, new H-1B petitions	3.8%	**2.1%**[2026]	−1.6 pp ▼	3.4%	−3.0 pp ▼	#46	[13]
New H-1B approvals at colleges and schools (NAICS 61)	45%	**34%**[2026]	−11.7 pp ▼	8.6%	−1.7 pp ▼	#7	[13]
New H-1B approvals in professional, scientific & technical services	9.5%	**17%**[2026]	+7.3 pp ▲	44%	−12.5 pp ▼	#40	[13]
Five largest employers' share of new H-1B approvals	43%	**31%**[2026]	−11.9 pp ▼	9.1%	−6.7 pp ▼	#28	[13]
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION							

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

ALABAMA – BY THE NUMBERS (CONTINUED)

Measure	2015	Latest	Change since 2015	U.S., latest	U.S. change since 2015	Rank	Source
STEM WORKFORCE AND INNOVATION (CONTINUED)							
Workers in STEM occupations	103K	**159K**[2024]	+55% ▲	13.7M	+51% ▲	#26	[12]
STEM workers as a share of all workers	5.0%	**6.8%**[2024]	+1.8 pp ▲	8.1%	+2.1 pp ▲	#31	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers	6.8%	**9.0%**[2024]	+2.2 pp ▲	24%	+1.6 pp ▲	#41	[12]
Foreign-born share of STEM workers with a graduate degree	18%	**20%**[2024]	+2.3 pp ▲	41%	+2.2 pp ▲	#37	[12]
Noncitizen share of STEM workers	3.7%	**3.9%**[2024]	+0.1 pp ▲	11%	+0.7 pp ▲	#44	[12]
STEM workers born abroad who arrived in the last 10 years	2.6%	**2.9%**[2024]	+0.3 pp ▲	7.5%	+0.3 pp ▲	#45	[12]
Share of foreign-born STEM workers born in India	15%[2023]	**18%**[2024]	+3.1 pp ▲	28%	+0.8 pp ▲	#24	[12]
Foreign-born share of residents	3.5%	**4.6%**[2025]	+1.1 pp ▲	15%	+1.3 pp ▲	#46	[12]
Foreign-born share of graduate-degree holders, 25+	6.1%	**8.0%**[2025]	+1.9 pp ▲	21%	+2.8 pp ▲	#45	[12]
STEM jobs, employer survey	95.3K	**133K**[2025]	+40% ▲	10.4M	+26% ▲	#25	[10]
STEM jobs concentration vs the U.S., location quotient	0.85	**0.95**[2025]	+0.1 ▲	1.00	0.0	#20	[10]
Mean annual STEM wage, nominal	$83.3K	**$107K**[2025]	+29% ▲	$120K	+38% ▲	#25	[10]
Median software developer wage, nominal	$97.1K[2019]	**$123K**[2025]	+26% ▲	$136K	+26% ▲	#34	[10]
Software developer jobs	9.09K	**17.4K**[2025]	+92% ▲	1.69M	+48% ▲	#24	[10]
Mean annual wage, all occupations, nominal	$41.9K	**$57.5K**[2025]	+37% ▲	$69.8K	+44% ▲	#46	[10]
Patents granted to assignees in the state	285	**278**[2025]	−2.6% ▼	135K	−0.6% ▼	#38	[22]
Share of U.S.-assignee patents	0.2%	**0.2%**[2025]	0.0 pp	–	–	#38	[22]
Share of the state's patents in digital technologies	25%	**16%**[2025]	−8.7 pp ▼	43%	+1.6 pp ▲	#31	[22]
Share of the state's patents in life sciences	15%	**22%**[2025]	+6.3 pp ▲	17%	+0.4 pp ▲	#19	[22]
Share of the state's patents in semiconductors	1.7%	**1.0%**[2025]	−0.7 pp ▼	2.9%	−1.7 pp ▼	#17	[22]
Women's share of inventors on the state's patents	8.7%	**9.1%**[2025]	+0.4 pp ▲	14%	+3.4 pp ▲	#42	[22]

Superscript years mark the year observed; changes since 2015 start from 2015 or the first later year with data. Rank is among the 50 states and DC (1 = highest). "pp" is percentage points. Dollars are 2024 dollars (CPI-U) unless the measure is labeled nominal. Counts and dollars are rounded to three significant figures (K, M, B). Arrow colors show direction only. Source numbers refer to the list of sources that follows the tables.

Sources

[1] Institute of International Education. *Open Doors Report on International Educational Exchange: State Fact Sheets.* Editions 2020–2026. New York: Institute of International Education. https://opendoorsdata.org/. Accessed November 2026.

[2] NAFSA: Association of International Educators. *NAFSA International Student Economic Value Tool*. Academic years 2018–19 to 2024–25. Washington, DC: NAFSA. https://www.nafsa.org/isev. Accessed November 2026.

[3] National Center for Education Statistics. *Digest of Education Statistics*. Editions 1995–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/. Accessed November 2026.

[4] National Center for Education Statistics. *Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System (IPEDS)*. Survey files, 1980–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://nces.ed.gov/ipeds/. Accessed November 2026.

[5] National Center for Education Statistics. *National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP)*. NAEP Data Service, 1990–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education, Institute of Education Sciences. https://www.nationsreportcard.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[6] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Higher Education Research and Development Survey*. Data tables, FY2003–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/higher-education-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[7] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Earned Doctorates*. Data tables, 1994–2025. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/earned-doctorates. Accessed November 2026.

[8] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Federal Funds for Research and Development*. Data tables, FY1985–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/federal-funds-research-development. Accessed November 2026.

[9] National Center for Science and Engineering Statistics. *Survey of Graduate Students and Postdoctorates in Science and Engineering*. Data tables, 1994–2024. Alexandria, VA: National Science Foundation. https://ncses.nsf.gov/surveys/graduate-students-postdoctorates-s-e. Accessed November 2026.

[10] U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics. *Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics*. State estimates, 1999–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.bls.gov/oes/. Accessed November 2026.

[11] U.S. Census Bureau, Center for Economic Studies. *Post-Secondary Employment Outcomes (PSEO)*. Release R2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://lehd.ces.census.gov/data/pseo_experimental.html. Accessed November 2026.

[12] U.S. Census Bureau. *American Community Survey*. 1-year estimates and Public Use Microdata Sample, 2010–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Commerce. https://data.census.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[13] U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services. *H-1B Employer Data Hub*. Fiscal years 2009–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.uscis.gov/tools/reports-and-studies/h-1b-employer-data-hub. Accessed November 2026.

[14] U.S. Department of Education, Office for Civil Rights. *Civil Rights Data Collection*. School years 1980–81 to 2023–24. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://civilrightsdata.ed.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[15] U.S. Department of Education. *College Scorecard*. Institution and field-of-study data, 1996–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Education. https://collegescorecard.ed.gov/data/. Accessed November 2026.

[16] U.S. Department of Homeland Security, Office of Homeland Security Statistics. *Yearbook of Immigration Statistics*. Fiscal years 1996–2024. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://ohss.dhs.gov/topics/immigration/yearbook. Accessed November 2026.

[17] U.S. Department of Labor, Employment and Training Administration, Office of Foreign Labor Certification. *LCA and PERM Disclosure Data*. Fiscal years 2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Labor. https://www.dol.gov/agencies/eta/foreign-labor/performance. Accessed November 2026.

[18] U.S. Department of State, Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs. *BridgeUSA: Exchange Visitor Program Participants by State*. 2015–2025. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of State. https://j1visa.state.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[19] U.S. Department of the Treasury, Bureau of the Fiscal Service. *USAspending.gov*. Award data, FY2008–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of the Treasury. https://www.usaspending.gov/. Accessed November 2026.

[20] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Student and Exchange Visitor Program. *SEVIS by the Numbers: Data Mapping Tool*. Monthly data, 2014–2026. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://studyinthestates.dhs.gov/sevis-data-mapping-tool. Accessed November 2026.

[21] U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement. *Student and Exchange Visitor Information System (SEVIS) Data*. Freedom of Information Act releases, 2008–2016. Washington, DC: U.S. Department of Homeland Security. https://www.ice.gov/foia/library. Accessed November 2026.

[22] U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. *PatentsView*. Annualized patent data, grant years 1976–2025. Alexandria, VA: U.S. Patent and Trademark Office. https://patentsview.org/. Accessed November 2026.